

Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not “the ten greetings” — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, “*may God give you good days.*” We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Spanish out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

1.1 hola — hello

The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there’s already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you’ll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- **vowel-o**, **vowel-a** — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.

This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*’s origin is **not settled**. It’s an old interjection — a hailing call — and that’s about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You’ll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* (“by God”), or to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.

In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**. English *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail*, *holler*, *hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish

and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the “hi” you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.

Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola” — *OH-la*, silent h
- “¡hola!” to an imagined friend — light, informal

Before you move on

Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 bien — “well,” a whole answer in one word

You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers “how are you,” it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

What to know first

- *hola* — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you'll need

- **diphthong-ie** — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- **v-b** — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — “well.” Root: Latin **bene** (“well”). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **benefit** — literally “to do **well**” (*bene* + *facere*).
- **benevolent** — “wishing **well**” (*bene* + *volens*).
- **benediction** — “speaking **well**,” a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **benefactor**, **beneficial**, **benign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene*- family you’ve owned in English your whole life.

Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- “¿Cómo estás?” (how are you?) → “**Bien.**” — “Well.” / “I’m good.” Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → “**Bien.**” — “Okay / fine.”

The adjective sibling: *bueno* / *buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done (“you speak *well*”). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as “good” — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** (“good”), *bene*’s sibling: Latin split the idea of “good” into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

English does the exact same split: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — “you did *well*” but “a *good* job.” En-

glish’s pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well/good* aren’t blood cousins of *bien/bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well, bueno/buena = good.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bien” as the answer to “how are you”
- “bueno” then “buena” — the adjective, masculine then feminine

Before you move on

Which is the adverb (“well”) and which is the adjective (“good”)? (*bien* / *bueno–buena*.) And name an English *bene-* cousin of *bien*. (benefit, benevolent, benediction...)

1.3 el and la — “the,” and the gender it carries

Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la*. Both mean “the.” Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

What to know first

- *bien* / *bueno* — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-e, vowel-a — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — “the” (masculine). **la** — “the” (feminine). English has one word, “the”; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.

Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant “**that one (over there)**”:

- **el** ← Latin **ille** (“that one,” masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** (“that one,” feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i*- dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la*. What began as “that one” softened into a plain “the.” The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance “the” is eroded Latin “that.”

The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** (“he”) and **ella** (“she”). So the article *el* (“the”) and the pronoun *él* (“he”) are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English “the,” by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you’ve built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark “the.” Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns “he” and “she.” The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el” then “la” — the two “the”s
- which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?

Before you move on

Which form is labelled masculine? (*el*.) Which is labelled feminine? (*la*.) Both come from Latin words meaning what? (“That one” — *ille / illa*.)

1.4 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

You know that *el* and *la* both mean “the.” Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

What to know first

- *el / la* — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.

Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, “kind” or “class.”

You cannot always predict a noun’s class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el + noun* or *la + noun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the article for a noun labelled masculine
- the article for a noun labelled feminine
- what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people

Before you move on

How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.5 día — your first noun

You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el / la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, “day.”

What to know first

- *el / la* — grammatical gender and the two “the”s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you'll need

- **accent-i** — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- **d-soft** — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — “the day.” Root: Latin **dies** (“day”). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **diary**, **diurnal** (“of the day”).
- **journal**, **journey** — French *jour*, “a day” (a *journey* was once “a day’s travel”).
- **quotidian** (“every-day”), **meridian** (“mid-day”), and *dismal* (*dies mali*, “evil days”).

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here’s how *día* wears it. **Gender.** *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited that gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it’s the first of several “*-a*-but-masculine” nouns you’ll meet.)

Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* (“days”). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn’t a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* (“good”) into *buenos* precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” — with its masculine “the”
- “días” — plural, vowel + -s
- is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the -a)

Before you move on

Which “the” goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the -a ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + -s.)

1.6 buenos días — assembled from two words you already have

Now watch two lessons snap together. You have *bueno* (“good,” from the *bien* lesson) and *días* (“days,” from the *día* lesson). Put them side by side and you build the greeting everyone knows — and, for the first time, you’ll know *why it’s shaped the way it is*.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno*.
- día — the noun *días*, and that it’s masculine.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- accent-i — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días = **bueno** (“good”) + **días** (“days”) = literally “**good days**.”

But look closely: it’s *buenos*, not *bueno*. Why? Because of the one new grammar rule of this lesson.

Grammar Lens: agreement

An adjective in Spanish **agrees** with its noun — it copies the noun’s gender and number. *días* is **masculine** (the *día* lesson’s flagged exception) and **plural** (the *-s* rule from the *día* lesson). So *bueno* has to become **masculine plural** to match: *bueno* → *buenos*.

The adjective *bueno* has four shapes, and you now understand the machine that picks between them:

- **bueno** — masculine singular (*un buen día* → a good day)
- **buena** — feminine singular
- **buenos** — masculine plural → *buenos días*
- **buenas** — feminine plural (you’ll want this one the moment we reach *tardes* and *noches*, which are feminine)

English adjectives never do this — “good” is “good” whether it’s one day or a hundred. Spanish makes the adjective echo the noun. That echo is *why* it’s *buenos días* and not *bueno días*.

Why it’s said this way

So why “good **days**,” plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: “**Buenos días os dé Dios,**” “*may God give you good days.*” You weren’t wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it’s why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *benediction* (the *bien* lesson’s word). (*A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- build it slowly — “bueno” ... “días” ... “buenos días”
- “hola, buenos días” — casual + warm, stacked
- why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)

Before you move on

Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? (“May God give you good days.”)

1.7 Practice — hola and buenos días

End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they’re automatic.

What you’ve built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual “hi.”
- **bien** — “well/good,” a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno** / **buena**.
- **día** → **días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + -s).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Your turn

Say each out loud; don’t just read.

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually — *hola*
- greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*
- stack them — *hola, buenos días*
- answer “how are you” with one word — *bien*
- the four shapes of “good” — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?

Twice through: Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the “why” feels obvious, not memorized.

Before you move on

You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That’s the whole next chapter, and it’s where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

2.1 tarde — “afternoon,” and the “late” hiding inside it

You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it’s secretly a word you already know from English.

What to know first

- *buenos días* — you’ll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you’ll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — “afternoon.” Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant “**slow, late.**” And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tardy** — late.
- **retard** — to slow down (literally “to make late”).
- **tardigrade** — “slow-stepper,” the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did “late” become “afternoon”? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word

for “late” and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you’re calling it “the late hours.”

Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el/la*, because gender isn’t reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tarde” — *TAR-de*
- “tarde” then English “tardy” — hear the shared root
- “tardes” — plural, add *-s* (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before “afternoon”? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + *-s*.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Same move as *buenos días*: take “good” and “afternoon” and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buenas*, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tardes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** (“good”) + **tardes** (“afternoons”) = literally “good afternoons.”

Grammar Lens: agreement, the feminine case

Back in *buenos días*, *bueno* became *buenos* — **masculine** plural, because *día* is masculine. Now: **tarde is a feminine noun** (*la tarde*). So *bueno* has to become **feminine** plural to match — *buenas*. Same rule, other gender:

- *días* (masculine, plural) → *buen**os** días*
- *tardes* (feminine, plural) → *buen**as** tardes*

That single vowel — the *o* vs. *a* at the end of *buenos/buenas* — is the adjective reporting the gender of the noun it’s attached to. You now control all four shapes in the wild: *bueno*, *buena*, *buenos*, *buenas*.

Why it’s said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for “*Buenas tardes os dé Dios*.” One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it’s genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there’s no fixed “12:00 = afternoon” line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas tardes” — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*
- “buenos días” then “buenas tardes” — hear the *o* flip to *a*
- why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)

Before you move on

Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — “night,” and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting. *noche* — “night” — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

What to know first

- *tarde* — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — “night / evening.” Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **nocturnal** — active at night.
- **nocturne** — a piece of night-music.
- **equinox** — *equi* (“equal”) + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* (“done”), *lactem* → *leche* (“milk”), *octo* → *ocho* (“eight”). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “noche” — *NO-cheh*
- “noche” then “nocturnal” then “equinox”

- “noches” — plural, vowel + -s

Before you move on

What English word is *equi-* + *noche*’s root? (*Equinox*, “equal night.”)
And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don’t: it works both coming and going.

What to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** (“good”) + **noches** (“nights”). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you’re now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes/noches* → *buenas*.

Why it’s said this way

The same amputated blessing (“*Buenas noches os dé Dios*”) — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* (“good evening”).
- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* (“goodnight”).

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn’t care which way you’re going — you’re wishing good hours either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas noches” arriving somewhere
- “buenas noches” leaving somewhere
- all four times of day — “buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches” — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why

Before you move on

What’s unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 Practice — the four greetings

You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let’s make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you’ve built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).
- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The “good” word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That’s why it’s *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* and *buenas noches*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet for the actual current time of day, correctly
- all three “buenos/buenas” greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits

- “hola, buenas tardes” — casual + timed, stacked

Twice through: Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Before you move on

Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Introducing Yourself

3.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — “me / myself.” Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, “I”). Here’s the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, “me”). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola/hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I*, *you*, *he*, *me*, *it*. *me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on (“call *me*”, “give *me*”). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you’ll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally “myself I-call.” For now, just hold *me* =

“me / myself.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me” — *meh*
- “me” then English “me”, “my”, “mine” — all one family

Before you move on

Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola/hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

3.2 llamo — “I call,” from a root that shouts

The verb inside “my name is.” On its own it means “to call” — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

What to know first

- me — you’ll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you’ll need

- 11-y — ll sounds like English y: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — “I call.” The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, “to call.” Root: Latin **clamare**, “to cry out, to shout.” That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- **exclaim**, **exclamation** — *ex-* (“out”) + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- **proclaim**, **proclamation** — *pro-* (“forth”): to call **forth**.
- **acclaim** — *ad-* (“toward”): to shout praise toward.

- **claim**, **reclaim**, **disclaim**; and **clamor**, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* (“key”), *flamma* → *llama* (“flame”), *plovere* → *llover* (“to rain”). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “llamo” — *YA-mo*
- “llamo” then “exclaim”, “proclaim”, “clamor” — the shouting root
- “llamar” (to call), “llave” (key) — both from Latin *cl-*

Before you move on

What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

3.3 me llamo — “I call myself”

Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn’t say “my name is” at all.

What to know first

- *me* · *llamo*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** (“myself”) + **llamo** (“I call”) = literally “**I call myself.**” Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — “I call myself Susan.”

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* (“myself”). *llamo* alone is “I call [someone else]”; *me llamo* is “I call **myself**.” English can do this (“I call myself Sam”) but usually doesn’t bother, flattening it to “my name is.” Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.

This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me llamo* (I call myself) → *te llamas* (you-informal call yourself) → *se llama* (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You’ll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* (“my name is”) but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It’s subtly more active, and it’s the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” + your own name
- “hola, me llamo ____” — greeting + introduction
- what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?

Before you move on

Literally, what is *me llamo*? (“I call myself.”) What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

3.4 tú and usted — two words for “you”

English has one word for “you.” Spanish has two. Today you get both words and what each one is for. What the choice *means* socially — and the odd grammar *usted* drags along with it — comes in the next lesson.

The two words

tú — “you,” **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you are on easy terms with.

Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate “you” (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — “you,” **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you are showing respect or keeping distance with.

Both are **subject pronouns** — the “doer” word, like *yo* (“I”). Say them enough times that they come out without hunting: *tú*, one syllable with the accent; *usted*, stress on the second, with a very soft final *d*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tú” — for a close friend
- “usted” — for someone you’d address respectfully
- “tú” then English “thou” — the retired twin

Before you move on

Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*Usted*.) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*, and what happened to it? (*Thou* — it faded out of English around 400 years ago.) Next: what picking one of them tells your listener.

3.5 tú *or* usted — a choice you have to make every time

You have both words. Now the hard part: Spanish makes you **choose** one every time you speak to someone, and the choice is never neutral.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the two words themselves.

Why it's said this way

Tú and *usted* do not differ in **meaning** — both are “you,” singular, one person. They differ in **register**: the social distance you are claiming.

you say	you are signalling
tú	closeness, equality, ease
usted	respect, deference, distance

English used to carry this too, with *thou* against *you* — and when *thou* died, English lost the ability to say it at all. One-size-fits-all “you” means an English speaker never has to decide. A Spanish speaker decides every single time, and getting it wrong is not a grammar mistake but a **social** one: *tú* to a stranger can read as presumptuous, *usted* to a friend as cold.

The safe default when you cannot tell: **usted**. Over-formal is recoverable; over-familiar is awkward.

Grammar Lens: *usted* takes he/she forms

One structural surprise, because it shapes every lesson after this: ***usted* takes the *he/she* verb forms, not the informal “you” forms.**

That is why “what’s your name?” formally is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — using the *se llama* you would otherwise use for “he calls himself” — and not *te llamas*. Grammatically, *usted* behaves as though you were talking **about** the person rather than **to** them. That is a fossil of where the word came from, and the next lesson digs it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” and name someone you would use it with
- “*usted*” and name someone you would use it with
- which verb pattern *usted* takes — the he/she one

Before you move on

Do *tú* and *usted* differ in meaning or in register? (**Register** — both mean “you”; they signal closeness versus respect.) Which do you pick when unsure? (**Usted.**) Which verb forms does *usted* take? (The same forms used with **he** or **she**.)

3.6 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

You use *usted* for respectful “you,” and it takes the same verb form as “he” or “she.” That surprising grammar preserves the word’s history.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, “your grace” or “your mercy.” *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, “your.” *Merced* comes from Latin *merces*, *mercedem*, “wages, reward, favor.”

The *merc-* root links **mercy**, **mercenary**, **commerce**, **merchant**, and **merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two words compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it’s said this way

A title like “your grace” refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means “you.” The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-word title that became *usted*
- “usted” followed by “mercy” and “merchant” — the *merc-* family

- which verb pattern *usted* takes

Before you move on

What did *vuestra merced* mean? (“Your grace” or “your mercy.”)
 Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.)

3.7 cómo — “how,” your first question word

To ask someone’s name or how they are, you need this word first.
Cómo — “how” — and hiding inside it is a little Latin word for
 “manner” that you already own a dozen English versions of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — “how.” Root: Latin **quo modo** — not a word but a **two-word phrase**, “in what **manner**.”

The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* (“manner, measure”) → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, **commodity**.
- *quo* (“in what”) is the Latin question-stem **qu-**, the seed of nearly every Spanish question word.

How the phrase became one word — the wearing-down. Spanish did not borrow *cómo* ready-made; it **eroded** out of *quo modo* over centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k*, written *c* before *o*. What is left is a whole Latin phrase worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cómo” — *CÓ-mo*, stress on the first syllable
- “cómo” then English “mode”, “model” — the *modo* root
- the erosion — “quo modo, quomo, como”

Before you move on

What does *cómo* mean? (“How.”) Walk the erosion: *quo modo* → ? → *cómo*. (*Quomo* → *como*.) What did the two Latin halves mean? (*Quo*, “in what”; *modo*, “manner” — the root of English *mode* and *model*.) Next: the two marks Spanish puts on a question.

3.8 ¿cómo? — the two marks that say “this is a question”

You have the word *cómo*. Written down, it wears **two** marks that English has no equivalent for — and neither of them is decoration. Both do a job English leaves to word order and guesswork.

What to know first

- *cómo* — the word itself, and where it came from.

Script — the upside-down opener

Spanish questions open with an upside-down ¿ and close with a normal ?:
¿cómo?

Why? Spanish word order often does not change in a question — *cómo estás* looks the same whether you are asking or reporting. A reader coming to a long sentence would not know to raise their pitch until they hit the mark at the very end, by which time it is too late. The ¿ is a piece of engineering: it tells your voice, in advance, what shape the sentence has. Only the **question part** gets bracketed, not necessarily the whole line.

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Now watch the accent mark do real work:

written	means
cómo	“how?” — the question word
como	“like / as” — or “I eat”

Same letters, same sound. The written accent is the **only** thing marking the difference:

- ¿**Cómo** estás? — “**How** are you?”
- **Como** tú. — “Like you.” / Yo **como**. — “I eat.”

Every question word you will meet — *qué, dónde, cuándo, quién* — carries this accent for exactly this reason. It is not about stress (the stress is the same either way); it is a flag that says “**asking.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿cómo?” — with question intonation, opening high
- the pair — “cómo” (how?) then “como” (like / I eat)

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Word order often does not change, so the reader needs the warning **before** the sentence, not after.) What changes when the accent disappears from *cómo*? (It stops being the question word — *como* means “like / as,” or “I eat.”)

3.9 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

What to know first

- *cómo* — “how,” from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

Spanish clue	← Latin	future meaning
<i>qué</i>	<i>quid</i>	what
<i>quién</i>	<i>quem</i>	who
<i>cuál</i>	<i>qualis</i>	which
<i>cuándo</i>	<i>quando</i>	when
<i>cuánto</i>	<i>quantus</i>	how much
cómo	<i>quomodo</i>	how

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, “where,” is an exception from Latin *de unde*, “from where.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Latin source of *cómo*
- the recurring Latin question stem
- whether the table is today’s production list or a preview

Before you move on

Which old stem connects *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*, and *cómo*? (*qu-*)
Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde*.)

3.10 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

You can say *me llamo* (“I call myself”). To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama*.

What to know first

- *me llamo* — the reflexive “I call myself.”
- *tú / usted* — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** (“himself / herself / yourself-formal”) + **llama** (“calls”). So *se llama* = “he/she calls himself,” or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — “**you** (formal) call yourself.”

se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin **sē** (“himself, herself, itself”). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of “self / apart / aside” — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **secede** — *se* + *cedere* (“go apart”).
- **seclude**, **segregate** (“apart from the flock”), **separate**.
- **seduce** — *se* + *ducere* (“lead aside”).
- **secure** — *se* + *cura* (“free from care”), **secret** (“set apart”).

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you* (*informal*, *tú*) call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you* (*formal*, *usted*) calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal “what’s your name?” is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — *usted*, born from “your grace,” politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “se llama” — *seh YA-ma*
- the set — “me llamo, te llamas, se llama”
- “se” then “secede”, “seclude”, “separate” — the set-apart root

Before you move on

Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What’s the “self/apart” root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

3.11 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

What to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* (“how”) + *se llama* (“do you-formal call yourself”) + *usted* (“you,” formal).

Literally: “**How do you call yourself?**” Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you’re asking by what name a person goes, the manner they’re called.

The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú/usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo** _____.

— ¿Cómo se llama usted? — **Me llamo David.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*
- ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*
- the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo* _____

Before you move on

Formal vs. informal “what’s your name”? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask “what” or “how” is your name? (“How” — *cómo*.)

3.12 mucho — “much,” and a sound-change you’ve already seen

One more word before “pleased to meet you.” *mucho* — “much, a lot” — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — “much, a lot.” Root: Latin **multus** (“much, many”). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **multiple**, **multitude**, **multiply**, **multi-purpose**, **multimedia**.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of

melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*nocturnal*, *multiple*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mucho” — *MOO-cho*
- “mucho” then “multiple”, “multitude” — the *mult-* family
- “noche” and “mucho” — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster

Before you move on

mucho comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (multiple, multitude, multiply.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

3.13 gusto → mucho gusto — “much pleasure”

The line you say when you shake someone’s hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you’ve got it.

What to know first

- mucho — “much,” about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — “taste; pleasure, liking.” Root: Latin **gustus** (“a tasting, a taste”). The English cousins:

- **gustatory** — to do with the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* (“not, opposite”) + *gust*: literally “**distaste**.”
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one’s from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn’t proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* (“much”) + *gusto* (“pleasure”) = literally “**much pleasure**” — short for “it’s a great pleasure [to meet you].” *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you’ve been building.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — “much pleasure” — where English names the *person* (“pleased to meet **you**”). The phrase works by itself, so this first exchange needs no extra reply formula.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gusto” then “gusto” (English), “disgust”, “gustatory”
- “mucho gusto” — on meeting someone

Before you move on

What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? (“Much pleasure.”) Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — “distaste.”)

3.14 Practice — introducing yourself

Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

- Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
- Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.**

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they’re the ones that carry the whole social difference:

- ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you’ve built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself (“I call myself”).
- **tú / usted** — the informal vs. formal “you,” and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from “your grace”).
- **¿cómo te llamas? / ¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te / se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure,” pleased to meet you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both parts
- the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*
- for a police officer, then your best friend — which “you” for each, and why?

Twice through: Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Before you move on

Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter, you will learn how to ask how someone is doing.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

4.1 gracias — “thank you,” and a whole family of English words

You can now introduce yourself. The next exchange is *how are you?* — but every answer ends the same polite way, so we learn the courtesy word first: **gracias**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-a** — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.
- **r-tap** — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.
- **ci-th-s** — the *ci* is a soft *s* in Latin America (**GRAH-syahs**) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (**GRAH-thyahs**). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of **gracia** (“grace, favour”), from Latin **grātia** — *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone “graces,” i.e. good will in return for theirs.

That one Latin root **grātia** fans out across English — once you see it, you get a fistful of words for free:

- **grace, gracious, graceful** — the direct borrowings.
- **grateful, gratitude** — being *full of* grātia.

- **gratis, gratuity** — something given as a *favour* (for free, or a tip).
- **congratulate** — literally “to wish grace *together with* someone.”
- Italian **grazie**, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças* — the whole Romance family kept *grātia*, even where everyday thanks went elsewhere (French says *merci*, Portuguese *obrigado*).

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” — *GRAH-syahs*, one soft tap on the *r*
- “gracias” then English “grace, grateful, gratitude” — one family

Before you move on

What everyday English word is *gracias* the plural of, at the root? (*Grace*.) So when you thank someone in Spanish, you are literally handing them — what? (Graces / favours.) Next: the little reply that closes the exchange, **de nada**.

4.2 de nada — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

Someone says **gracias**. You need the reply that closes the loop: **de nada** — literally “*of nothing*.” You’re waving the favour off as no trouble at all — the same move English makes with “*it’s nothing*” / “*no problem*.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (**NAH-thah**), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.

- vowel-a — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = “of / from” (Latin **dē**) — the same *de* hiding in English **depart**, **deduct**, **descend**.
- **nada** = “nothing.” And this is the beautiful part.

nada comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta** — “(a thing) *born*.” From *nāscī*, “to be born,” the same root as English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, **re-nais-sance** (re-birth). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, “there is not a born thing” — *not a single thing that ever came into being* — and over centuries the emphatic *nāta* (“born thing”) wore down until **the word for ‘born thing’ became the word for ‘nothing’ itself**.

So the reply *de nada* literally says “**of [a] born-thing**” → “of nothing at all.” French did the identical trick with **rien** (“nothing”) — which is Latin **rem**, “a thing.” Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy pair

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues *thank you* → *you’re welcome*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” ... “de nada” — the full exchange, both voices
- “de nada” then English “native, nature, natal” — nada’s true family

Before you move on

nada (“nothing”) started life as the Latin word for a *born* — what? (A *thing* — *rēs nāta*, a born thing.) What English words share that “born” root? (Native, nature, natal, renaissance.) Next: the verb the whole “how are you?” question turns on — **estar**.

4.3 *estar* — “to be,” the *standing* kind

To ask *how are you?* Spanish needs a verb for **being**. Today just the verb itself and where it came from; how to use it, and its two forms, come next.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stāre* grew to become *estar*.)
- **r-tap** — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar comes straight from Latin **stāre**, “to stand.” Hold onto that picture: it is the whole reason this verb behaves the way it does. How you are **standing** at this moment — well, tired, here, there — is a snapshot, not a permanent fact.

That root **stā-/sta-** is one of the most productive in English. *Estar* hands you a large family for free:

- **stay, stand, stance, station, stable, stationary** — to stand or stay put.
- **state, status, statue, estate** — a way of *standing* (your state is how you stand).
- **constant, circumstance, substance** — “standing with / around / under.”

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, “**how are you standing?**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*estar*” — *es-TAR*, with the little propping *e*
- “*estar*” then English “stay, state, status, stable” — all *standing*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is *estar* — “to be” or “to stand”? (To **stand** — *stāre*.) Why does Spanish put an *e* on the front? (It never begins a word with bare *st-*.) Name two English cousins. (*Stay, state, status, stable, estate...*) Next: the two forms you will actually ask with.

4.4 estás / está — the two forms, and what they are for

Estar is “to stand.” Now put it to work. Two forms, one job: saying how somebody is **right now**.

What to know first

- *estar* — the verb and its Latin “to stand” root.
- *tú* or *usted* — why *usted* takes he/she forms.

Grammar Lens: state and location use *estar*

Use **estar** for a **current state** or a **location** — the two things that can change without changing what something *is*:

- a state: *estoy bien* — “I’m well” (today; maybe not tomorrow).
- a location: *está aquí* — “it’s here” (for now).

“How are you?” asks about a current state, so it takes *estar*. Spanish has a second be-verb for identity, and it arrives in its own later lesson; keeping it out of today’s drill lets one contrast settle at a time.

Grammar Lens: the two forms you need

you’re addressing	form	reads as
tú (informal)	estás	“you are”
usted (formal)	está	“you are”

Notice that **está** is also “he is / she is.” That is not a coincidence and not something extra to learn — it is the *usted*-takes-he/she-forms rule you already met, showing up for the first time in a real verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estás” ... “está” — the two forms you’ll ask with
- which one goes with *tú*, which with *usted*
- a state, then a location — “estás bien”, “está aquí”

Before you move on

What two kinds of thing does *estar* cover? (**Current state** and **location**.) Which form goes with *tú*, and which with *usted*? (*Estás*; *está*.) Why is *está* also “he/she is”? (Because *usted* takes the **he/she** verb forms.) Next lesson, you finally ask it: **¿cómo está usted?**

4.5 ¿cómo está usted? — “how are you?”

Everything you’ve built this chapter now snaps together into one question. You already met **cómo** (“how”) and the **tú / usted** choice back in Chapter 3; you just learned **estar**. Assemble them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo está usted? = “How are you?” (formal) literally:
“In what manner are you standing?”

- **cómo** = “how / in what manner”
- **está** = “you are” (the *usted*/he-she form of **estar** — state, not identity)
- **usted** = the formal “you”

Note the **¿** — Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming before you start reading aloud. (We take that mark apart in a dedicated writing lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — formal, for a stranger
- the pieces — “cómo + está + usted”

Before you move on

Which be-verb does “how are you?” use — *ser* or *estar*, and why? (*estar* — it’s about your current state.) What changes between formal and informal? (**The next step changes the ending and pronoun.**) Next: choosing the register.

4.6 ¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

You can already ask a stranger **¿Cómo está usted?** Now change only the relationship: ask the same question of a friend.

Grammar Lens: one question, two relationships

register	question
formal (stranger, elder, customer)	¿Cómo está usted?
informal (friend, peer, child)	¿Cómo estás?
The formal version uses the third-person ending está plus usted . The informal version uses second-person estás and normally omits tú . This is the same relationship contrast you drilled with se llama / te llamas .	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a doctor you just met — “¿Cómo está usted?”
- to your cousin — “¿Cómo estás?”
- swap back and forth — “está usted / estás”

Twice through: Ask both versions until the ending swap is automatic.

Before you move on

Which version fits a stranger? (¿**Cómo** **está** usted?) Which fits a friend? (¿**Cómo** **estás**?) What two things change? (**The verb ending and the pronoun.**)

4.7 regular / más o menos — the honest “so-so”

You asked *¿cómo estás?* Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. You already have **bien** (“well,” Chapter 1). Today, the *middling* answers — because nobody is *bien* every day.

What to know first

Recall from Chapter 1: **bien** — “well.” Root? (Latin *bene*, “well” — same as *benefit*, *benevolent*.) So *estoy bien* = “I’m well.” Now the answer for when you’re *not* quite bien.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular — as an answer to “how are you?”, it means “**so-so, average, not great.**” (A famous false-friend trap: it does **not** mean English “regular / normal / usual” here.) From Latin *rēgula*, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is “on the rule, on the average line” → middling.

That *rēgula* rod is everywhere in English: **rule, ruler, regulate, regular, regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.

más o menos — “more or less,” the shrug-answer:

- **más** = “more,” from Latin **magis** (“more”) — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*.
- **menos** = “less,” from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *más o menos* is literally “**more or less**” — the exact phrase, root for root, that English uses for the same shrug.

Grammar Lens: a small answer set

You now have a scale to answer *¿cómo estás?*:

answer	sense
(muy) bien	(very) well
regular	so-so
más o menos	more or less / meh

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “regular” — *reh-goo-LAR*, soft tap on both *r*’s
- “más o menos” — a little shrug in the voice
- answer “¿cómo estás?” three ways — bien / regular / más o menos

Before you move on

As an answer, does *regular* mean “normal” or “so-so”? (So-so — the false-friend trap.) What straight-rod Latin word is it from, and what English “rod” words share it? (*rēgula* → rule, ruler, regulate, rail.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

4.8 y / ¿y tú? — pass the question back

You can ask how someone is and answer. One tiny connector turns that exchange around so the other person gets a turn too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Y means **and** and sounds like Spanish **i**: *ee*. It continues Latin **et**, also “and.” English borrowed that Latin word intact inside **et cetera**, literally “and the rest.”

Grammar Lens: the shortest return question

Put **y** before a person you already know:

- **¿Y tú?** — And you? (*informal*)

- ¿Y usted? — And you? (*formal*)

Nothing else needs repeating. The little question hands the previous topic back to the other person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Bien. ¿Y tú?” to a friend
- “Regular. ¿Y usted?” to a stranger
- “y” — one clear *ee* sound

Before you move on

What does **y** mean? (**And.**) How do you hand a question back to a friend? (¿Y tú?) To a stranger? (¿Y usted?) Which Latin word survives inside English **et cetera**? (**Et**, “and.”)

4.9 á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does

You’ve been reading accented words since your very first noun — **día**, **cómo**, **está**, **más**. Time to make that little stroke make sense. Spanish uses one mark to write exceptional stress — the *acute* accent, ´, leaning right — and it does two jobs in the words you know. Learn the stress job now; the next lesson adds its grammar-label job.

Script — shape and stroke

A short stroke rising **left-to-right**, sitting on top of a vowel: **á é í ó ú**. (On the *í*, it replaces the dot.) One clean up-stroke — the opposite lean from the French *grave* accent â. Spanish never uses grave or circumflex; if it leans the wrong way, it isn’t Spanish.

Grammar Lens: the mark records exceptional stress

Spanish stress is regular, so most words need **no** mark. The default:

- word ends in a **vowel, -n, or -s** → stress the **second-to-last** syllable (*ho-la*, *lla-mo*, *gus-to*).
- word ends in **any other consonant** → stress the **last** syllable (*us-ted*, *re-gu-lar*, *es-tar*).

The accent appears **only when a word breaks that rule** — it marks the exception. *está* ends in a vowel, so the rule wants *ES-ta*; the accent overrides it to *es-TÁ*. *cómo* ends in a vowel (rule wants *co-MO*) but is stressed *CÓ-mo*, so it gets the mark. The accent is a **spoken stress you can see** — it never changes the vowel’s sound, only which syllable you hit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola, llamo, gusto” — second-to-last stress
- “usted, regular, estar” — final stress
- “está, cómo” — the accent overrides the default

Before you move on

How many accent marks does Spanish have, and which way does it lean? (One — the acute, ´, rising left-to-right.) Its two jobs? (Mark irregular stress; the next step covers its look-alike job.) When does a word ending in a vowel, **-n**, or **-s** need an accent? (**When its stress breaks the second-to-last default.**)

4.10 el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

You know **el** as the article “the.” Add one acute accent and the same two letters do a different job.

Grammar Lens: one mark, two grammatical jobs

The **tilde diacrítica** separates words that otherwise look alike:

no accent

with accent

el = the

él = he

The two words are pronounced alike. Here the accent does not move stress; it labels meaning and grammar. Other pairs will arrive only when you know both words, so this lesson asks you to hold one contrast, not memorize a list.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “el” — the
- *Say it:* “él” — he
- *Write it:* **el** / **él**, adding the meaning-label accent only to the pronoun

Before you move on

What is the accent’s second job? (**Separate look-alike words.**) Which means “the”? (**El**, no accent.) Which means “he”? (**Él**, with the accent.) Does this mark change their stress? (**No — it labels the job.**)

4.11 ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

ñ is the one letter English does not have — and it has the best origin story in the alphabet. That wavy hat (~, a *tilde*) is not decoration. It is a **tiny second n, written on top to save space**. Once you know that, you know both how to write it *and* why it sounds as it does.

Sounds you’ll need

ñ = the *ny* in “canyon” or “onion” — one squished sound, tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. English *canyon* is, in fact, Spanish **cañón** with the *ñ* spelled out as *ny*. Say “onion,” freeze on the middle: that is **ñ**.

Script — how to write it

Write a normal **n**, then a small wavy ~ floating above it. Two strokes, one letter.

Careful: ñ is its own letter, not “n with an accent.” *año* (“year”) and *ano* (a rather different word) are completely different words — the tilde is not an optional flourish, it is a distinct letter of the alphabet, with its own slot in the dictionary.

Why it’s said this way

That wave is a **medieval shorthand**. Scribes copying Latin were forever writing double letters, so they saved a stroke: write the letter **once**, and put a little mark above meaning “...and one more of these.” A bar over a vowel meant a dropped *n* or *m* (Latin *tantum* → *tātum*); a wave over an *n* meant **nn**.

Spanish is full of words where a Latin **-nn-** did exactly this:

- Latin **annus** (“year”) → *anno* → **año**. (That same *annus* gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, **bi-ennial**.)
- Latin **canna** (“reed”) → **caña**; Latin *domina* → *donna* → **doña**.

So the tilde on **ñ** is a **frozen abbreviation** — a thousand-year-old note saying “there used to be two *n*’s here.” You are writing a scribe’s shortcut.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año” — *AH-nyo*, one squished *ny*; then English “annual”
- the doubled-n words — “año, caña, doña”

Before you move on

What is the tilde on **ñ**, really? (A tiny second *n* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *nn*.) What Latin word gives *año*, and what English words share it? (*Annus* → annual, anniversary.) Is **ñ** a separate letter or an accented *n*? (A **separate letter**.) Next: the two everyday

words you will be writing it in.

4.12 mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

You can write **ñ** and you can say it. Two of the next words in the course carry it, and both are worth a minute on their own — because neither of them got its *ñ* from a doubled *n*.

What to know first

- *ñ* — the letter, the sound, and the scribe’s shorthand.

Script — the two forms

- **mañana** — “tomorrow,” and also “morning.” *ma-NYA-na*: the *ñ* is in the **middle**, and it is the stressed syllable.
- **español** — “Spanish.” *es-pa-NYOL*: the *ñ* is at the **end**, right before the *-ol*.

Now the honest footnote. The scribe’s doubled *nn* is **one** road to *ñ*, the one you met with *año*. These two words took a **different** road: Latin’s **-ni-** before a vowel. *Mañana* traces back through *maneana* to **māne** (“morning” — the root of English **matinée**); *español* comes from **Hispaniolus**, built on **Hispania**. In both, a *ni* sequence squeezed together into the same single palatal sound.

So *ñ* is where **two** separate Latin sequences ended up — *-nn-* and *-ni-*. One letter, one sound, two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año, mañana, español” — the *ñ* in three positions
- the two roads — “año, from *-nn-*” then “mañana, from *-ni-*”

Before you move on

Where does the ñ sit in *mañana*, and where in *español*? (Middle; end.) Did those two get their ñ from a doubled *n*? (**No** — from Latin **-ni-** before a vowel, a second road to the same letter.) What was the first road? (**-nn-**, the scribe’s shorthand, as in *año*.)

4.13 ¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question

You’ve been writing them since *¿cómo está usted?* Spanish is the one major language that puts an **upside-down** question or exclamation mark at the **start** of the sentence, as well as the normal one at the end. It looks exotic; the reason is purely practical.

Script — the two opening marks

- ¿ ... ? wraps a question: *¿Cómo estás?*
- ¡ ... ! wraps an exclamation: *¡Hola! ¡Gracias!*

The opening mark is just the closing mark **flipped 180°** — turned upside down *and* left-right. To write ¿, draw a normal ? and rotate it half a turn: the hook ends up at the bottom, the dot on top.

Why it’s said this way

English lets you read most of a sentence before the final ? reveals it was a question — fine, because English usually flags a question early with word order (“*Are you...*”, “*Do you...*”). Spanish often **doesn’t reorder words**: *Tienes hambre*. (“You’re hungry.”) and *¿Tienes hambre?* (“Are you hungry?”) are the **same words** — only punctuation and the spoken rising tone tell them apart.

So the Spanish Royal Academy, in **1754**, made the opening ¿ official: it warns the reader “*a question is starting — read this with rising intonation from the very first word.*” It’s a **melody cue placed before the melody**, the exact same instinct as the written accent marking stress you can’t otherwise see. For a language read aloud, it’s genuinely useful.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read “¿Cómo estás?” — start the rising *question* melody from the very first word, the way the ¿ tells you to
- “¡Hola!” — the ¡ warns you to begin with exclamation energy

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Because word order often doesn't change, so the reader needs an early warning to use question intonation.) How do you write it? (A normal ? rotated 180°.) Does it always sit at the sentence's start? (**The next step places it around a question inside a larger sentence.**)

4.14 Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

You can open a whole question with ¿. Now place that mark inside a larger sentence, exactly where the questioning voice begins.

Script — bracket the spoken span

The opening mark goes where the **question** begins, even if the sentence started earlier:

Roberto, ¿cómo estás?

The name **Roberto** is outside the question. The marks bracket the words that need question intonation. The same principle works for an exclamation:

Roberto, ¡buenos días!

This is why the opening mark is more than decoration. It tells the reader exactly where to begin and end a change in spoken melody.

Your turn

- *Write it:* “María, ¿cómo estás?”
- *Write it:* “María, ¡buenos días!”
- *Say it:* begin the new melody at *i* or *j*, not at the first capital

Before you move on

In **Roberto, ¿cómo estás?**, is **Roberto** inside the question? (**No.**) Where does the inverted mark go? (**At the start of the question or exclamation span.**) What does that placement tell a reader? (**Where to change the spoken melody.**)

4.15 Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *gracias, de nada, estar, ¿cómo está?, regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, run formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. It picks up right where the Chapter 3 introduction left off.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien, gracias.** *¿Y usted?* — **Más o menos.** — [reply to a thanks, later in the chat] **De nada.**

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb + pronoun change:

— ¡Hola! **¿Cómo estás?** — **Regular.** *¿Y tú?* — Bien, gracias.

The glue pattern you just secured is **¿y usted?** / **¿y tú?** — “and you?” It bounces the question back without repeating the whole sentence.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **gracias** — thank you (← *grātia*, “grace”).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (← “of a born-thing” → “of

nothing”).

- **estar** — the state/location be-verb (← *stāre*, “to stand”).
- **¿cómo está usted?** / **¿cómo estás?** — how are you, formal / informal.
- **bien** / **regular** / **más o menos** — well / so-so / more-or-less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same exchange *informally* — catch *está* → *estás*, *usted* → *tú*
- chain Chapter 3 + 4 — introduce yourself *and* ask how they are: “Me llamo ... ¿Cómo está usted?”

Twice through: Run the formal exchange, greeting to answer, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which be-verb carries “how are you?” and why? (*estar* — current state.) Two words swap between formal and informal — which? (*está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*.) What does *de nada* literally say? (“Of nothing.”) Next chapter: **farewells** — hasta luego, hasta mañana, adiós.

Chapter 5

Farewells

5.1 adiós — “goodbye,” or “to God”

You can greet, introduce yourself, and ask how someone is. Time to leave gracefully. The final, plainest parting is **adiós** — and, like the English *goodbye*, it’s a tiny prayer worn smooth.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**io** — the *-íos* is one glide, *ee-OHS*: *ah-DYOHS*, stress on the end (that’s what the accent on *ó* marks — remember the acute-accent lesson).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós is **a + Dios** — “**to God**.” It’s the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, “I commend you **to God**” — said to someone setting off, when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God’s keeping.

Every Romance sister kept the same farewell-prayer:

language	goodbye	literally
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God” (<i>à Dieu</i>)
Italian	<i>addio</i>	“to God”
Portuguese	<i>adeus</i>	“to God”

And English is doing the **exact same thing** without telling you: **good-bye** is a crushed-down “*God be with ye*.” So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

- **Dios** (“God”) ← Latin **Deus** — the *Deus* of English *deity*, *divine*, *adieu*, and (via Greek *Zeus*, same root) the whole sky-god family.

Grammar Lens: adiós is a *final* goodbye

adiós leans toward a **longer** parting — you won’t see them soon, or it’s the end of the day. For “see you later / tomorrow,” Spanish reaches for **hasta ...**, which the rest of this chapter is about — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “adiós” — *ah-DYOHS*, stress the end
- adiós / adieu / addio / adeus — four “to God” farewells
- English “goodbye” = “God be with ye” — the same prayer

Before you move on

What two words hide inside *adiós*? (*a* + *Dios* — “to God.”) What English goodbye is built the same way? (*Goodbye* ← “God be with ye.”) Is *adiós* for a quick “see you soon”? (No — it’s the longer/final parting; *hasta ...* comes next.) Next: **hasta**, and a word Spain borrowed from Arabic.

5.2 hasta — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries

Spanish says “see you later” as **hasta luego** — literally “**until** later.” So the key word is **hasta**, “until.” And *hasta* carries the single most important fact about Spanish’s history: **for nearly 800 years, much of Spain spoke Arabic.**

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — Spanish **h** is **always silent**: **hasta** = *AHS-tah* (no breath on the *h* at all). Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta comes from Arabic **ḥattā**, “until, up to.” From **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for **centuries**, until 1492. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.

Most of those loans are **nouns**, and you can spot a huge number by the frozen Arabic article **al-** (“the”) fused onto the front:

- **almohada** (pillow), **alcázar** (fortress), **alcalde** (mayor), **alfombra** (rug), **aduana** (customs), **álgebra**, **alcohol**.
- **azúcar** (sugar), **aceite** (oil), **naranja** (orange).

But **hasta** is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never — so an Arabic *preposition* surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rival *ad* “to”/*usque* “up to” simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta” — *AHS-tah*, silent h
- “hasta” then Arabic *ḥattā* — the same word, 1,300 years apart

Before you move on

What language is *hasta* from, and what does it mean? (Arabic *ḥattā* — “until.”) Why is it remarkable that Spanish borrowed it? (It’s a *function word* / preposition — languages almost never borrow those; it shows how deep the Arabic centuries went.) How do you spot many Arabic nouns in Spanish? (The frozen *al-* article: *almohada*, *azúcar*, *álgebra*.)

5.3 **hasta aquí / hasta la noche** — point to the limit

You know **hasta** means “until” or “up to.” Give that small word one spatial endpoint and one temporal endpoint, using only one new word.

Grammar Lens: endpoints in space and time

Aquí means **here**. Put it after **hasta**:

hasta aquí — up to here

For a time endpoint, reuse **la noche**, “the night,” from Chapter 2:

hasta la noche — until the night / until tonight

The same preposition points to a place or the end of a stretch of time. The next lessons will place new time words after it one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**aquí**” — here
- “**hasta aquí**” — up to here
- “**hasta la noche**” — until tonight

Before you move on

What does **hasta** point to? (**An endpoint.**) Give one spatial and one temporal example. (**Hasta aquí; hasta la noche.**) What is the only new lexical item? (**Aquí**, “here.”)

5.4 **hasta luego** — the everyday “see you later”

This is the goodbye you’ll actually use most — friendly, casual, open-ended. **hasta luego**: “until later.” You already own **hasta** (“until”); today you add **luego** (“later”), and it has a very Latin backstory.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **luego** = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, *lweh*-.
 • The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta luego = “until later” → “see you later.”

- **hasta** = “until” (last lesson — Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **luego** = “later / then / soon,” from Latin **loco**, “at the place / at that point.” The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → “then, next, soon.” So its cousins in English are all about **place**: **local**, **locus**, **location**, **locate**, **al-loc-ate**. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

A nice contrast: **hasta luego** fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word in three syllables — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” family

hasta + a time word is Spanish’s whole toolkit of soft goodbyes. You’ll build the other two this chapter:

phrase	“until ...”	when
hasta luego	later	the default “see you”
hasta mañana	tomorrow	leaving for the day
hasta pronto	soon	you expect to meet again shortly

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” — *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*
- “luego” then English “local, location” — the *loco* “place” family
- “¡Adiós! ... no — ¡hasta luego!” — feel the difference: final vs. soon

Before you move on

What does *hasta luego* literally mean? (“Until later.”) What did *luego*’s Latin root *loco* first mean, and what English words keep it? (Place — *local*, *location*, *locus*.) Which two language layers meet in *hasta luego*? (Arabic *hasta* + Latin *luego*.) Next: **hasta mañana**.

5.5 hasta mañana — “see you tomorrow” (and the ñ returns)

Leaving for the day? **hasta mañana** — “until tomorrow.” It brings back a letter you studied in the writing lessons: the ñ. Here it is, living in a word you’ll say every evening.

Sounds you’ll need

- **enye-ny** — **mañana** = *mah-NYAH-nah*: the ñ is the squished *ny* of “canyon” (your ñ writing lesson — the tilde is a tiny second *n*, remember). Three soft *ah*’s: *ma-ÑA-na*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta mañana = “until tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **mañana** = “tomorrow” — **and** “morning.” One word for both, from Latin (**hōra**) **maneana**, “the **early** hour” (from *māne*, “in the morning”). The logic: the next “early hour” you’ll see is *tomorrow morning* → *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**.

The ñ, in the wild. Recall the writing lesson: ñ is a frozen *nn* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *n*. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n+ea* palatalized (softened) into that single ñ sound. So the tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of “tomorrow.”

Grammar Lens: same word, two meanings — context decides

mañana means “morning” **or** “tomorrow”; the sentence tells you which. Paired with *hasta*, it’s always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, “until tomorrow.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mañana” — *mah-NYAH-nah*, squished *ñ*
- “hasta mañana” — until tomorrow
- “mañana” once as “morning,” then once as “tomorrow” — context decides

Before you move on

What two meanings does *mañana* carry? (Morning; tomorrow.) With *hasta*, which one? (Tomorrow.) What sound is the *ñ*, and what is its tilde, historically? (The *ny* of “canyon”; a frozen doubled-*n*.) Next: **hasta pronto**.

5.6 hasta pronto — “see you soon”

The last of the “hasta ...” trio: **hasta pronto**, “until soon” — for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly. One new word, **pronto**, and it’s hiding in plain sight in English.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hasta pronto** = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr*, a pure *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta pronto = “until soon” → “see you soon.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **pronto** = “soon / quickly / ready,” from Latin **promptus**, “brought forth, ready at hand” (from *prōmere*, “to bring out”). Something *prompt* is brought out **without delay** — so *pronto*

slid to “soon.”

You already know its English twin: **prompt** (on time; to bring out a response), plus **prompter**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** (the cursor “ready” for input). Italian borrowed *pronto* too — it’s what Italians say when they pick up the phone (“*Pronto!*” = “Ready!”).

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” trio, complete

You now have Spanish’s three soft goodbyes, sharpest to vaguest in time:

phrase	until...	nuance
hasta pronto	soon	you’ll meet again shortly
hasta luego	later	the neutral default “see you”
hasta mañana	tomorrow	you’re parting for the day

...and **adiós** for the long or final goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta pronto” — *AHS-tah PRON-toh*
- “pronto” then English “prompt, promptly” — one family
- the trio — hasta pronto / hasta luego / hasta mañana

Before you move on

What does *hasta pronto* mean, and *pronto*’s English twin? (“Until soon”; *prompt*.) What Latin word is it from, and its literal sense? (*promptus*, “brought forth / ready.”) Order the three *hasta* goodbyes by time. (pronto → luego → mañana.) Next: put the whole farewell set together.

5.7 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. This chapter’s farewells — *adiós* and the three *hasta ...* goodbyes — now close a real conversation, and fold back into the whole arc you’ve built since *hola*.

Grammar Lens: choosing the right goodbye

The choice is about **when you’ll meet again**:

you’re...	say
parting for good / a long time	Adiós.
expecting to meet again shortly	Hasta pronto.
just “see you” (neutral default)	Hasta luego.
leaving for the day	Hasta mañana.

The exchange — start to finish

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

— ¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted?
 — Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto. — ¿Cómo está usted? — Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted? — Bien. **Hasta mañana**, Luis. — **Hasta mañana**, Ana. ¡**Adiós!**

What you’ve built this chapter

- **adiós** — the plain/final goodbye (“to God”; twin of *goodbye*).
- **hasta** — “until,” Spain’s everyday Arabic word (← *hattā*).
- **hasta luego** / **mañana** / **pronto** — see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full conversation above, both voices — greeting to goodbye
- pick the goodbye — for a friend you’ll see tomorrow? (*hasta mañana*); for someone moving away? (*adiós*)

Twice through: Run the whole exchange, *hola* to *adiós*, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye for someone you won't see for a long time? (*Adiós.*) Which everyday word for “until” did Spanish take from Arabic? (*hasta.*) You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish. Next chapter: **por favor** and **gracias**’ partner courtesies, then into everyday verbs.

Chapter 6

The First Verbs

6.1 café — coffee, and a place to drink it

Before you can make a polite request, you need one small thing to request. **Café** gives you a useful noun and lets the written accent do a job you already understand.

Sounds you'll need

Say **ca-FÉ**. A vowel-final word would normally stress the second-to-last syllable, so the acute accent records the unexpected final stress.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **café** came through Italian **caffè** and Turkish **kahve** from Arabic **qahwah**. English **coffee** reached the same travelling word by a different European route. The drink and the word both crossed languages. **Café** can name the drink or the place, just as English **coffee** and **café** divide those jobs. It is masculine: **el café**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “café” — final stress
- “el café”
- the route — “qahwah → kahve → caffè → café”

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall? (**On the final é.**) Why is the accent written? (**It overrides the usual vowel-final stress.**) What route carried the word into Spanish? (**Arabic qahwah → Turkish kahve → Italian caffè → Spanish café.**)

6.2 por favor — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”

You can already thank (*gracias*) and reply (*de nada*). The third courtesy completes the set: **por favor**, “please” — literally “for [a] favour.” You’re asking someone to do you a kindness.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tapped *r* in *por* and *favor*.
- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* sound **identical** (a soft *b*): *favor* ≈ *fah-BOR*. (So *favor* and English *favour* look alike *and* the *v* even sounds like the *b* you’d hear in “harbour.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **por** = “for / through / by,” from Latin **prō** (“for, on behalf of”) — the same *pro-* in English **pronoun**, **propose**, **protect**.
- **favor** = “a favour, goodwill,” from Latin **favēre**, “to be favourable to, to support.” It’s the very word English borrowed: **favour**, **favorite**, **favorable**, **favouritism**.

So *por favor* literally says “**for a favour**” — [*do this*] as a kindness to me. English **favour**, **favorite**, and **favorable** keep the same Latin family visible without asking you to learn another language’s formula.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy set is complete

You now hold the three pillars of politeness:

- **por favor** — please (asking).
- **gracias** — thank you (receiving).

- **de nada** — you're welcome (replying).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “por favor” — *por fah-BOR*, soft *v/b*
- “Café, por favor” — “Coffee, please”
- “favor” then English “favour, favorite” — one family

Before you move on

What does *por favor* literally mean? (“For a favour.”) What Latin verb is *favor* from, and its English cousins? (*favēre* — favour, favorite, favorable.) Which three-word courtesy loop do you now own? (*Por favor* → *gracias* → *de nada*.) Next: your first regular **verb** — *hablar*, “to speak.”

6.3 hablar — “to speak,” which used to mean “to tell tales”

Fixed phrases got you this far. **Hablar** (“to speak”) is the first verb you will take apart and put back together. Today: the word itself. Next lesson: the pattern it unlocks.

Sounds you'll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **completely silent**: *hablar* = *ah-BLAR*. (Spanish *h* never makes a sound.)
- **v-b** — the *b* is a soft *b*; *hablo* = *AH-bloh*.

That silent *h* is not an accident of spelling. Latin's initial **f**- weakened in a whole set of Spanish words and eventually fell silent altogether, but the scribes kept writing a letter where it used to be — and that letter is **h**. You are looking at the gravestone of an *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar comes from Latin **fābulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story.” So *to speak*, in Spanish, is at root *to tell stories*. Notice Latin had a plainer verb available (*loquī*, “to speak,” which English keeps in **eloquent** and **loquacious**) — and Spanish chose the chattier, more colourful one.

That **fābula** is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** (“story-like”), **con-fabulate**, and **ineffable** (“un-speak-able”).

The single path you need today is **fābulārī** → **hablar**; later words will let you test how broadly that *f*- → *h*- pattern reaches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablar” — *ah-BLAR*, silent *h*
- “hablar” then English “fable, fabulous, ineffable” — the *fābula* root
- the sound law — “fābulārī” then “hablar”

Before you move on

What Latin word is *hablar* from, and what English word shares it? (*Fābulārī* ← *fābula* — **fable**.) What happened to its initial Latin *f*? (It weakened away, leaving the written but **silent** Spanish *h*-.) Next: the ending pattern that turns this one verb into a machine.

6.4 hablo, hablas, habla — one ending swap, three sentences

Hablar is one word. Swap its last two letters and it becomes “I speak,” or a question to a friend, or a polite question to a stranger. This is the biggest single piece of leverage in the course so far.

What to know first

- *hablar* — the verb and its *fābula* root.
- *tú* or *usted* — which forms *usted* takes.

Grammar Lens: the -ar present tense

Hablar belongs to the **-ar** family. To make the three singular forms you need now: **drop the -ar**, then add the ending for the person.

person	ending	<i>hablar</i> →	meaning
I	-o	hablo	I speak
tú (you, informal)	-as	hablas	you speak
usted (you, formal)	-a	habla	you speak

The *usted* row is the same *he/she* form you were warned about back in Chapter 3 — it turns up here for real. **This same template fits every regular -ar verb**, so learning it once buys you every *-ar* verb you will ever meet.

Grammar Lens: pro-drop

Look at **hablo** again. The **-o** already says “I.” Saying *yo hablo* is not wrong, but it is like saying “I, I speak” — Spanish normally leaves the subject pronoun out entirely.

That is called **pro-drop**, and it is only possible because the endings are distinct enough to carry the information by themselves. English endings are worn down to almost nothing (*spea*k, *spea*k, *spea*ks), so English **must** keep its pronouns. Spanish endings did not wear down, so Spanish can throw the pronoun away. One word, *hablo*, is a complete sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pattern — “hablo, hablas, habla” (I / tú / usted)
- “hablo” alone, and notice it is already a whole sentence

Before you move on

How do you build the three singular forms of an *-ar* verb? (**Drop -ar**, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**.) Which one goes with *usted*, and why is it the *he/she* form? (**Habla** — *usted* takes third-person forms.) Why is no subject pronoun needed? (**Pro-drop** — the ending already carries the subject.) Next: **trabajar**, “to work,” straight into the same slot.

6.5 trabajar — “to work,” and it once meant *torture*

A second **-ar** verb — snap it into the exact template you just learned. And *trabajar* has the darkest, best etymology in this chapter: it began as a word for **torture**, and it’s the secret origin of English **travel**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **j-jota** — the **j** is a raspy *h*-from-the-throat (the *jota*): *trabajar* = *tra-ba-HAR*.
- **r-tap, b-soft** — tapped *r*, soft *b*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, “to torture” — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri*- “three” + *pālus* “stake,” the root of English **pale** and **impale**).

The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment* / *suffering* → *hard toil* → just **work**. And English took the very same word down a parallel road:

- **travail** — painful, laborious effort (and the pains of childbirth).
- **travel** — yes: journeying was once such an *ordeal* that “travail” (toil) became **travel** (to make a journey). Every time you *travel*, you’re etymologically being *tortured*.

So even plain **trabajo**, “I work,” hides the old idea of toil as torment — a dark little joke inside an everyday verb.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	trabajo	I work
tú	trabajas	you work
usted	trabaja	you (formal) work

Notice you didn't learn a new ending — that's the point. **One template, every regular -ar verb.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “trabajar” — *tra-ba-HAR*, raspy *j*
- “trabajo, trabajas, trabaja” — same endings as *hablo/hablas/habla*
- “trabajar” → travail → travel — torture became a journey

Before you move on

What did *trabajar* originally mean, and from what device? (“To torture,” ← *tripalium*, a three-stake tool.) What two English words come from the same root? (*Travail* and *travel*.) How do you say “I work”? (*Trabajo* — same -o ending.) Next: **estudiar**, “to study.”

6.6 estudiar — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it

Your third **-ar** verb. By now the pattern should feel automatic — that's exactly what we want. *estudiar* also hides a nicer feeling than the classroom suggests: at root it means **eagerness**.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish props up *st-* with an *e*: **es-tudiar** (the same reflex behind *estar*, *España*, *escuela*). *es-too-DYAR*.
- **diphthong-io** — the *-iar* glides: *es-too-DYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar comes from Latin **studēre**, “to be eager, to apply oneself zealously.” A *studium* was **zeal, enthusiasm, devotion** — only later “study.” So to *study* is, at heart, to *throw yourself eagerly* at something. That **studēre** is everywhere in English:

- **student** — literally “one who is *eager*.”
- **studio, studious, study** — the place, the trait, the act.
- Italian **studio** and the musical *studio* keep the “devoted practice” sense.

So *Estudio español* is “I *devote myself eagerly* to Spanish” — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Grammar Lens: the template holds

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — for the third time:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	estudio	I study
tú	estudias	you study
usted	estudia	you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo, trabajo, estudio*. The singular regular **-ar** present is now reusable rather than memorized verb by verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estudiar” — *es-too-DYAR*
- “estudio, estudias, estudia” — the now-familiar endings
- “estudiar” then English “student, studio” — the *studēre* “eagerness”

Before you move on

What did *studēre* originally mean? (“To be eager / apply oneself.”) Its English cousins? (Student, studio, studious.) Say “I study” — and notice it uses the same *-o* as *hablo* and *trabajo*. (*Estudio*.) Next: put a verb and a noun together into your **first real sentence**.

6.7 español — the word for the language

You have practised writing this word's **ñ**. Now find out what is inside it — because *español* is not a Spanish-made word at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español = “Spanish” — both the language and a Spaniard — from **Hispania**, the **Roman** name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down, and there is the **ñ** again, exactly the *-ni-* squeeze you met in the writing lesson (*Hispaniolus* → *españ-ol*). Say it *es-pa-NYOL*.

Two footnotes worth having:

- English **Spanish**, **Hispanic** and **Hispania** are all the same root, so the English and Spanish names for the language are cousins, not translations of each other.
- *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician** name for the coast, often read as “land of hyraxes” (or rabbits) — the Phoenicians having met an unfamiliar animal and reached for the nearest word they had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “español” — *es-pa-NYOL*
- the path — “Hispania, hispaniolus, español”
- “español” then English “Hispanic” — same root

Before you move on

Where does *español* come from? (**Hispania**, the Roman name for Iberia.) What letter does its ending bring back, and from what Latin sequence? (**ñ**, from **-ni-** in *Hispaniolus*.) Next: put it behind a verb and build your first sentence.

6.8 Hablo español — your first real sentence

This is the moment the course has been building to. You take a **verb** you conjugated yourself and a **noun** you took apart yourself, and make a sentence **nobody handed you pre-assembled**.

What you’ve built — the sentence assembled

Snap two things you already own together:

Hablo (I speak, from *hablar*) + **español** (Spanish) = **Hablo español**.

That is a complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, and notice what is **not** in it: no separate subject word. The *-o* of *hablo* already says “I” — the pro-drop you just learned, doing real work in a real sentence. Now swap the pieces and watch it generate:

- **Estudio español.** — “I study Spanish.”
- **Trabajo.** — “I work.”
- **¿Hablas español?** — “Do you speak Spanish?” (the *¿ ?* pair opening and closing the question, as in the writing lesson).

Grammar Lens: languages go bare

One more thing missing from *hablo español*: **no “the,” no “a.”** After a verb like *hablar* or *estudiar*, a language name takes **no article** — *hablo español*, never *hablo el español*.

This matters because Spanish otherwise loves its articles far more than English does (*me gusta el café*, “I like coffee”). So this is a genuine exception you have to hold onto, and the rule of thumb is narrow: right after *hablar*, the language goes bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablo español” — *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*
- swap the verb — “Estudio español”, “Trabajo”

- ask it — “¿Habras español?” (raise the pitch; ¿ opens it)

Before you move on

Say “I speak Spanish,” then “I study Spanish.” (*Hablo español; estudio español.*) Why is there no separate subject word? (The *-o* ending carries “I.”) Why no “the” before *español*? (**Languages take no article** after a verb like *hablar*.) You just built a sentence from parts — that is the whole game from here.

6.9 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

A milestone chapter: for the first time you’re not reciting fixed phrases, you’re **building sentences from a pattern**. Drill the three verbs through the endings until *hablo / hablas / habla* is automatic.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each verb through the three singular jobs you know: the ending alone for **I** → **tú** → **usted**:

- **hablar**: hablo · hablas · habla
- **trabajar**: trabajo · trabajas · trabaja
- **estudiar**: estudio · estudias · estudia

Same three endings (**-o / -as / -a**) every time — that’s the whole regular **-ar** present, singular.

The exchange — say something real

— ¿Habras español? — **Hablo español.** — ¿Estudias español? — **Estudio español.** — **Café, por favor.** — ¡Gracias!
— De nada.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **por favor** — please (← “for a favour”), completing *gracias / de nada / por favor*.

- **the singular regular -ar pattern** — drop *-ar*, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**: the template behind *hablar*, *trabajar*, and *estudiar*.
- **hablar** (← *fābula*, fable; the f→h law), **trabajar** (← *tripalium*, torture → travail/travel), **estudiar** (← *studēre*, eagerness → student).
- **Hablo español** — your first self-assembled sentence (pro-drop, no article).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs for I / tú / usted, without stopping
- answer “¿Hablas español?” and “¿Estudias español?” about yourself
- request “Café, por favor” and run the full gracias/de nada loop

Twice through: Ask and answer “¿Hablas español? — Hablo español.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the “I” form of all three verbs. (*Hablo, trabajo, estudio*.) Why does *Hablo español* need no separate subject word? (The *-o* carries “I.”) You can now generate sentences — the course stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules*. Next chapter adds the *-er/-ir* verb families.

Chapter 7

Eating, Drinking, Living — the *-er* and *-ir* Verbs

Spanish has exactly three verb families, and you have already met one of them. This chapter hands you the other two — *-er* and *-ir* — which turn out to be almost the same as each other. Then it gives you two question words, so that for the first time you can *ask* something and understand the answer. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C07-*.md.*

7.1 *comer* — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Sounds you’ll need

The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*, and the final *r* is one soft tap of the tongue: *comer* = *ko-MER*, with the stress on the second syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer (“to eat”) ← Latin *comedere*, “to eat up” — *com-* (an intensifier, “completely”) + *edere*, “to eat.”

That *edere* is the twin of English **eat**: both descend from the same ancient root, the Latin and Germanic branches of one family.

The English relatives: **edible** (“fit to be eaten”), **comestible** (a fancy word for food, straight from *comedere*), and **eat** itself.

Grammar Lens

A **verb** is the action word of a sentence, and Spanish changes its ending to show *who* is doing the action. The *-er* family works exactly like the *-ar* family with the *a*'s swapped for *e*'s. Chop the *-er* off *comer* to get the stem *com-*, then add:

person	<i>-ar</i> was	<i>-er</i> is	<i>comer</i> →
<i>yo</i> (I)	<i>-o</i>	<i>-o</i>	<i>como</i> (I eat)
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	<i>-as</i>	<i>-es</i>	<i>comes</i> (you eat)
<i>él / ella / usted</i> (<i>nosotros</i> , we)	<i>-a</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>come</i> (he/she eats)
<i>(ellos / ustedes, they/you</i> all)	<i>-amos</i>	<i>-emos</i>	<i>comemos</i>
	<i>-an</i>	<i>-en</i>	<i>comen</i>

So the *yo* form is identical (*-o*), and *tú/él* simply trade *a* for *e*: *hablas / habla* → *comes / come*. If you know *-ar*, you already know ninety percent of *-er*.

Why it's said this way

Watch this small trap: *como* means “I eat” and “like / as” (*como tú*, “like you”) and, once it puts on an accent, *cómo* = “how?” Same four letters, three jobs — the accent and the surrounding words sort them out.

7.2 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family

Sounds you'll need

The Spanish *v* is pronounced as a soft *b*, so *vivir* sounds roughly like *bee-BEER*. The final *r* is again a single tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir (“to live”) ← Latin *vīvere*, “to live” — one of the most alive roots in English.

vivid (“full of life”), **survive** (← *super-vīvere*, “to live beyond”), **revive** (“live again”), **vivacious**, **convivial** (“living together,” so sociable),

viva!, **vivarium**.

And the noun beside it, Latin *vīta* (“life”), gives English **vital** and **vi-tamin**.

Grammar Lens

Here is the punchline of the whole system: in the present tense, *-ir* is almost identical to *-er*. Set the three families side by side in the singular:

person	-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	-er (<i>comer</i>)	-ir (<i>vivir</i>)
<i>yo</i>	<i>hablo</i>	<i>como</i>	<i>vivo</i>
<i>tú</i>	<i>hablas</i>	<i>comes</i>	<i>vives</i>
<i>él / ella</i>	<i>habla</i>	<i>come</i>	<i>vive</i>

Look closely: *-er* and *-ir* are *identical* in the singular (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*). They part company only in the “we” and “you all” forms — *comemos* / *coméis* against *vivimos* / *vivís*. So learning *-ir* costs you almost nothing.

Three families, three vowels, one idea. You can now conjugate the present tense of virtually any regular Spanish verb.

7.3 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Sounds you’ll need

Both *b*’s are the soft Spanish *b*, the same sound as the Spanish *v*: *be-BER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber (“to drink”) ← Latin *bibere*, “to drink” — a thirsty little root that soaked into English.

beverage (a drink, by way of Old French *bevrage*, from *bibere*), **imbibe** (“to drink in”: *in-* + *bibere*), **bibulous** (fond of drinking), and **bib**, the cloth that catches the drips. Even **beer**’s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens

There is no new grammar here, and that is exactly the point. *beber* is a regular *-er* verb, so it takes the endings you already own:

person	form	meaning
<i>yo</i>	<i>bebo</i>	I drink
<i>tú</i>	<i>bebes</i>	you drink
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>bebe</i>	he/she drinks; you (formal) drink

Nothing new to learn — you are simply reusing the machine. Which means you can now say: *Como pan y bebo agua.* (“I eat bread and drink water.”) Two verbs, two nouns, one sentence you built yourself.

7.4 *qué* — “what?”, your first question word

Sounds you’ll need

qu is a plain hard *k* and the *u* is silent, so *qué* = *keh*. The accent on the *é* marks this as the *question* word: *qué* = “what?”, while *que* without the accent = “that.” Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué (“what?”) ← Latin *quid*, “what” — the neuter form of *quis*, “who.” It is a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

quiddity — the “what-ness,” the essence of a thing; **quid pro quo** — “*what* for *what*,” this for that.

The family it heads in Spanish: *qué* (what), *quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin’s *qu-* question words. Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins, which is why the two languages share the same questioning instinct.

Grammar Lens

Put *qué* in front of a verb, wrap the whole thing in the pair of Spanish question marks, and you have a real question:

¿*Qué comes?* — “What are you eating? / What do you eat?”

¿Qué bebes? — “What are you drinking?”

The opening ¿ warns the reader that a question is coming, and the accent on *qué* marks which word is doing the asking. Answer with the verb you already conjugate: *Como pan.* (“I eat bread.”)

7.5 *dónde* — “where?”

Sounds you’ll need

The middle *d* is soft, close to the *th* of English “this”: *DON-deh*. As with *qué*, the accent on the *ó* marks the question word — *dónde* = “where?”, while *donde* without the accent means “where” as a connector, as in “the place *where* I live.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde (“where?”) ← Latin *de unde*, literally “from whence.” *unde* meant “from where”; Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*.

English once had the matching set **whence** / **where** / **whither** — “from where / at where / to where.” Spanish keeps that flavour alive: *de dónde* (“from where”), *dónde* (“where”), *adónde* (“to where”).

Grammar Lens

Two question words plus the verbs you own = real conversation:

¿Dónde vives? — “Where do you live?” → *Vivo en Madrid.*

¿Dónde trabajas? — “Where do you work?”

¿Qué estudias? — “What do you study?”

Notice the little *en* (“in”) in the answer, from Latin *in* — your first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You are now trading real questions and answers, not reciting fixed phrases.

Why it’s said this way

¿Dónde vives? is the single most common getting-to-know-you question in Spanish, and the answer opens a door: the city you name tells your listener which Spanish you speak, which food you eat, and often how to

place you. Pair it with *¿Y tú?* (“and you?”) and the conversation runs itself.

7.6 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families *and* two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can ask and answer, not just recite. Conjugate *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* and feel how little differs:

family	verb	<i>yo · tú · él/ella</i>
-ar	<i>hablar</i>	<i>hablo · hablas · habla</i>
-er	<i>comer</i>	<i>como · comes · come</i>
-ir	<i>vivir</i>	<i>vivo · vives · vive</i>

The endings: -ar takes -o / -as / -a; -er and -ir both take -o / -es / -e, identical in the singular. Master these and you conjugate almost any regular verb.

- *¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en Sevilla. ¿Y tú?*
- *Vivo en México. ¿Qué estudias?*
- *Estudio español. ¿Qué comes?*
- *Como una tapa y bebo un café. ¿Algo más?*
- *Un agua, por favor.*

What you built this chapter: *comer* and *beber* (the -er family) and *vivir* (the -ir family), with the singular endings -o / -es / -e; *qué* (from *quid*) and *dónde* (from *de unde*), each wearing its accent and opening with *¿*; and real questions — *¿Qué comes?*, *¿Dónde vives?*, *¿Dónde trabajas?* — answered with the first preposition, *en*. Try chaining a whole café moment: greet, order with *por favor*, ask and answer, then *gracias* and *adiós*. Next chapter: numbers — *uno, dos, tres* — and telling someone your age.

Chapter 8

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Numbers are the most reused words in any language, and Spanish counts almost exactly the way Latin did — which means each one planted an English word you can lean on. Then one irregular verb, *tener* (“to have”), turns those numbers into your age: in Spanish you don’t *be* twenty, you *have* twenty years. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C08-*.md.*

8.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five

Sounds you’ll need

cuatro = *KWA-tro* — the *cu-* is a *kw* glide, not two separate vowels. The *r* in *tres* and *cuatro* is a soft tap of the tongue against the ridge behind the upper teeth — close to the *tt* in the American pronunciation of “butter,” not an English *r*.

Spanish	← Latin	English cousins
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	unit, union, unique, unanimous, universe
dos (2)	<i>duo</i>	duo, dual, duet, double, duplex
tres (3)	<i>trēs</i>	trio, triple, trinity, trident, triangle
cuatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	quart, quarter, quadrant, square
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	quintet, quintessence, quintuplet

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Pattern: Latin *qu-* softens on its way into Spanish — *quattuor* → *cuatro* (*qu-* → *cu-*), *quīnque* → *cinco* (*qu-* → *c-*).

So *cinco* and **quintet** are the same number wearing different clothes. *uno* also stands behind English **one** and **a/an**. Count the family on your fingers: **unit, duo, trio, quart, quint**.

Grammar Lens

uno shrinks when it stands in front of a noun: **un** (masculine) / **una** (feminine). A **noun** is a word for a thing or a person; Spanish sorts every noun into one of two classes, *masculine* or *feminine*, and the words in front of it must match.

These shrunken forms do double duty: Spanish makes no distinction between “one” and “a/an.” *un café* is both “a coffee” and “one coffee”; *una cerveza*, “a beer / one beer.” The other numbers (*dos, tres, cuatro, cinco*) never change shape.

8.2 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez* — and the calendar’s secret

Sounds you’ll need

siete = *SYE-teh* and **nueve** = *NWE-veh*. Those *ie* and *ue* glides — two vowels said in one smooth motion — are a Spanish signature; you will meet them again in almost every irregular verb.

Spanish	← Latin	English cousins
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	sextet, sextant, semester (six months)
siete (7)	<i>septem</i>	September (the 7th month), septet, septuagenarian
ocho (8)	<i>octō</i>	October (8th), octopus , octave, octagon
nueve (9)	<i>novem</i>	November (9th), novena
diez (10)	<i>decem</i>	December (10th), decimal , decade, dime, decimate

Why it's said this way

Why are the “7th–10th” months numbered 7–10 when they sit at positions 9–12 on the calendar? Because the old **Roman year began in March** — so *September* really was the seventh month.

Julius Caesar and Augustus later inserted **July** and **August**, named for themselves, shoving the counting-months out of place. The Latin numbers stayed put anyway. Every time you say *December*, you are saying Roman “**ten**.”

Grammar Lens

Past ten, Spanish **fuses** “ten and X” into a single word:

diez y seis (“ten and six”) → *dieciséis* (16); *diez y siete* → *diecisiete* (17), and onward to 19.

English built its own teens the identical way: *six + ten = sixteen*. *Dieciséis* and **sixteen** are the same two numbers glued together in the same order.

8.3 *tener* — “to have,” your first irregular verb

A **verb** is an action or state word (“speak,” “eat,” “have”), and a **regular** verb changes its ending by a fixed, predictable recipe. *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”) are all tidy that way. *tener* is your first **irregular** verb, and it breaks the rules in the two ways Spanish verbs most often do.

Sounds you'll need

tener = *te-NER*, with the stress on the second syllable. When the stem cracks open you get the *ie* glide again: **tienes** = *TYE-nēs*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener (“to have”) ← Latin *tenēre*, “to hold, to keep, to grasp.” Having is, at root, *holding*.

The bare root: **tenant** (one who *holds* land), **tenure**, **tenacious** (*holding* on), **tenable**, **tenet** (a *held* belief).

With prefixes: **contain** (“hold together”), **retain** (“hold back”), **maintain** (“hold in hand”), **sustain** (“hold up”), **detain**, **obtain**.

Grammar Lens

tener misbehaves in exactly the two classic Spanish ways. First, the *yo* (“I”) form is odd: not *teno* but **tengo**, with a *-g-* appearing from nowhere. A handful of very common verbs do this (*hago*, *pongo*, *salgo*, *vengo*).

Second, the stem vowel breaks $e \rightarrow ie$ in the stressed forms — a **stem-changer**.

Person	Form	Note
<i>yo</i> (I)	tengo	the <i>-go</i> form
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	 tienes	$e \rightarrow ie$
<i>él / ella / usted</i> (he, she, you-formal)	 tiene	$e \rightarrow ie$
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	tenemos	back to plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
<i>ellos / ustedes</i> (they, you-plural)	 tienen	$e \rightarrow ie$

Notice that *tenemos* keeps the plain *e*: the vowel only cracks to *ie* when the stress falls on it. Sketch the changed forms on the table and they trace a boot shape around the untouched *nosotros* — which is why this is called the **boot** pattern. It is the single most common irregularity in Spanish, and *tener* is your model for it.

8.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — “how old are you?”

With *tener* and your numbers you can now ask and give an **age** — and Spanish does it in a way English does not.

¿Cuántos años tienes? = “How old are you?”
literally: “How many years do you have?”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuántos (“how many”) ← Latin *quantus*, “how much, how great” → **quantity**, **quantum**, **quantify**. It belongs to the *qu-* question family:

qué, cómo, dónde, cuántos.

años (“years”) ← Latin *annus* — and there is the ñ again, born from the doubled *nn* of *annus*. *annus* also gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, **biennial**.

tienes (“you have”) — the *tener* you just learned.

Grammar Lens

cuántos **agrees** with the noun it counts: because *años* is masculine and plural, the question word takes the matching masculine plural ending, *cuántos años*. Spanish makes the words around a noun echo its gender and number; English leaves them alone.

Why it’s said this way

Age is had, not been. Spanish counts age with *tener* (“have”), never with *ser/estar* (“be”).

— *¿Cuántos años tienes?* — *Tengo veinte años.* (“I have twenty years.”)

Saying *soy veinte* (“I am twenty”) is simply wrong. You possess your years; you do not equal them. French and Italian agree — *j’ai vingt ans*, *ho vent’anni*, both “I have.”

Say it as *KWAN-tos AN-yos TYE-nes*, and answer *Tengo ... años* with your own number.

8.5 Practice — numbers, having, and age

Two new powers this chapter: you can **count**, and you can talk about what you **have** — including your years. Drill both until they are automatic.

Count up: uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.

tener, all forms: tengo · tienes · tiene · tenemos · tienen.

— *Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas?* — *Me llamo Ana. ¿Y cuántos años tienes?*

— *Tengo veintiuno. ¿Y tú?*

— *Tengo diecinueve.*

— *Un café, por favor. ¿Cuánto es?* — *Dos euros.*

What you have built:

- the **numbers 1–10** ($\leftarrow \bar{u}nus \dots decem$), including *cinco*/**quintet** and *diez*/**December**;
- the **teen fusion** *diez y seis* $\rightarrow$ *dieciséis*, the same construction as **sixteen**;
- **tener**, “to have” ($\leftarrow ten\bar{e}re$, “hold”), your first irregular, stem-changing verb, with *tengo* and its $e \rightarrow ie$ crack; and
- *¿Cuántos años tienes?*, age given with *tener* rather than “be,” where *años* $\leftarrow annus$ brings back the ñ.

Next chapter: *ser* versus *estar* head-on — the two “to be” verbs, sorted for good.

Chapter 9

Ser and *Estar* — Two Ways to Be

Spanish has *two* verbs where English has one. This chapter finally meets the second one, *ser*, and settles the famous question of when to use which — a choice that is not arbitrary at all, but written into the two Latin roots. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C09-*.md.*

9.1 *ser* — “to be,” the *essential* kind

Back in Chapter 4 you met **estar** — the *temporary* to-be (← *stāre*, “to stand”): how you *are right now*, and *where*. It always came with a promise: Spanish has **two** be-verbs, and here is the other. **ser** is the *permanent* one — what a thing *essentially is*. It is also your second irregular verb, and its irregularity is spectacular.

Sounds you’ll need

r-tap — *ser* ends in one soft tap of the tongue: *SER*.

no propping e here — unlike *es-tar*, *ser* already starts with its own vowel, so nothing has to be propped up in front of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ser ← Latin *esse*, “to be” — the plainest, oldest verb there is. (Vulgar Latin actually rebuilt the infinitive as **essere*, and even folded in a second verb, *sedēre* “to sit,” which is why a few forms look like they wandered in from elsewhere.)

The es- family runs deep into English: *essence*, *essential*, *entity*, and — all the way down — **is**, **am**, **are**. This is the ancient PIE root **h₁es-*, “to be.” When you say *es*, you are saying a cousin of English

is.

With prefixes: **present** (← *prae-esse*, “to be before / at hand”), **absent** (← *ab-esse*, “to be away”), **interest** (← *inter-esse*, “to be between”).

So *ser* is not just a word to memorize — it is the same ancient “be” that English carries in *is* / *am* / *are*.

Grammar Lens

ser is **suppletive**: its forms come from *different* Latin words fused into one verb, so you cannot derive them from the infinitive. You simply learn them as a set.

person	form	Latin source
yo	soy	<i>sum</i> (“I am”); the <i>-y</i> is the same odd tail as in <i>estoy</i> / <i>voy</i> / <i>doy</i>
tú	eres	<i>eris</i> (“you will be”) — a future form drafted into the present
él / ella / usted	es	<i>est</i> — literally cognate with English <i>is</i>
nosotros	somos	<i>sumus</i>
ellos / ustedes	son	<i>sunt</i> — cognate with the plural English <i>are</i>

Say them as a set: *soy · eres · es · somos · son*. Notice how *es* and *son* sit right next to English *is* and Latin *sunt* — you half-knew this verb before you started.

9.2 *ser* vs *estar* — essence vs state

This is the lesson every Spanish learner waits for and dreads. Two verbs, one English word (“to be”). But the choice is not arbitrary — it is written into the **etymology** of each verb. Get the roots, and the rule follows.

verb	root	picture	used for
ser	<i>esse</i> → essence	what a thing <i>is</i>	identity, origin, profession, nationality, material, the time
estar	<i>stāre</i> → stand, state	how a thing <i>stands</i> now	mood, condition, location, the temporary

The mnemonic writes itself: **ser** = **essence**, **estar** = **estado** — *estado* being the Spanish for “state,” the very word *estar* built. Permanent, defining truth → *ser*. Passing state or where-you-are → *estar*.

Soy alto. — “I am tall.” (a defining trait → *ser*)

Estoy cansado. — “I am tired.” (a passing state → *estar*)

Es médico. — “She is a doctor.” (identity → *ser*)

Está en casa. — “She is at home.” (location → *estar*, always)

Grammar Lens

Here is the proof that the split is *real*, not decoration. Swap *ser* for *estar* on the **same adjective** and the meaning changes — because *essence* and *state* are genuinely different claims.

with ser (essence)	with estar (state)
<i>es aburrido</i> — “he <i>is</i> boring” (his nature)	<i>está aburrido</i> — “he <i>is</i> bored” (right now)
<i>es listo</i> — “she <i>is</i> clever” (a trait)	<i>está lista</i> — “she <i>is</i> ready” (this moment)
<i>es rico</i> — “he <i>is</i> rich” (wealth)	<i>está rico</i> — “it <i>tastes</i> delicious” (this dish)
<i>es verde</i> — “it <i>is</i> green” (its colour)	<i>está verde</i> — “it <i>is</i> unripe” (its state)

Why it’s said this way

Same adjective, two verbs, two worlds. A boring person *is* (*ser*) boring; a bored person merely *stands* (*estar*) bored today. This is why Spanish keeps two verbs where English merged them into one — it can say in

one word things English needs extra words for. Say it twice and let it stick: “*ser* = who/what it is; *estar* = how/where it is *right now*.”

9.3 *soy de...* — saying where you’re from

You have *ser*. Now aim it. **Where you are from** and **what you do** are treated as *essence* in Spanish — they define you — so both take *ser*, not *estar*. This is where the split starts paying rent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de (“from / of”) ← Latin *dē* (“down from, about”). It is one of the most common words in Spanish, and its English children are everywhere as the prefix **de-**: **deduct**, **depart**, **descend**, **describe** — all carrying the “from / down-from” of *dē*.

Origin is a permanent fact about you, so the pattern is *ser* + *de* + place:

Soy de México. — “I’m from Mexico.”
Eres de España. — “You’re from Spain.”
Es de Colombia. — “She’s from Colombia.”

And to ask it, Spanish fronts the *de*: *¿De dónde eres?* — literally “From where are-you?” (*dónde*, “where,” you met in Chapter 7; here it rides with *de* to mean *from where*.)

Grammar Lens

Note that it is *eres*, not *estás* — even though *dónde* usually pairs with *estar* for location. Origin is not *where you are standing*; it is *what you are*. Essence → *ser*.

Because profession and nationality also define you, they are *ser* too — and they take **no article**:

Soy profesor. — “I’m a teacher.”
Soy español. — “I’m Spanish.”
Somos estudiantes. — “We’re students.”

Why it's said this way

Spanish drops the “a” with a bare profession: *soy profesor*, never *soy un profesor*, unless you add something to it. The naked noun is enough — you are not *a* teacher among many, you simply *are* teacher. (And there is *español* again, from Chapter 6, back through Latin *Hispania*.)

9.4 *está en...* — saying where something is

The mirror image of the last lesson. Origin was *ser* (essence). But **location** — where a thing physically *stands* right now — is the home turf of *estar* (← *stāre*, “to stand”). The root tells you: to be *located* is to *stand* somewhere.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en (“in / on / at”) ← Latin *in* — and it *is* English **in**, barely changed in two thousand years. Latin *in* → Spanish *en*, English *in*; the same word runs through **interior**, **include**, **invade**.

One Spanish word covers three English prepositions: *en casa* = “at home,” *en la mesa* = “on the table,” *en Madrid* = “in Madrid.” And location is always *estar* — never *ser*, with no exceptions for physical place:

Estoy en casa. — “I’m at home.”
Estás en Madrid. — “You’re in Madrid.”
Está en la mesa. — “It’s on the table.”

To ask it, pair *dónde* with *estar*: *¿Dónde estás?* — “Where are you?” Answer: *Estoy en casa*.

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Put the two questions side by side and the whole chapter snaps into focus.

question	verb	why
<i>¿De dónde eres?</i> — “Where are you <i>from</i> ?”	<i>ser</i> (<i>eres</i>)	origin = essence
<i>¿Dónde estás?</i> — “Where are you <i>at</i> ?”	<i>estar</i> (<i>estás</i>)	location = state

Same word *dónde*, two different be-verbs — and each is locked in by meaning. *From* where → what you *are* (*ser*). *At* where → where you *stand* (*estar*). Even a permanent-seeming place stays *estar*: *Madrid está en España* — cities do not move, but *being located* is still *estar*.

9.5 Practice — *ser* or *estar*?

The whole chapter comes down to one reflex: **essence** → **ser**, **state** → **estar**. Drill it until you do not have to think. Say each form aloud, and for every sentence name *why* the verb is the one it is.

ser (essence)	estar (state)
soy	estoy
eres	estás
es	está
somos	estamos
son	están

ser is suppletive (*sum, eris, est, sumus, sunt*); *estar* carries the -oy tail in *estoy*, the same tail as *soy, voy, doy*.

Sort these — say “ser” or “estar,” then the reason:

“I’m a doctor.” → *ser* (soy médico — *identity*)

“I’m tired.” → *estar* (estoy cansado — *passing state*)

“She’s from Peru.” → *ser* (es de Perú — *origin*)

“The keys are on the table.” → *estar* (están en la mesa — *location*)

“We’re students.” → *ser* (somos estudiantes — *identity*)

“You’re at home.” → *estar* (estás en casa — *location*)

Then the minimal pairs, where the meaning flips with the verb: *es aburrido* (“is boring”) vs *está aburrido* (“is bored”) · *es listo* (“is clever”) vs *está listo* (“is ready”) · *es rico* (“is rich”) vs *está rico* (“tastes delicious”) · *es verde* (“is green”) vs *está verde* (“is unripe”).

Now say something real:

— *Hola. ¿De dónde eres? — Soy de México. ¿Y tú?*

— *Soy de España. Soy profesor. ¿Dónde estás ahora?*

— *Estoy en casa. Estoy un poco cansado, pero bien.*

Two verbs, one conversation: *soy de / soy profesor* (essence $\rightarrow$ *ser*), *estoy en casa / estoy cansado* (state $\rightarrow$ *estar*).

What you built this chapter: *ser*, the essence to-be ($\leftarrow$ *esse* $\rightarrow$ essence / present; suppletive *soy · eres · es · somos · son*, cousins of English *is / am / are*), completing the pair begun with *estar* in Chapter 4 · the *ser/estar* split read straight off the roots — *essence* (*ser*) vs *estado/standing* (*estar*) — with minimal pairs that flip meaning · *soy de...* (origin $\rightarrow$ *ser*; *de* $\leftarrow$ *dē*) and *está en...* (location $\rightarrow$ *estar*; *en* $\leftarrow$ *in*), plus the twin questions *¿De dónde eres?* and *¿Dónde estás?* Next chapter: the near future — *ir a* + infinitive, “going to...” — and possessives.

Chapter 10

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Three new powers: you can *go* somewhere, you can talk about the *future*, and you can say *whose* something is. The future comes almost free — Spanish builds tomorrow out of the verb “to go,” exactly as English does. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C10-*.md.*

10.1 *ir* — “to go,” stitched from three verbs

Sounds you’ll need

vowel-i — the infinitive *ir* is just *eer*: two letters, one of the shortest verbs in Spanish.

diphthong-oy — *voy* sounds like *boy* (a *b/v* sound + “oy”), sharing the *-oy* tail of *soy*, *estoy*, *doy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir (“to go”) is not one verb but *three* Latin verbs collapsed into a single Spanish one.

The infinitive *ir* ← Latin *īre*, “to go” → English **exit** (*ex-īre*, “to go out”), **transit**, **ambition**.

The present *voy*, *vas*, *va*, *vamos*, *van* ← a different Latin verb, *vādere*, “to advance, to rush” → English **invade**, **evade**, **wade**.

The past *fuī* (which comes later) ← Latin *esse/fuī*, “to be” — the same *fu-* that supplies the past of *ser*.

So the present tense of “to go” does not come from the word *ir* at all. It comes from *vādere*:

Person	Form	Note
yo	<i>voy</i>	the <i>-oy</i> , like <i>soy</i> , <i>estoy</i> , <i>doy</i>
tú	<i>vas</i>	
él / ella / usted	<i>va</i>	
nosotros	<i>vamos</i>	this is also “let’s go!”
ellos / ustedes	<i>van</i>	

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When a single verb draws its forms from more than one original verb, linguists call it **suppletion**. English does exactly this: *go* in the present, but *went* in the past — and *went* was borrowed from a completely different old verb, *wend*. Spanish plays the same trick, only it does it *inside* one tense: the infinitive from one Latin verb, the present from another, the past from a third.

Grammar Lens

Pointing *ir* at a destination. Add *a* (“to” ← Latin *ad*) and then the place:

Voy a Madrid. — “I’m going to Madrid.”

Vamos a casa. — “We’re going home / Let’s go home.”

When *a* meets the masculine article *el*, the two contract into **al**: *voy al café*, “I’m going to the café.”

10.2 *voy a* + infinitive — the “going-to” future

Here is a gift. Spanish builds its everyday future *exactly* the way English does. English says “I’m **going to** speak”; Spanish says ***voy a hablar***. Same verb, same metaphor — so you get a whole tense for almost nothing.

An **infinitive** is the dictionary form of a verb, the naming form: in English “to speak,” in Spanish *hablar* (“to speak”), *comer* (“to eat”), *vivir* (“to live”). Take the present of *ir*, add *a*, then add any infinitive at all:

Person	Spanish	English
yo	<i>voy a hablar</i>	“I’m going to speak”
tú	<i>vas a comer</i>	“you’re going to eat”
él / ella / usted	<i>va a estudiar</i>	“she’s going to study”
nosotros	<i>vamos a vivir</i>	“we’re going to live”
ellos / ustedes	<i>van a trabajar</i>	“they’re going to work”

Only *ir* changes. The second verb stays a bare infinitive and is never conjugated — just as English keeps “to speak” unchanged after “going to.”

Grammar Lens

Why “go” becomes “future.” It is one of the most natural metaphors in human language: *movement toward* something becomes *time approaching* it. If you are *going to* a place, you have not arrived — the place is ahead of you — so “going to (do something)” comes to mean “about to, soon.” French makes the same move (*je vais parler*, “I’m going to speak”), English makes it, Spanish makes it: three languages, one picture. Spanish even keeps the little *a* (“to” ← Latin *ad*) that English swallows in speech, where “going to” becomes “gonna.”

10.3 *mi, tu, su* — my, your, his/her

To say *whose* something is, Spanish puts a small word in front of the noun: *mi casa* (“my house”), *tu café* (“your coffee”). These are called **possessives**, and they come straight from Latin.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mi (“my”) ← Latin *meus* — a genuine cousin of English **my** and **mine** (and **me**).

tu (“your,” informal — what belongs to a *tú*) ← Latin *tuus* — the cousin of English **thy** and **thine**, the old intimate “your” that English retired.

su (“his / her / its / your-formal / their”) ← Latin *suus* — the *su-* that survives in the borrowed phrase *sui generis*, “of its own kind.”

Two things to notice.

Grammar Lens

tu versus tú. The possessive **tu** (“your”) has *no* accent; the pronoun **tú** (“you”) does. This is the same device you have seen elsewhere in the writing system — *el* versus *él*, *si* versus *sí*. The accent here is called the *tilde diacrítica*: it does no work for pronunciation, it only separates two look-alike words on the page.

Why it’s said this way

su does a great deal of work. One little word covers *his*, *her*, *its*, *your-formal* and *their* all at once, and context is normally enough to tell you which is meant. *Su casa* can be “his house,” “her house,” “your house” (to an *usted*), or “their house.” When it is genuinely unclear, Spanish spells it out afterwards: *de él* (“of him”), *de ella* (“of her”), and so on.

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They agree in number, not gender. Unlike most Spanish modifiers, *mi* / *tu* / *su* do *not* change for masculine or feminine: *mi casa* (feminine) and *mi café* (masculine) both take plain *mi*. They change only for **number** — add *-s* when the noun is plural.

Singular	Plural	English
<i>mi libro</i>	<i>mis libros</i>	“my book → my books”
<i>tu casa</i>	<i>tus casas</i>	“your house → your houses”
<i>su amigo</i>	<i>sus amigos</i>	“his friend → his friends”

(*nuestro* / *nuestra*, “our” ← Latin *noster*, is the one possessive that *does* flex for gender. You will meet it in full later.)

10.4 Practice — going, planning, and possessing

No new words. Drill the irregular *ir* until *voy*, *vas*, *va*, *vamos*, *van* is automatic, because the whole future rides on it.

- **ir, present:** *voy* · *vas* · *va* · *vamos* · *van* (from *vādere* — the *-oy* of *voy*, like *soy*, *estoy*, *doy*).
- **The near future:** *ir* + *a* + infinitive — *voy a hablar*, *vas a comer*, *va a estudiar* (“I’m / you’re / she’s going to ...”).

- **Possessives:** *mi · tu · su*, and their plurals *mis · tus · sus* — agreeing in number, not gender.

— ¿*Qué vas a hacer hoy?*

— *Voy a estudiar en mi casa, y luego voy a trabajar. ¿Y tú?*

— *Voy a comer con mis amigos. Vamos a un café.*

Three threads run through those four lines: *voy a estudiar* and *voy a comer* are the near future (*ir* + *a* + infinitive); *mi casa* and *mis amigos* are the possessives, one singular and one plural; *vamos a un café* is plain *ir a* + a place.

What you built: *ir*, “to go,” the most suppletive verb in Spanish (infinitive ← *īre*; present *voy/vas/va/vamos/van* ← *vādere* → invade, evade), the same *go/went* trick English plays · the near future, *ir a* + infinitive (*voy a hablar* = “I’m going to speak”), Spanish making tomorrow out of the verb “to go” exactly as English and French do · *mí / tu / su* (← *meus / tuus / suus* → my / thy), possessives that agree in number (*mis / tus / sus*) and not gender, plus *tu* (“your”) against *tú* (“you”), the accent doing its quiet work again. Next chapter takes these rules further — from here on the course runs on grammar, not phrases.

Chapter 11

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Two power-verbs — *querer* (“to want”) and *poder* (“can”) — crack their own vowels when you conjugate them. This chapter shows why: one ancient sound-law, two vowels, and a boot-shaped pattern you can predict. It closes with *nuestro*, “our,” which carries the very same crack. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C11-*.md.*

11.1 *querer* — “to want,” and the *e→ie* crack

Sounds you’ll need

diphthong-ie — under stress the stem breaks open into *-ie-*: *quiero* is said *KYE-ro*, one gliding syllable, not *kee-EH-ro*.

r-tap — the *r* of *querer* is a single flicked tap of the tongue, like the middle of American *butter*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer (“to want”; of a person, “to love”) ← Latin *quaerere*, “to seek, to ask, to want.” Seeking and wanting are the same impulse at the root — and that root is a treasure-house of English.

The plain seeking words: **query**, **quest**, **question** — each one a seeking.

With prefixes: **inquire** (*in-*, “into”), **require** (*re-*, “back”), **acquire** (*ad-*, “toward”), **conquer** (*con-*, “thoroughly seek/win”), **exquisite**

(“sought out”), **quorum** (“of whom” the seeking needs enough).

So when you say *quiero*, you are using the same “seek” root as **question** and **conquer**.

Grammar Lens

A **stem** is the part of a verb left when you strip the ending: in *querer*, the stem is *quer-* and the ending is *-er*. A **stem-changing verb** is one whose stem vowel changes when the stress lands on it. In *querer* that stressed *e* breaks into *ie*.

Only *queremos* keeps the plain *e*, because there the stress falls on the ending, not on the stem. Shade in the forms that do change — *yo, tú, él/ella/usted, ellos/ustedes* — and they draw a **boot** shape around the *nosotros/vosotros* gap. That boot is the signature of every stem-changer.

Person	Form	Vowel
yo	<i>quiero</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
tú	<i>quieres</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>quiere</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
nosotros	<i>queremos</i>	plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	<i>quieren</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>

Say it out loud until the crack is automatic: *quiero · quieres · quiere · queremos · quieren*. Then put it to work: *Quiero un café* (“I want a coffee”), *Quiero café, por favor*.

11.2 *poder* — “to be able,” and the *o*→*ue* crack

Sounds you’ll need

diphthong-ue — under stress the stem breaks to *-ue-*, with a *w*-glide: *puedo* is said *PWE-do*.

r-tap — again one flicked tap for the *r* of *poder*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder (“to be able / can”) ← Latin *potēre* (from *posse*), “to be able, to have power.” It is literally the verb *power*.

power itself — English took it through Old French *poeir* ← *potēre*.

potent, **potential**, **omnipotent** (“all-powerful”), **possible** (“able to be”), **posse** (“[those] able” to be summoned).

So *puedo* and **power** are the same word — one a Spanish verb, the other its English noun.

Grammar Lens

poder is a stem-changer of the *o*→*ue* kind: the stressed stem *o* breaks to *ue*, in exactly the same **boot** shape — every form but *nosotros/vosotros*. Just as with *querer*, only the *nosotros* form keeps the plain vowel. Other *o*→*ue* verbs you will meet: *dormir* (“sleep”) → *duermo*, *volver* (“return”) → *vuelvo*.

Person	Form	Vowel
yo	<i>puedo</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
tú	<i>puedes</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>puede</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
nosotros	<i>podemos</i>	plain <i>o</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	<i>pueden</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>

Grammar Lens

***poder* + infinitive.** An **infinitive** is the naming form of a verb — the one that ends in *-ar*, *-er*, or *-ir* (*hablar*, “to speak”). Point *poder* at an infinitive and you say what you are *able* to do:

Puedo hablar español. — “I can speak Spanish.”

¿Puedes venir? — “Can you come?”

No puedo. — “I can’t.”

11.3 *e*→*ie* and *o*→*ue* — one rule, two vowels

You have now seen both cracks: *querer* → *quiero* (*e*→*ie*) and *poder* → *puedo* (*o*→*ue*). They are not two random quirks. They are *one sound-law*,

and knowing it turns a “memorize each verb” chore into a pattern you can predict.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The law: in the leap from Latin to Spanish, a **short, stressed *e*** broke into ***ie***, and a **short, stressed *o*** broke into ***ue***. It happened in ordinary nouns, not just verbs.

terra → *tierra* (“earth”) — *e* → *ie*

septem → *siete* (“seven”) — *e* → *ie*

porta → *puerta* (“door”) — *o* → *ue*

novem → *nueve* (“nine”) — *o* → *ue*

The numbers *siete* and *nueve* carry that glide for exactly this reason.

Grammar Lens

In verbs, the stem vowel is stressed in the “boot” forms and unstressed in *nosotros/vosotros* — so it breaks inside the boot and stays plain outside it. That single fact explains both patterns at once.

Person	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i> (<i>querer</i>)	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i> (<i>poder</i>)
yo	<i>quiero</i>	<i>puedo</i>
tú	<i>quieres</i>	<i>puedes</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>quiere</i>	<i>puede</i>
nosotros	<i>queremos</i>	<i>podemos</i>
ellos / ustedes	<i>quieren</i>	<i>pueden</i>

Same shape both times: the four “corner” forms crack, the *nosotros* form stays plain — the boot. The verb *tener* (→ *tienes*), met earlier, was your first taste of it; now you own the whole rule.

11.4 *nuestro* — “our,” the possessive that agrees fully

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro (“our”) ← Latin *noster*, “our.” You have heard it without knowing: the **Paternoster** is the “*Our* Father,” and a **nostrum** is literally “*our* thing” — a quack’s secret remedy.

Its partner **vuestro** (“your,” said to a group) ← Latin *voster/vester*.

The stem-change fossil: *noster* → *nuestro* shows the very *o*→*ue* break you just learned — short stressed *o* → *ue*. The possessive cracks exactly like *puerta* and *puedo*.

Grammar Lens

A **possessive** marks who owns the thing. The possessives *mi* (“my”), *tu* (“your”), *su* (“his/her/your-formal”) change only for **number**: *mís*, *tus*, *sus*. *nuestro* is different — it agrees in **both gender and number**, like an ordinary *-o/-a* adjective, so it has **four** forms instead of two. It is the fullest-flexing of the possessives, and *vuestro* does the same (*vuestro*, *vuestra*, *vuestros*, *vuestras*).

	singular	plural
masculine	<i>nuestro libro</i>	<i>nuestros libros</i>
feminine	<i>nuestra casa</i>	<i>nuestras casas</i>

So it is *nuestro coche* (“our car,” masculine) but *nuestra casa* (“our house,” feminine) — you match the noun in both gender and number, just as with *bueno/buena/buenos/buenas*. Say the full set aloud: *nuestro · nuestra · nuestros · nuestras*, then attach nouns — *nuestro coche*, *nuestra casa*, *nuestros amigos*.

11.5 Practice — wanting, being able, and the boot

Two power-verbs and a rule: *querer* (want, *e*→*ie*), *poder* (can, *o*→*ue*), and the stem-change boot that shapes them both — plus *nuestro*, the fully-agreeing “our.” Drill the cracks until *quiero* and *puedo* come without thinking.

Conjugate both boots, out loud. *querer* ($e \rightarrow ie$): *quiero* · *quieres* · *quiere* · *queremos* · *quieren* — only *queremos* stays plain. *poder* ($o \rightarrow ue$): *puedo* · *puedes* · *puede* · *podemos* · *pueden* — only *podemos* stays plain.

Chain the verbs (want to / can + infinitive):

Quiero hablar español. — “I want to speak Spanish.”

Puedo hablar un poco. — “I can speak a little.”

¿Quieres comer? — “Do you want to eat?”

¿Puedes venir? — “Can you come?”

Vamos a poder. — “We’re going to be able to.”

nuestro, agreeing: *nuestra casa* (feminine), *nuestro coche* (masculine), *nuestros amigos* (masculine plural) — match gender *and* number, unlike *mi/tu/su*.

Say something real:

— *¿Qué quieres hacer?*

— *Quiero ir a un café con nuestros amigos. ¿Puedes venir?*

— *Sí, puedo. Podemos ir ahora.*

Every tool of the chapter is in there:

- *quiero*: want, with the $e \rightarrow ie$ crack;
- *puedes*, *puedo*, and *podemos*: can, with the $o \rightarrow ue$ crack;
- *nuestros*: our, with agreement; and
- *ir a*: the near future.

Why it’s said this way

querer does double duty: aimed at a thing it means “to want,” but aimed at a person it means “to love.” *Te quiero* is one of the warmest things one Spanish speaker can say to another — the same verb that orders a coffee. The seeking root never left: to want someone and to seek someone are one word.

What you have built this chapter: *querer* (want, ← *quaerere* “seek” → **query** / **quest** / **conquer**), the $e \rightarrow ie$ stem-changer; *poder* (can, ← *potēre* → **power** / **potent** / **possible**), the $o \rightarrow ue$ stem-changer, plus *poder* + infinitive

for ability; **the boot** — one sound-law (short stressed $e \rightarrow ie$, $o \rightarrow ue$; *tierra*, *puerta*) cracking all forms but *nosotros/vosotros*; and *nuestro/vuestro* ($\leftarrow$ *noster/voster* $\rightarrow$ **Paternoster**), the possessive that agrees in gender *and* number, four forms. The next chapter carries the grammar forward — the course now runs on rules.

Chapter 12

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Two workhorse verbs — one for *doing* and *making*, one for *saying* — and the strange little club they belong to, where the “I” form grows a hard *g* out of nowhere. Learn the club once and six of the language’s most-used verbs stop being surprises. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C12-*.md.*

12.1 *hacer* — “to do / to make,” and the *yo*-form that grows a *g*

English splits the work between two verbs: you *do* homework but you *make* coffee. Spanish uses one verb for both — **hacer**. It is one of the language’s workhorses, and it hides two patterns worth naming.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer (“to do, to make”) ← Latin *facere* (“to do, to make”). Spanish softened the Latin *f*- into an *h*- that is now completely silent — the same change that turned *fabulārī* into *hablar* (“to speak”) and *filium* into *hijo* (“son”).

The English family from *facere* is enormous: **fact** (“a thing done”), **factory** (“a place of making”), **manufacture** (“made by hand”), **feat**, **feature**.

With prefixes: **affect** and **effect** (*ad*- and *ex*- + *fac*-), **perfect** (“thoroughly done”), **satisfy** (“make enough”), **difficult** (“not easy to do”), **benefit** (“do well”).

So *hacer* and **factory** are the same “make” root — one worn down inside

Spanish, one kept crisp on its way into English through Latin.

Sounds you'll need

The *h* in *hacer* is **silent**. Say it *a-THER* (Spain) or *a-SER* (Latin America) — never with an English *h* sound. That silent *h* is the ghost of the Latin *f*: the letter stayed on the page long after the sound left the mouth.

Grammar Lens

hacer behaves normally through most of the present tense — but the *yo* (“I”) form is irregular: it grows a **g**, giving **hago**. This is not a one-off. It is the same move you saw in *tener* → *tengo*: a small, very high-frequency club of “-go” verbs.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	hago	irregular — grows a <i>g</i>
tú (you, informal)	haces	regular
él / ella / usted (he, she, you-formal)	hace	regular
nosotros (we)	hacemos	regular
ellos / ustedes (they, you-plural)	hacen	regular

The *g* appears in *hago* and nowhere else.

Why it's said this way

The weather is something Spanish *makes*. Where English says “it is hot,” Spanish says *hace calor* — literally “it makes heat.” So too *hace frío* (“it’s cold,” “it makes cold”) and *hace sol* (“it’s sunny,” “it makes sun”). And the all-purpose everyday question: *¿Qué haces?* — “What are you doing?”

12.2 *decir* — “to say,” the verb with two irregularities at once

decir (“to say / to tell”) is the trickiest verb so far — and the most instructive, because it stacks *two* separate patterns onto one word: the *-go* ending you just met in *hago*, and a change inside the stem (the part of the verb before the ending). Learn *decir* and the whole system clicks together.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir (“to say, to tell”) ← Latin *dīcere* (“to say, to tell, to point out”). Its root *dic-* / *dict-* (“say”) runs straight through English.

Plain: dictate, diction, dictionary, dictaphone — every one of them about *saying*.

With prefixes: predict (“say beforehand”), contradict (“say against”), verdict (“a true saying”), indicate (“point out”), dedicate, edict, index.

So *decir* is the “say” root sitting inside **dictionary** itself — the book of what words *say*.

Sounds you’ll need

In *decir* the stressed stem vowel *e* does *not* break into two vowels. Instead it **closes to *i***: *digo*, *dices*, *dice*. Keep it a single tight *ee* sound — no glide, no second vowel.

Grammar Lens

Irregularity one: the *-go yo*-form. Exactly like *hago* and *tengo*, the “I” form grows a *g*: **digo**.

Irregularity two: the stem change $e \rightarrow i$. In the forms where the stress lands on the stem, that *e* closes to *i* — a tighter shift than the $e \rightarrow ie$ of *querer*.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	 digo 	-go form; stem also $\rightarrow i$
tú (you, informal)	 dices 	$e \rightarrow i$
él / ella / usted (he, she, you-formal)	 dice 	$e \rightarrow i$
nosotros (we)	decimos	plain e — unstressed
ellos / ustedes (they, you-plural)	 dicen 	$e \rightarrow i$

The **boot** shape returns: draw a line around the changed forms on the table and they make a boot, with *decimos* standing outside it. Only *decimos* keeps the plain e , because there the stress falls on the ending rather than the stem. Everything inside the boot shifts to i — and the *yo* corner carries the -go on top of that.

Why it's said this way

The single most useful question a learner owns: *¿Cómo se dice ...?* — “How do you say ...?” It lets you build your own vocabulary out loud, from anyone, forever. Its close companion is *dime* — “tell me.”

12.3 The -go club — one irregular corner, many verbs

You have now met three verbs whose *yo*-form ends in a surprising -go: *tener* $\rightarrow$ **tengo**, *hacer* $\rightarrow$ **hago**, *decir* $\rightarrow$ **digo**. That is not three coincidences — it is a **club**. Learn the membership once and you never have to re-learn the shape.

Grammar Lens

Most Spanish verbs build a tidy *yo*-form: *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”). But a small set of very common verbs **grow a hard g** in the *yo*-form only. The rest of the present tense behaves normally.

Verb	Meaning	<i>yo</i> -form	Met it?
tener	to have	tengo	yes — Chapter 8
hacer	to do / to make	hago	yes — this chapter
decir	to say	digo	yes — this chapter
poner	to put	pongo	coming
salir	to leave / go out	salgo	coming
venir	to come	vengo	coming

Three you know, three still to come — and every one follows the same rule: **-go in the *yo*-form, regular elsewhere**, with any stem-change stacked on top, as in *digo*.

Why it's said this way

Why the *g*? A Latin fossil. The *g* is an inheritance. Latin's first-person forms and old sound-laws left a **velar** sound — a *g* or *k* made at the back of the mouth — clinging to these particular verbs, and Spanish tidied it into a clean *-go*. You do not need the history to use them, but it explains why the club is old and closed: these are among the *most-used verbs in the language*, and the oldest, most-used words are exactly the ones that keep their irregularities. English does the same thing — **am** / **was**, **go** / **went**.

12.4 Practice — doing, making, saying

This chapter added two workhorse verbs — *hacer* (“do / make”) and *decir* (“say”) — and the *-go* club that unites their *yo*-forms with *tengo*. Time to make them automatic.

Drill 1 — the *-go yo*-forms. Say the *yo*-form for each, then the *tú*-form, which drops the *g*:

Verb	<i>yo</i>	<i>tú</i>
<i>hacer</i>	hago	haces
<i>decir</i>	digo	dices (mind the $e \rightarrow i$)
<i>tener</i>	tengo	tienes (mind the $e \rightarrow ie$)

What do all three *yo*-forms share? The *-go*. And what happens to it in the *tú*-form? It *drops* — the *-go* is *yo*-only.

Drill 2 — say the full present. Run each verb top to bottom: *hacer*: hago · haces · hace · hacemos · hacen. *decir*: digo · dices · dice · decimos · dicen — the boot again, with only *decimos* keeping the plain *e*.

Drill 3 — put it to use. Say each one out loud:

¿Qué haces? — “What are you doing?”

Hago la tarea. — “I’m doing the homework.”

¿Cómo se dice “window”? — “How do you say ‘window’?”

Hace frío hoy. — “It’s cold today” (weather with *hacer* — “it makes cold”).

Drill 4 — the root families. Name an English cousin from the same Latin root: *hacer* ← *facere* → **fact, factory, perfect, manufacture** — any of them. *decir* ← *dicere* → **dictate, diction, predict, verdict** — any of them.

Recall. Give the *yo*-forms of *hacer*, *decir*, and *tener* (*hago, digo, tengo* — the *-go* club). In *decir*, which form escapes the *e* → *i* boot, and why? (*decimos* — the stress falls on the ending.) How does Spanish say “it’s hot”? (*Hace calor.*) You can now *do, make, and say* in Spanish — and you have seen that the language’s most irregular verbs are its most-used, oldest words.

Chapter 13

Poner, Salir, Venir — Completing the -go Club

Three verbs remain in the small club of Spanish verbs whose *I* form grows an extra **g**: *pongo, salgo, vengo*. They hide a Latin “place” root, a Latin “leap” root, and a Latin “come” root — and the last of them stacks *two* irregularities at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C13-*.md.*

13.1 *poner* — “to put,” and the club gains a member

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner (“to put / to place”) ← Latin *pōnere*, “to put, to place, to set down.” Its stem *pon-/pos-* (“place”) is one of the busiest roots in English.

Bare: **position**, **pose**, **posit** — each one a *placing*.

With prefixes: **compose** (“place together”), **deposit** (“place down”), **expose** (“place out”), **oppose** / **opponent** (“place against”), **propose** (“place forward”), **postpone** (“place after”), **component**.

So *poner* and **position** share the same “place” root — when you *poner* something, you are putting it in its *pōnere*.

Grammar Lens

A verb’s **infinitive** is its plain naming form (“to put”), and Spanish infinitives end in *-ar*, *-er*, or *-ir*. *poner* is an *-er* verb, and it behaves like a perfectly regular one *everywhere except* the *yo* (“I”) form, which

grows a **g**: **pongo**. That single odd corner is what marks a verb as a member of the *-go* club, alongside *tengo* (“I have”), *hago* (“I do/make”), and *digo* (“I say”).

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	pongo	<i>-go</i> , like <i>tengo</i>
tú (you, informal)	pones	regular
él / ella / usted	pone	regular
nosotros (we)	ponemos	regular
ellos / ustedes	ponen	regular

Sounds you’ll need

The *g* in **pongo** is a *hard g*, as in English *go* — never the soft *g* of English *gem*. The same hard *-go* you hear in *tengo*.

Why it’s said this way

The everyday payoff: *poner la mesa* (“to set the table”), *poner música* (“to put on music”), and the reflexive *ponerse* — “to put on (clothes)” or “to become”: *me pongo nervioso*, “I get nervous.” One verb covers setting, playing, dressing, and becoming.

13.2 *salir* — “to go out,” from a verb that meant “to leap”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir (“to leave, to go out”) ← Latin *salīre*, “to leap, to jump, to spring.” Over time “leaping out” softened into simply “going out” — but the leap survives all across English.

Bare: **salient** (“leaping out,” so: prominent, sticking out), **sally** (“a sudden rush out”), **somersault** (*sopra* + *saltus*, “a leap over”).

With prefixes: **assail** / **assault** (“leap at”), **resilient** (“leap back”), **result** (“leap back out”), **insult** (“leap upon”).

And a fish: *salīre* gave Latin *salmō*, “the leaper,” for the **salmon** that leaps upstream.

So every time you say *salgo* (“I go out”), you are using the old *leap* verb behind **salient** and **salmon**.

Grammar Lens

salir is an *-ir* verb, and the story is exactly *poner*’s: regular everywhere but the *yo* form, which grows the **g** — **salgo**.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	salgo	<i>-go</i> , like <i>pongo</i> / <i>tengo</i>
tú (you, informal)	sales	regular
él / ella / usted	sale	regular
nosotros (we)	salimos	regular
ellos / ustedes	salen	regular

Why it’s said this way

salir de casa is “to leave the house”; *salir con alguien* is “to go out with someone” — that is, to date. And *la salida* is “the **exit**” — the sign you will read at every station. Note that English *exit* comes from a *different* Latin verb, *exīre* (“go out”); Spanish chose the *leaping* one instead.

13.3 *venir* — “to come,” cracked *and* g-grown

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir (“to come”) ← Latin *venīre*, “to come.” Its root *ven-/vent-* comes toward English from every direction:

adventure (*ad-venīre*, “what *comes to you*”), **event** (“what comes out”), **convene** / **convention** (“come together”), **invent** (“come upon”), **prevent** (“come before”), **intervene**, **revenue** (“what *comes back*”), **avenue** (“a coming-toward”), and **souvenir** (from French, “a thing that *comes to mind*”).

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venir is **doubly irregular** — it stacks two changes at once.

(1) The *-go yo* form, like *pongo* / *salgo* / *tengo*: **vengo**.

(2) The $e \rightarrow ie$ stem-change. The **stem** is the part of the verb before the ending — here *ven-*. When the stress of the word falls on that stem, its *e* breaks apart into *ie*: *vienes*, *viene*, *vienen*. When the stress falls on the ending instead, the *e* stays plain: *venimos*.

Write the five forms in a column and the changed ones outline the shape of a **boot**: everything cracks to *ie* except *venimos*, which sits outside it, and the *yo* corner carries the *-go*.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	vengo	the <i>-go</i> form
tú (you, informal)	vienes	$e \rightarrow ie$
él / ella / usted	viene	$e \rightarrow ie$
nosotros (we)	venimos	plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	vienen	$e \rightarrow ie$

Sounds you'll need

Two things to hear. The *g* of **vengo** is the hard *-go* again. And *ie* is a **diphthong** — two vowel sounds glided together in one syllable: *vienes* is *vee-EH-nes*.

This is the exact shape of *tener* (*tengo* / *tienes*) — *venir* is its mirror twin: *Vengo de España* (“I come from Spain”), ¿*Vienes?* (“Are you coming?”).

13.4 The club is complete

All six members, in one place: *tengo* · *hago* · *digo* · *pongo* · *salgo* · *vengo*. Every one of them is irregular in the *yo* form only — the rest of each verb is regular, plus whatever stem-change it carries.

Infinitive	<i>yo</i> form	Kind
hacer (to do/make)	hago	plain <i>-go</i>
poner (to put)	pongo	plain <i>-go</i>
salir (to go out)	salgo	plain <i>-go</i>
decir (to say)	digo	<i>-go</i> + $e \rightarrow i$ (dices/dice)
tener (to have)	tengo	<i>-go</i> + $e \rightarrow ie$ (tienes)
venir (to come)	vengo	<i>-go</i> + $e \rightarrow ie$ (vienes)

The two $e \rightarrow ie$ twins run side by side, and only the *we* forms keep the plain *e* — the boot again:

<i>tener</i>	<i>venir</i>
tengo	vengo
tienes	vienes
tiene	viene
tenemos	venimos
tienen	vienen

Now put them to work. Say each aloud:

Vengo de casa y pongo la mesa. — “*I come from home and set the table.*”

Salgo a las ocho. — “*I leave at eight.*”

¿Qué haces? — *Hago la cena.* — “*What are you doing? — I’m making dinner.*”

Digo que sí. — “*I say yes.*”

And one English cousin for each new root: *poner* $\leftarrow$ *pōnere* $\rightarrow$ **position** / **compose** / **deposit**; *salir* $\leftarrow$ *salīre* $\rightarrow$ **salient** / **salmon** / **somersault**; *venir* $\leftarrow$ *venīre* $\rightarrow$ **adventure** / **event** / **convene**. You now hold the whole irregular *-go* corner of Spanish — its oldest, most-used verbs, mastered as one pattern.

Chapter 14

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Until now everything you have said lived in the present. This chapter crosses into “what happened”: the **preterite**, Spanish’s everyday past. It opens with the strangest fact in the language — “I was” and “I went” are the same word — and closes with a pattern that covers thousands of verbs and hangs on a single accent mark. *Practice lessons: [lessons/ES-C14-*.md](#).*

14.1 *fui* — the past arrives, and two verbs become one

Spanish’s everyday past tense is called the **preterite**: “I spoke, I went, I was” — an action finished, sealed off, done. And it opens with the most memorable oddity in the whole language: the verbs *ser* (“to be”) and *ir* (“to go”) have the *exact same* preterite. *Fui* means both “**I was**” and “**I went**.”

<i>ser / ir</i> (the same!)	
yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él / ella / usted	fue
nosotros	fuimos
ellos / ustedes	fueron

One set of forms, *two* verbs. There is no separate past for “to go” — Spanish simply reuses “to be.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fui ← Latin *fuī*, “I have been.” Here is the twist: Latin had *two* different roots for “to be.” The present *sum* / *es* / *est* (which became *soy* / *eres* / *es*) came from the ancient root PIE **es-*. The perfect *fuī* came from a *different* root, PIE **b^huH-*, “to grow, to become” — and that is the very root of English **be** and **been**, and (by way of Greek and Latin) **future** and **physics**.

Spanish stitched the two roots into a single verb. That patchwork is called **suppletion** — the same thing English does with *go* / *went*, two unrelated words serving one verb.

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Then *ir* (“to go”) borrowed *fuī* as well, because Latin’s own past of *īre* (“to go”) had worn away to almost nothing. So “to be” and “to go” *merged* in the past tense, and only **context** tells them apart:

Fui a Madrid. — “I **went** to Madrid.” (movement → *ir*)

Fui profesor. — “I **was** a teacher.” (a state → *ser*)

The giveaway is usually what follows: *a* + a place means going; a description or a role means being.

Sounds you’ll need

stress-final — the preterite loves the *final* syllable. *fui* and *fue* are single syllables; then *fuiste*, *fuimos*, *fueron*. Say the set aloud pushing the weight to the end: *fui* · *fuiste* · *fue* · *fuimos* · *fueron*.

diphthong -ui- — *ui* is one glide, not two beats: “fwee,” not “foo-ee.”

14.2 *hablé* — the regular past, built on an accent

Fui was irregular — a one-off you memorize. Now the **pattern** that covers thousands of verbs. Take any regular *-ar* verb, drop the *-ar*, and add the preterite endings. The whole tense hangs on one small mark: the **accent**.

Drop *-ar* from **hablar** (“to speak”) and add:

preterite		
yo	hablé	(accent on é)
tú	hablaste	
él / ella / usted	habló	(accent on ó)
nosotros	hablamos	(no accent)
ellos / ustedes	hablaron	

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Set this beside the **present** tense of the same verb — *hablo, hablas, habla* — and the difference is almost entirely *where the stress lands*: *HA-blo* (“I speak,” now) versus *ha-BLÉ* (“I spoke,” done). The written accent is not decoration; it **carries the tense**. Move the stress to the end and the past tense announces itself.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These endings are worn-down Latin **perfect** forms. Latin *amāvī* (“I loved”) → *amé*; *amāvistī* → *amaste*; *amāvit* → *amó*. The *-āv-* in the middle dissolved away and left behind the *stressed final vowel* that Spanish now crowns with an accent.

So *hablé* is Latin (*fabulāvī*) with the middle chewed away — the same erosion you have watched all along, this time applied to an entire tense.

Why it’s said this way

One trap — *hablamos*. The *nosotros* form is *identical* in present and preterite: *hablamos* is both “we speak” and “we spoke.” Nothing in the word itself decides. Only **context** — or a time-word such as *ayer* (“yesterday”) — tells them apart: *hablamos ayer* = “we spoke yesterday.” Spanish speakers lean on *ayer, anoche, el año pasado* to do the work the verb ending leaves undone.

Sounds you’ll need

accent-acute — the written ´ marks the *stressed* vowel: *habl-É, habl-Ó*. Practise the flip: *hablo* → *hablé*, *habla* → *habló*. Then a full sentence: *Ayer hablé con María* (“Yesterday I spoke with María”).

14.3 Practice — past against present

This chapter gave you the past: the shared *ser/ir* preterite (*fui*) and the regular *-ar* pattern (*hablé*). The skill now is switching between *now* and *then* without stumbling.

Drill 1 — say the two paradigms. *fui · fuiste · fue · fuimos · fueron*. Then: *hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablaron*.

Drill 2 — the accent flips the tense. Say each present form, then its preterite twin; the stress jumps to the end.

present		preterite
<i>hablo</i> (I speak)	→	<i>hablé</i> (I spoke)
<i>habla</i> (s/he speaks)	→	<i>habló</i> (s/he spoke)
<i>trabajo</i> (I work)	→	<i>trabajé</i> (I worked)

What one thing changed? The **accent** — the stressed syllable moved to the end.

Drill 3 — *ser* or *ir*? Context decides.

Fui a la escuela. → *ir* — “I went.”

Fui estudiante. → *ser* — “I was a student.”

Ella fue muy amable. → *ser* — “She was very kind.”

Ellos fueron a España. → *ir* — “They went.”

Drill 4 — put it to use. Say each aloud:

Ayer hablé con mi madre. — “Yesterday I spoke with my mother.”

Fui al mercado y compré pan. — “I went to the market and bought bread.”

Fuimos amigos. — “We were friends.”

Which two verbs share *fui* / *fue*? *Ser* and *ir*. How does the accent turn *hablo* into *habló*? It moves the stress to the end — present becomes preterite. And in *Fui a casa*, be or go? Go — *ir*. You can now speak in the past: the course has crossed from “what is” to “what happened.”

Chapter 15

Completing the Preterite — Three Families, One Question

The past tense finishes here. The *-er* and *-ir* verbs hand you a gift — one set of endings for two conjugations — and then a handful of very old verbs pull the stress backwards and drop their accents entirely. One question sorts all of them: where does the stress land? *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C15-*.md.*

15.1 *comí, viví* — two conjugations become one

You have the *-ar* past (*hablé*, “I spoke”). Now the other two families. Here Spanish does you a favour it never does in the present tense: *-er* and *-ir* verbs take the *exact same* preterite endings. Learn one set, get both.

Drop the *-er* or *-ir* from the infinitive, and add *-í, -iste, -ió, -imos, -ieron*.

person	<i>comer</i> (“to eat”)	<i>vivir</i> (“to live”)
<i>yo</i> (I)	comí	viví
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	comiste	viviste
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	comió	vivió
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	comimos	vivimos
<i>ellos / ustedes</i> (they / you all)	comieron	vivieron

Look down the two columns: the endings are *identical*. That is not true in the present, where *-er* and *-ir* pull apart (*comemos* versus *vivimos*). In the past, the two conjugations **merge**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These endings are worn-down Latin **perfect** forms — *-ī*, *-istī*, *-it*. The middle one barely changed at all: Latin *-istī* → Spanish *-iste* (*comiste*, *viviste*). Two thousand years, one dropped vowel.

Sounds you'll need

The written accent marks the **stressed final vowel**: *comí*, *comió*. Say them with the loudness at the very end of the word. Stress at the end = the past.

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One trap. For *-ir* verbs, the *nosotros* form is the *same* in present and preterite: *vivimos* means both “we live” and “we lived” (just like *hablamos* in the previous chapter). But for *-er* verbs it differs: *comemos* (“we eat”) versus *comimos* (“we ate”). One vowel does the whole job.

Try it aloud: *comí*, *comiste*, *comió*, *comimos*, *comieron*; then *viví*, *viviste*, *vivió*, *vivimos*, *vivieron* — hear the same endings. Then a whole sentence: *Ayer comí paella* (“Yesterday I ate paella”).

15.2 *tuve*, *hice*, *estuve* — the strong preterites

Everything so far pushed the stress *to the end*: *hablé*, *comí*, *comió*. Now meet the verbs that do the opposite. They pull the stress *back into the stem* — and so they lose their accent marks entirely. Spanish calls them *pretéritos fuertes*, “**strong**” preterites: strong because the *stem* carries the weight.

The stem changes, and then one shared set of endings follows: *-e*, *-iste*, *-o*, *-imos*, *-ieron*.

person	<i>tener</i> → <i>tuv-</i>	<i>hacer</i> → <i>hic-</i>	<i>estar</i> → <i>estuv-</i>
<i>yo</i>	tuve	hice	estuve
<i>tú</i>	tuviste	hiciste	estuviste
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	tuvo	hizo	estuvo
<i>nosotros</i>	tuvimos	hicimos	estuvimos
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	tuvieron	hicieron	estuvieron

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The accent rule, inverted. Compare the *yo* and *él* forms across the three families.

family	<i>yo</i>	<i>él / ella</i>	stressed syllable	accent?
-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	hablé	habló	the ending	yes
-er / -ir (<i>comer</i>)	comí	comió	the ending	yes
strong (<i>tener</i>)	TU ve	TU vo	the stem	no

Sounds you'll need

Say them out loud back to back: *habló ... TUvo*. The written accent isn't decoration — it is telling you *where the stress went*. There is no accent on a strong preterite because the stress never left the stem.

Note the *yo* ending too: -e, not -é — *tuve*, not *tuvé*.

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One spelling swerve. *Hacer* gives **hizo**, not *hico* — Spanish swaps *c* → *z* before *o* to keep the sound the same. The letter changes so the pronunciation won't.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Why are these irregular? Because they are **old**. Latin had two ways to build a perfect, and these verbs kept the “strong” one, inherited whole rather than rebuilt: *tenuī* → **tuve**, *fēcī* → **hice**, *stetī / stāre* → **estuve**.

The regular -ar / -er / -ir patterns are the tidy replacements that spread later; the strong verbs are the most-used ones, worn smooth by frequency and never re-made. Notice that *tuv-* and *estuv-* even share the same -*uv*-shape.

Say them aloud: *tuve, tuviste, tuvo, tuvimos, tuvieron*; then *hice, hiciste, hizo* — hear the *z*. Then the contrast pair, *habló ... TUvo*. And a sentence: *Ayer estuve en casa* (“Yesterday I was at home”).

15.3 Practice — three families, one question

You now have the *entire* everyday past tense. Three families — and one question sorts them: **where does the stress land?**

	<i>yo</i>	<i>tú</i>	<i>él / ella</i>	<i>nosotros</i>	<i>ellos</i>
-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	hablé	hablaste	habló	hablamos	hablaron
-er (<i>comer</i>)	comí	comiste	comió	comimos	comieron
-ir (<i>vivir</i>)	viví	viviste	vivió	vivimos	vivieron
strong (<i>tener</i>)	tuve	tuviste	tuvo	tuvimos	tuvieron
<i>ser / ir</i>	fui	fuiste	fue	fuimos	fueron

Two things to notice. First, rows two and three are the *same* — *-er* and *-ir* merged. Second, only the first three rows carry accents, and only on *yo* and *él*. Those are exactly the forms where the stress is on the ending.

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The stress test. Read any preterite and ask: is the loud syllable the *last* one?

Yes → regular. Accent on *yo* and *él / ella* (*hablé, habló, comí, comió*).

No, it's the stem → **strong**. No accent (*TUve, HIce, ESTUvo*).

Some forms live in both tenses, and only context decides.

form	could be	which?
<i>hablamos</i>	we speak / we spoke	either — context decides
<i>vivimos</i>	we live / we lived	either — context decides
<i>comemos / comimos</i>	we eat / we ate	distinct — the vowel tells you
<i>fui</i>	I was / I went	either — <i>ser</i> and <i>ir</i> share it

Practise aloud: the *yo* forms straight down all five rows — *hablé, comí, viví, tuve, fui*. Then whole sentences: *Ayer hablé con mi madre y comí en casa* (“Yesterday I spoke with my mother and ate at home”); *Hice la comida* (“I made the food”) — stem stress, no accent; *Fui al mercado* (“I went to the market”). Finally say the diagnostic itself: last syllable loud → accent; stem loud → none.

Next chapter: talking about the past that *kept going* — the imperfect.

Chapter 16

The Imperfect — the Past That Kept Going

One past tense says a thing finished; this one says a thing was *going on*. It is also the most regular tense in the language, with exactly three irregular verbs in the whole of Spanish — and then one genuinely new distinction to learn to think in. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C16-*.md.*

16.1 *hablaba, comía* — the past that kept going

A **tense** is the shape a verb takes to place an action in time. Spanish has two ordinary past tenses. The **preterite** reports that a past thing **finished**: *hablé*, “I spoke.” The **imperfect** reports that a past thing was **going on**, or happened over and over: “I **was speaking**,” “I **used to speak**.” That is what this whole chapter is about.

And here is the good news: the imperfect is the **most regular tense in the language**. Drop the infinitive ending (*-ar, -er, -ir*) and add one of two sets of endings.

Person	<i>-ar</i> (<i>hablar</i>)	<i>-er</i> / <i>-ir</i> (<i>comer, vivir</i>)
yo	habl aba	com ía / viv ía
tú	hablab as	com ías
él / ella / usted	hablab a	com ía
nosotros	habláb amos	com íamos
ellos / ustedes	hablab an	com ían

The ***-er*** and ***-ir*** verbs share one set again — the third time now (they also shared in the preterite). Two conjugations, one pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba ← Latin *-ābam* · **-ía** ← Latin *-ēbam*.

Same Latin ending, two fates. The *b* survived whole in *-aba* (*-ābam* → *-aba*), but wore away in the other set (*-ēbam* → *-ea* → *-ía*). One sound, two outcomes, inside the same language.

Sounds you'll need

accent-acute — *hablábamos*: the stress falls **three syllables back** (*ha-BLÁ-ba-mos*), and Spanish writes an accent whenever it does. This is the *only* form in the *-ar* set that takes one.

hiatus-ia — *comía*: here the accent **splits the vowels**. Without it, *ia* would be a single syllable (as in *piano*); with it, *co-mí-a* is three. **Every** form in the *-er/-ir* set needs it.

Grammar Lens

One trap, and a broken rule. *Yo hablaba* and *él hablaba* are **identical** — the ending no longer tells you who is speaking. Spanish normally *drops* its subject pronouns, because the ending carries the person; in the imperfect the ending stopped doing that job, so the pronoun steps back in. You will hear *yo* said out loud here far more often than in the present tense.

Say them straight through: *hablaba, hablabas, hablaba, hablábamos, hablaban · comía, comías, comía, comíamos, comían*. And in a sentence: *Cuando era niño, hablaba español en casa* (“When I was a child, I used to speak Spanish at home”).

16.2 *era, iba, veía* — all three of them

The preterite hands you a pile of strong, irregular forms to memorise. Here is the compensation: the imperfect has **three** irregular verbs. Not three families — **three verbs**, in the entire language.

Person	<i>ser</i> → era	<i>ir</i> → iba	<i>ver</i> → veía
yo	era	iba	veía
tú	eras	ibas	veías
él / ella / usted	era	iba	veía
nosotros	éramos	íbamos	veíamos
ellos / ustedes	eran	iban	veían

That is the entire irregular inventory. Every other verb in Spanish — thousands of them — takes the regular endings from the last section.

And *ver* barely counts: it simply keeps an extra *-e-* from its older form *veer*, then conjugates normally (*ve-* + *-ía*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

era ← Latin *eram*, from the same *es-* root that gives *ser*, *soy*, *es* — and English **is** and **are**. So *ser* uses that ancient root in the present *and* the imperfect, but jumps to a different verb entirely, Latin *fuī*, in the preterite: *era* versus *fue*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

***ir*'s third Latin verb.** Spanish *ir* (“to go”) is stitched together out of **three different Latin verbs**, one per tense:

present *voy*, *vas*, *va* ← Latin *vādere*, “to advance”

preterite *fui*, *fuiste*, *fue* ← Latin *fuī*, from *esse*

imperfect ***iba*, *ibas*, *iba*** ← Latin *īre* — *ir*'s **own infinitive**

The imperfect is the **one place** the original *īre* survives conjugated. The infinitive *ir* and the imperfect *iba* are the last two pieces of the real verb; everything else was borrowed from elsewhere.

Sounds you'll need

stress-antepenultimate — **éramos** and **íbamos** take a written accent for exactly the reason *hablábamos* does: the stress lands three syllables back (*É-ra-mos*, *Í-ba-mos*). Those two are the only accented forms in the irregular set apart from *ver*, whose accent is the vowel-splitting kind (*ve-í-a*).

Say them: *era*, *eras*, *era*, *éramos*, *eran* · *iba*, *ibas*, *iba*, *íbamos*, *iban*. In a sentence: *Cuando era niño, iba a la escuela* (“When I was a child, I used

to go to school”). And say the three sources out loud: *voy* ← *vādere* · *fui* ← *fuī* · *iba* ← *īre*.

16.3 Practice — two pasts, one choice

You now have **both** past tenses. English marks this difference only sometimes, and never with an ending — so this is a genuinely **new distinction** to think in, not merely new forms to learn.

	preterite	imperfect
what it does	a completed event	an ongoing or habitual state
shape of time	a point	a line
English	“I ate”	“I was eating” / “I used to eat”
typical clues	<i>ayer, una vez, de repente</i>	<i>siempre, todos los días, mientras</i>

Comí = the meal happened and ended. **Comía** = I was in the middle of it, or I did it regularly.

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Background and interruption. The classic pairing: the imperfect sets the scene, the preterite breaks it.

Hablaba con María cuando llegó Juan. (“I was talking to María when Juan arrived.”)

The talking is the **line**; the arriving is the **point** that lands on it. Swap the two tenses and the sentence stops making sense.

Why it’s said this way

Verbs that change meaning. With a few verbs the choice does not just shift the shape of time — it changes **what the word means**. The logic is consistent: the imperfect gives you the *state*, the preterite gives you the *instant the state began*. Knowing → the moment of finding out.

verb	imperfect (state)	preterite (the moment it started)
<i>saber</i>	<i>sabía</i> — I knew	<i>supe</i> — I found out
<i>conocer</i>	<i>conocía</i> — I knew (a person)	<i>conocí</i> — I met
<i>tener</i>	<i>tenía</i> — I had	<i>tuve</i> — I got, received
<i>querer</i>	<i>quería</i> — I wanted	<i>quise</i> — I tried

(And the negative sharpens it further: *no quise* = “I **refused**.”)

Drill — **which tense?** Decide before you read the answer.

sentence	tense
“Every summer we went to Spain.”	imperfect (<i>íbamos</i>) — habitual
“Yesterday we went to Spain.”	preterite (<i>fuimos</i>) — one event
“She was tall.”	imperfect (<i>era</i>) — a lasting state
“The concert was yesterday.”	preterite (<i>fue</i>) — a bounded event

Say these aloud: *Comía cuando llamaste* (“I was eating when you called”) · the pair *sabía* “I knew” ... *supe* “I found out” · *Cuando era niño, iba a la playa todos los veranos.*

Recall it all: preterite or imperfect for a **habit**? (**Imperfect.**) Which tense sets the background, and which interrupts it? (Imperfect **sets**, preterite **interrupts**.) What is the difference between *conocía* and *conocí*? (“I **knew** someone” versus “I **met** them.”) How many irregular imperfects are there? (**Three.**) And the one-word test, the thing to keep: **line** → imperfect; **point** → preterite. Next chapter: talking about what **will** happen.

Chapter 17

The Future and the Conditional — One Weld, Twice

Two whole tenses built from a single trick: glue an infinitive to the verb “to have.” Use the present of “have” and you get the future; use its past and you get “would.” One machine, one part swapped, and a seam you can still see. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C17-*.md.*

17.1 *hablaré* — the future, welded shut

A **tense** is the shape a verb takes to say *when* something happens. Spanish has two ways to talk about what is coming. One you can already build out of small parts — *voy a hablar*, “I am going to speak.” The other is a single word, and it has the best origin story of any Spanish tense.

Grammar Lens

The **infinitive** is a verb’s plain dictionary form — *hablar* (“to speak”), *comer* (“to eat”), *vivir* (“to live”). Every other Spanish tense begins by *stripping* that ending off: you cut *-ar* from *hablar* and build on *habl-*.

The future does not. It keeps the infinitive whole and stacks endings on top of it. And because the infinitive stays intact, *one* set of endings serves all three verb families: *hablar* → *hablaré*, *comer* → *comeré*, *vivir* → *viviré*.

Person	Future of <i>hablar</i>
<i>yo</i> (I)	<i>hablaré</i>
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	<i>hablarás</i>
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>hablará</i>
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	<i>hablaremos</i>
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	<i>hablarán</i>

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablaré is not one piece but two, fused: *hablar* + *he*. That *he* is “I have,” the present tense of *haber* (“to have”) ← Latin *habēre* — the root English borrowed in **habit** (“what one has”), **habitat**, **inhabit**, **able** and **ability** (from *habēre*’s compound *habēlis*, “handy to have”), **prohibit**, **exhibit**.

Latin had its own future — *amābō*, “I will love” — and it **died out**. Speakers replaced it with a phrase:

amāre habeo — “*I have to love*” → “*I will love*.”

Infinitive + the verb *habēre*, “to have.” This is exactly the English “**I have to go**,” which also slides from obligation toward the future. Then the Spanish phrase **fused**. Say *hablar he* fast enough, often enough, for enough centuries, and it closes into one word.

Stage	Form
two words	<i>hablar + he</i>
squeezed	<i>hablar-he</i>
welded	<i>hablaré</i>

So the endings are not really endings. They are the present tense of *haber*, worn down to a suffix. Line the two lists up side by side:

<i>haber</i> (present)	Future ending
<i>he</i>	-é
<i>has</i>	-ás
<i>ha</i>	-á
<i>hemos</i>	-emos
<i>han</i>	-án

They are the same list. A **compound** tense — two words — that closed up into a **simple** one, a single word. That is the exact reverse of what French and Italian did with their compound past, which stayed open as two words.

Why it's said this way

The seam Spanish sealed over is still faintly open next door. Portuguese welded its future too (*falarei* is one word), but in **formal European Portuguese** a pronoun can still be lodged *inside* it:

falá-lo-ei — “I will speak it.”

That *-lo-* is sitting in the join, between *falar* and *ei*. It is a leftover, not the normal pattern — Brazilian Portuguese does not do it, and neither does ordinary speech. But it shows you the weld from the outside.

Sounds you'll need

Every future form except *nosotros* carries a written accent, and the accent falls on the very last syllable: *ha-bla-RÉ*, *ha-bla-RÁS*, *ha-bla-RÁN*. That final stress is the ghost of the second word — *he*, *has*, *han* — that used to stand there on its own.

hablaremos needs no accent: its stress already lands where Spanish expects it by default.

17.2 *hablaría* — the same weld, one tense over

Same machine, one part swapped. Whole infinitive again, new endings.

Person	Conditional of <i>hablar</i>
<i>yo</i>	<i>hablaría</i>
<i>tú</i>	<i>hablarías</i>
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>hablaría</i>
<i>nosotros</i>	<i>hablaríamos</i>
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	<i>hablarían</i>

Look hard at those endings: *-ía*, *-ías*, *-íamos*, *-ían*. They are exactly the *-er/-ir* **imperfect** endings — *comía*, *comías*, *comíamos*, *comían* (“I used to eat,” and so on).

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They are identical because they *are* the same. The future welds the infinitive to the **present** of *haber*; the conditional welds the same infinitive to the **imperfect** of *haber* — its “used to” past.

Tense	Infinitive +	Result
future	<i>haber</i> present (<i>he, has, ha...</i>)	<i>hablaré</i>
conditional	<i>haber</i> imperfect (<i>había, habías...</i>)	<i>hablaría</i>

Strictly, what fused was the older, shorter form *avía* — which is why you get *hablaría* and not *hablarhabía*. The modern *había* is the same word, un-worn. One trick, two tenses of the same auxiliary: that is the whole chapter.

Sounds you’ll need

The accent on *-ía* does real work. Left alone, *i* and *a* would glide together into one syllable. The accent **breaks** them apart, so *hablaría* is three-and-a-bit syllables — *ha-bla-RÍ-a* — with the stressed *í* standing on its own.

Now, what the conditional is *for*. Three jobs:

Use	Example	English
would — hypothetical	<i>Hablaría con él.</i>	“I would speak with him.”
politeness — softening	<i>¿Podrías ayudarme?</i>	“Could you help me?”
future-in-the-past	<i>Dijo que hablaría.</i>	“He said he would speak.”

Why it’s said this way

That third use is the neat one: measured from a point in the *past*, the conditional *is* the future — which makes sense once you remember that a past tense of *haber* is sitting inside it.

The second use is the one you will reach for daily. *Me gustaría...* (“I would like...”) is about the politest opening in Spanish: the conditional

turns a demand into a wish, in every language that has one.

17.3 Practice — ten stems, two tenses

A handful of verbs bend the infinitive before welding it. The good news: **the same bent stem serves both tenses**, so you learn ten shapes once and get twenty conjugations. They fall into three families.

1. Drop the vowel. The infinitive's last vowel simply goes.

Verb	Stem	Future	Conditional
<i>poder</i> (to be able)	<i>podr-</i>	<i>podré</i>	<i>podría</i>
<i>querer</i> (to want)	<i>querr-</i>	<i>querré</i>	<i>querría</i>
<i>saber</i> (to know)	<i>sabr-</i>	<i>sabré</i>	<i>sabría</i>
<i>haber</i> (to have)	<i>habr-</i>	<i>habré</i>	<i>habría</i>

2. Drop the vowel, then wedge in a *d*. Dropping alone would leave *-n'r-* or *-l'r-* jammed together, and Old Spanish refused to leave it that way — so a *d* slid in to prop the cluster apart.

Verb	Would be	Becomes	Future
<i>tener</i> (to have)	<i>ten-r-</i>	<i>tendr-</i>	<i>tendré</i>
<i>poner</i> (to put)	<i>pon-r-</i>	<i>pondr-</i>	<i>pondré</i>
<i>venir</i> (to come)	<i>ven-r-</i>	<i>vendr-</i>	<i>vendré</i>
<i>salir</i> (to leave)	<i>sal-r-</i>	<i>saldr-</i>	<i>saldré</i>

Sounds you'll need

It is not that modern Spanish cannot say those clusters — *honra*, *sonrisa*, *alrededor* are perfectly ordinary. It is that when this particular squeeze happened, the language fixed it.

It even tried a **second** solution first: medieval Spanish also said *terné*, *porné*, *verné*, swapping the two consonants around instead of inserting anything. The *d*-forms won.

Those four verbs — *tener*, *poner*, *venir*, *salir* — are all members of the **-go club** from Chapters 12–13, the verbs whose “I” form ends in *-go* (*tengo*, *pongo*, *vengo*, *salgo*). The club has six members, and the other two, *hacer* and *decir*, are sitting in family 3 below. So **all six of the -go verbs are**

irregular here too; they just split into two shapes. The oldest, most-used verbs misbehave in the same places over and over.

3. Chop hard. Two verbs shorten drastically.

Verb	Future	Conditional
<i>decir</i> (to say)	<i>diré</i>	<i>diría</i>
<i>hacer</i> (to do)	<i>haré</i>	<i>haría</i>

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Here is the test that covers every irregular in this chapter: they are irregular in the **stem only**. The endings never change.

irregular stem + the same *-é* / *-ás* / *-á* / *-emos* / *-án* (future) or *-ía* / *-ías* / *-íamos* / *-ían* (conditional).

One more use, and it surprises everyone: Spanish uses the **future** to express **present guessing**.

Spanish	Means
<i>¿Dónde estará Juan?</i>	“Where can Juan be?” (right now)
<i>Serán las tres.</i>	“It must be three o’clock.”
<i>¿Quién será?</i>	“Who could that be?”

And the **conditional** does the same job for the **past**: *Serían las tres cuando llegó* — “It must have been three when he arrived.”

Why it’s said this way

This looks arbitrary until you remember where these tenses came from. Both were built out of “**I have to...**” — and *have to* is about **obligation and likelihood**, not only about time. English does the very same slide: “it *must* be three” is a word of obligation used for a guess. Spanish just made the whole tense carry that double duty.

- *¿Qué harás mañana?*
- *Hablaré con Susana. ¿Podrías venir?*
- *Me gustaría, pero tendré que trabajar. ¿Qué hora es?*
- *Serán las tres.*

Run the recall. What do the future *and* conditional endings attach to? The **whole infinitive** — you never strip it. What happened to Latin's own future? It **died**, and Romance replaced it with the phrase **infinitive** + **habēre**, "I have to speak." So what are the endings really? The **present of haber** for the future, the **imperfect of haber** for the conditional. Which language still shows the seam? **Portuguese**, in *falá-lo-ei*. Do the irregulars change the endings or the stem? **The stem only**. Why does *tener* become *tendr-*? Dropping the vowel squeezed *-n'r-* together and a **d** wedged in to fix it. Which two verbs chop hardest? *decir* → *diré* and *hacer* → *haré*. And what does *Serán las tres* mean? "It must be three" — the future used for guessing. Next chapter: the subjunctive, the mood for things that are not facts.

Chapter 18

The Subjunctive — the Mood of the Not-Yet-Real

Every verb form so far has *asserted* something. This chapter opens the other door: a whole second set of endings reserved for what is wanted, doubted, hoped for — for what has not happened and may never happen. It is built by one small trick, triggered by one simple test, and its name means “joined underneath.” *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C18-*.md.*

18.1 *hable, coma, viva* — building the present subjunctive

Grammar Lens

What a mood is. A **tense** tells you *when*: I speak, I spoke, I will speak. A **mood** tells you what the speaker is *doing* with the sentence — reporting it, or reaching for it.

Everything in this book up to now has been the **indicative**: the mood of assertion. It states how things are, and it keeps on stating even when it is guessing — *Serán las tres* (“it must be three o’clock”) is still an assertion, just a confident one about something unknown.

Spanish has a second mood for what is not asserted at all: things wanted, doubted, feared, hoped for. That is the **subjunctive**. English has a shrunken one left over in fixed phrases — “if I **were** you” (not *was*), “I insist that he **be** here” (not *is*), “God **save** the Queen” (not *saves*). Those odd forms are English’s last subjunctives. Spanish never let its own wear away.

The recipe — and it does not start from the infinitive. It starts from the *yo* (“I”) form of the present tense.

1. Take the *yo* form: *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”).
2. Drop the *-o*: *habl-*, *com-*, *viv-*.
3. Add the **opposite** vowel.

“Opposite” is the whole trick. The two verb families swap costumes.

Verb type	Present takes...	Subjunctive takes...
<i>-ar</i>	<i>-a-</i> (hablas)	-e- (hables)
<i>-er</i> / <i>-ir</i>	<i>-e-</i> / <i>-i-</i> (comes)	-a- (comas)

	<i>hablar</i> (to speak)	<i>comer</i> (to eat)	<i>vivir</i> (to live)
yo	hable	coma	viva
tú	hables	comas	vivas
él / ella / usted	hable	coma	viva
nosotros	hablemos	comamos	vivamos
ellos / ustedes	hablen	coman	vivan

Notice that *-er* and *-ir* verbs are **identical** here — *coma* and *viva* take exactly the same endings. Outside the present tense, those two conjugations keep merging.

Grammar Lens

Why building from *yo* is a gift. Because the subjunctive is built from the *yo* form, *any* irregularity already sitting in that form is inherited automatically. The **-go club** — six very common verbs whose “I” form grows a hard *g* — transfers whole, with nothing new to memorise.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>tener</i> (to have)	tengo	tenga
<i>decir</i> (to say)	digo	diga
<i>hacer</i> (to do / make)	hago	haga
<i>poner</i> (to put)	pongo	ponga
<i>salir</i> (to leave)	salgo	salga
<i>venir</i> (to come)	vengo	venga

The **stem-changers** — verbs whose stressed vowel breaks into two — come along on the same free ride:

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>querer</i> (to want)	quiero	quiera
<i>poder</i> (to be able)	puedo	pueda

One caution: for these, the *nosotros* form keeps the **plain** stem — *queramos*, *podamos*, never *quieramos*. That is the same rule as the present tense: the stress falls elsewhere, so the broken vowel never appears.

Where the recipe runs out. Step two says “drop the *-o*,” so the recipe needs a *yo* form with a strippable *-o* on the end. Five very common verbs do not have one.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive	
<i>ser</i> (to be)	soy	sea	unpredictable
<i>ir</i> (to go)	voy	vaya	unpredictable
<i>saber</i> (to know)	sé	sepa	unpredictable
<i>haber</i> (to have, auxiliary)	he	haya	unpredictable
<i>estar</i> (to be)	estoy	esté	predictable

The first four are simply learned outright — and *sea* carries a footnote.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sea (“that it be”) ← Latin *sedeam*, the subjunctive of *sedēre*, “**to sit**” — the second Latin verb that got folded into Spanish *ser*. *Sea* comes from that sitting verb’s own subjunctive. The wanderer turns up again here, at the far end of the grammar.

But *estar* behaves differently. Strip off the *whole -oy* and a perfectly ordinary stem is left — **est-** — which then takes the normal *-ar* endings: *esté*, *estés*, *esté*, *estemos*, *estén*.

Sounds you’ll need

estar’s one real oddity is **stress**, not spelling. Spanish’s default: a word ending in a **vowel**, **-n** or **-s** is stressed on the **second-to-last** syllable. *hablar* obeys that all the way through — **HA**-ble, ha-**BLE**-mos, **HA**-blen — so it never needs a written mark.

estar breaks it. The stress lands on the **last** syllable: es-**TÉ**, es-**TÉS**, es-**TÉN** — so each of those carries a written accent. Only es-**TE**-mos falls where Spanish expects, and it takes none.

The written accents are not decoration and not arbitrary: they are the *receipt* for a stress that does not sit where the language expects it.

So the honest count is **four irregular, plus one** whose stem is perfectly regular but whose stress is not.

(*dar*, “to give,” has the same *-oy* tail — *doy* — and its stem shrinks the same way, down to *d-*: **dé, des, dé, demos, den**. Careful, though: that single accent is *not* a stress mark. *Dé* is one syllable; the mark is there only to keep the verb apart in writing from the little preposition *de*, “of.”)

Grammar Lens

A caution about *why*. “No *-o* to strip” is a **memory aid for the modern language**, not the history. *sea, vaya, sepa* and *haya* come down from Latin *sedeam, vādam, sapiam* and *habeam*; and *saber* and *haber* plainly do have usable stems elsewhere, *sab-* and *hab-*. The *yo*-form recipe is a superb shortcut, and these five are exactly where it stops describing the language.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

subjunctive ← Latin *subiūctīvus*, “**joined underneath**” — *sub-* (“under”) + *iungere* (“to join”). English **join, junction** and **conjunction** all descend from that verb.

Two more words belong to the family without descending from Latin: **yoke** (a native English word, Old English *geoc*) and **yoga** (Sanskrit *yuj-*, literally “a yoking”). Those are *iungere*’s **cousins**, not its children — all three go back to the same Proto-Indo-European root **yewg-*, “to join.” A yoke is what joins two oxen; yoga is what joins the self to something larger; a conjunction is what joins two clauses.

Latin coined the term to translate Greek *hypotaktikē*, “**subordinated**.” So the name describes where the mood *lives*, not what it means: in a clause hanging **underneath** another one. The next section shows exactly that structure.

18.2 *quiero que...* — making the subjunctive appear

You can now *build* the subjunctive. This section is about what makes it *show up* — and the core case is beautifully simple: **one person wanting a different person to do something**.

Spanish	English
Quiero hablar español.	I want to speak Spanish.
Quiero que hables español.	I want you to speak Spanish.

Grammar Lens

The first sentence has **one** subject — I want, I speak — so Spanish uses a plain infinitive, exactly like English.

The second has **two**. *I* am the wanter; *you* are the speaker. The moment the two subjects differ, Spanish must do two things: (1) join the halves with **que** (“that”), and (2) put the second verb in the **subjunctive**. ***Quiero que hables***.

That is *subiunctivus* doing precisely what its name says: living in a clause joined *underneath* the main one.

Why it is not a fact. *Hables* is not a report that you speak. It is what I *want* — which may never happen. The main clause reaches out and bends the second one into something unreal, and the mood marks the bend.

Spanish	English	Mood
Sé que hablas español.	I know that you speak Spanish.	indicative (a fact)
Quiero que hables español.	I want you to speak Spanish.	subjunctive (not yet real)

Same *que*, same person, different mood — because knowing *reports* the world and wanting tries to *change* it.

Grammar Lens

The English trap. English says “I want *you to speak*” — an object followed by an infinitive. **After verbs of wanting, Spanish will not do this.** There is no *Quiero te hablar* meaning “I want you to speak.”

You must build the full clause: **Quiero que hables**. This is the single most common English-speaker error with the Spanish subjunctive, and it comes from translating the *shape* instead of the *meaning*.

Two things keep the rule honest. First, it is about **wanting**, not about Spanish in general: object + infinitive is perfectly good after verbs of *perceiving* and *causing* — *Te vi salir* (“I saw you leave”), *Me hizo hablar* (“he made me speak”), *Déjame hablar* (“let me speak”). Volition is the family that demands a clause. Second, *Quiero hablarte* is perfectly fine — it just means “I want to *speak to you*”: one subject, with the pronoun attached to the infinitive. What is impossible is using a pronoun to smuggle in a *second* subject.

ojalá — a wish, borrowed whole. Spanish has another trigger, and it is a wonderful word: **Ojalá hable español** — “I hope he speaks Spanish / may he speak Spanish.” *Ojalá* takes the subjunctive **always**; there is no indicative version, because the word *is* a wish.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ojalá (“would that...”) ← Andalusí Arabic *law shā’ Allāh*, “**if God should will**.” The *Allāh* is still sitting in the second half of the word every time a Spanish speaker says it. The nearest English is “**God willing**” — and nearer still, the Arabic *inshallah* that English has now borrowed in its own right.

Why it’s said this way

Languages borrow *nouns* constantly: Spanish took *azúcar* (“sugar”), *aceite* (“oil”) and *álgebra* from Arabic without blinking. Borrowing a **function word** — a piece of the machinery rather than a piece of the furniture — is far rarer, and this course teaches you the two that matter: **hasta** (“until”), from Arabic *hattā*, and **ojalá**. One is a preposition; the other is a word that *forces a grammatical mood*. Eight centuries of contact left Spanish not just Arabic words, but Arabic grammar.

18.3 Practice — fact or wish?

Two skills to drill, in order: **build the form**, then **decide whether you need it**.

Drill 1 — the vowel flip. Recipe: *yo* form → drop the *-o* → flip the vowel.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>hablar</i>	hablo	hable
<i>estudiar</i>	estudio	estudie
<i>comer</i>	como	coma
<i>beber</i>	bebo	beba
<i>vivir</i>	vivo	viva
<i>tener</i>	tengo	tenga
<i>hacer</i>	hago	haga
<i>venir</i>	vengo	venga
<i>querer</i>	quiero	quiera
<i>poder</i>	puedo	pueda

The last four are the point: **you never learned a new stem.** The *-g-* and the broken vowel were already sitting in the *yo* form.

Then the four with no *-o* to strip, learned outright: *ser* → **sea**, *ir* → **vaya**, *saber* → **sepa**, *haber* → **haya**. And *estar*, which looks as though it belongs with them and does not: take off the whole *-oy* and the stem **est-** is completely ordinary — *esté, estés, esté, estemos, estén* — with the irregularity living in the **stress** alone.

Drill 2 — one subject or two? The test: *does the second verb have a different subject?*

English	Spanish
I want to eat.	Quiero comer . (same subject → infinitive)
I want you to eat.	Quiero que comas . (two → <i>que</i> + subjunctive)
We want to live here.	Queremos vivir aquí.
We want them to live here.	Queremos que vivan aquí.
She wants to work.	Quiere trabajar .
She wants me to work.	Quiere que yo trabaje .

Say each pair aloud back to back. English switches quietly, from “to eat” to “you to eat”; Spanish switches loudly — and the loudness is the help.

Drill 3 — fact or not? Same *que*, different mood. Report the world → **indicative**. Reach for it → **subjunctive**.

Spanish	English	
Sé que comes aquí.	I know you eat here.	fact
Quiero que comas aquí.	I want you to eat here.	wish
Sé que está aquí.	I know he's here.	fact
Ojalá esté aquí.	I hope he's here.	wish
Dice que viene .	She says she's coming.	report
Quiero que venga .	I want her to come.	wish

Notice that *ojalá* needs no *que* and no main verb. The word *is* the wish, so it triggers the mood all by itself.

Drill 4 — hear the flip. The vowel swap is small on paper and clear in the mouth.

Indicative	Subjunctive
habla	hable
come	coma
trabaja	trabaje
vive	viva

Sounds you'll need

The two *-ar* rows carry a warning. *Hable* and *hablé* are different words — and so are *trabaje* and *trabajé*. The written accent is the only thing separating “**(that) he speak**” from “**I spoke**.” In Spanish the accent does not merely mark a syllable: it *carries the tense*.

What you built this chapter: a second **mood**, made from the *yo* form with the vowel flipped — *hable, coma, viva*; the free ride that hands you *tenga, diga, haga, ponga, salga, venga, quiera, pueda*; the four you learn outright, *sea, vaya, sepa, haya*, and *esté*, whose only secret is its stress; the two-subject test that summons the mood, *quiero que hables*; and *ojalá*, a wish that Spanish carried over whole from Arabic. You now have both halves of the Spanish verb: the mood that reports the world, and the mood that reaches for it. Everything still ahead — describing what surrounds you, telling longer stories, arguing, hoping out loud — is built on the pair.

Chapter 19

Yes and No

19.1 sí — yes

The smallest useful word — and the accent on it is doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí = **yes**. One syllable, said *see*.

The written accent is not decoration — it is the **whole difference** between two words:

- **sí** (with the accent) = **yes**
- **si** (no accent) = **if**

They sound almost identical, so Spanish uses the mark to tell them apart on the page: *Sí, si quieres* = “Yes, if you want.” Miss the accent and you’ve written “if” where you meant “yes.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí is Latin **sīc**, “thus, so” — answering a question with “just so,” exactly the move Latin also made with **ita** (“thus” = yes, from the Latin yes/no lesson). Its Romance cousins kept the same root:

Latin <i>sīc</i>	→
Spanish	sí
Italian	sì
Portuguese	sim

French is the odd one out — it went a completely different way for “yes” (*oui*), which its own lesson tells. But say *sí*, *sì*, *sim* in a row and you hear one Latin word answering across three countries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*sí*” — *see*, and picture the accent
- the pair — “*sí*” (yes) vs “*si*” (if)
- the cousins — “*sí*, *sì*, *sim*” — all from Latin *sīc*

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Spanish? (*sí*.) What is the *only* difference between *sí* “yes” and *si* “if”? (The **written accent**.) What Latin word is *sí* from, and what did it mean? (*sīc* — “thus, so”.)

19.2 no — no / not

The easiest word yet — and it quietly does two jobs Spanish never splits apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no = **no**. Said *noh*, a clean single vowel.

It is Latin **nōn** with almost nothing worn off — just the final consonant gone. Compare the family, all from the same *nōn*:

Latin <i>nōn</i>	→
Spanish	no
Italian	no
French	non

Grammar Lens: one word, two jobs

Here’s the thing English splits and Spanish doesn’t. English has “**no**” (the answer) and “**not**” (inside a sentence) — two different words. Spanish uses **no** for **both**:

- as the **answer**: *¿Hablas inglés?* — **No**.
- as the **negator**, placed right before the verb: *No hablo inglés* = “I do **not** speak English.”

So learning *no* gives you the whole of Spanish negation for free: to make any sentence negative, drop **no** in front of the verb. One little word, two everyday jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “no” — *noh*
- as an answer — “¿Hablas inglés? No.”
- as a negator — “No hablo inglés”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Spanish? (**no**.) What Latin word is it from? (**nōn**.) Spanish *no* does the work of which **two** English words? (“**no**” the answer and “**not**” the negator — *No hablo* = “I do not speak.”) Where does *no* go to negate a sentence? (**Right before the verb**.)

Chapter 20

Lo Siento

20.1 lo siento — “I’m sorry,” i.e. “I feel it”

You already know **por favor**, “please.” The next courtesy phrase is **lo siento**. Spanish does not say “I *am* sorry” as an adjective; it says something closer to “**I feel this.**”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **lo** = “it” — a **neuter** pronoun. It does not point at any noun; it points at the **situation itself**. Spanish keeps this one leftover neuter slot precisely for “the whole business, unnamed.”
- **siento** = “I feel,” from **sentir**, “to feel,” from Latin **sentīre**. That root gave English a whole family: **sentiment**, **sense**, **consent** (“feel together”), **resent** (“feel back at”), and **sentence** (originally an *opinion*, something felt).

So **lo siento** is literally “*I feel it.*” You are naming a feeling — regret, sympathy — rather than declaring a state about yourself. That is why it stretches so easily: *lo siento mucho*, “I feel it a lot,” works both for stepping on someone’s foot and for hearing that their father died.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “siento” — I feel — then “lo siento,” I feel it / I’m sorry
- “lo siento mucho” — I’m so sorry

- “siento” then English “sentiment, sense, consent”

Before you move on

What does **lo siento** literally mean? (“**I feel it**” — *siento*, “I feel,” from Latin *sentire*.) What is the *lo* pointing at? (The **situation**, not a noun — it is the neuter “it.”) Next: Spanish’s *other* word for sorry, and when it is the right one.

20.2 perdón — the sorry that asks for something back

Lo siento names a feeling. Spanish keeps a **second** word for a different job — one that is not about your feelings at all, but about something you want from the other person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perdón (“pardon”), from the verb **perdonar** — Latin **per-** (“thoroughly”) + **dōnāre** (“to give”). Literally: “**to give completely**.” That *dōnāre* is English’s **donate**, **donor**, and **condone**; the *per-* is the same intensifier in **perfect** (“thoroughly made”) and **perturb**. So forgiveness, in Latin’s picture of it, is a **gift given all the way** — you hand over the debt rather than keeping a share of it.

Why it’s said this way

The two are not interchangeable, and the difference follows straight from the etymologies:

	lo siento	perdón
literally	“I feel it”	“give [it] completely”
points at	your feeling	their forgiveness
use for	regret, sympathy	fault, or getting past someone

So **perdón** is what you say to squeeze through a crowd or catch a waiter’s eye (English “excuse me”), and to ask forgiveness for something **you did** — often stronger than *lo siento*. **Lo siento** leans toward “I’m sorry that happened,” including things that are nobody’s fault at all. Be honest about the edges: native speakers use whichever fits, the

boundary is soft, and mixing them is not a real mistake — just a shade off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “perdón” — pardon / excuse me
- the pair — “lo siento” for regret, “perdón” for fault
- “perdón” then English “donate, condone” — the *dōnāre* root

Before you move on

What do the two halves of **perdonar** mean? (**Per-**, “thoroughly,” plus **dōnāre**, “to give” — to give completely.) Which word do you use to get past someone in a corridor? (**Perdón.**) Which leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (**Lo siento** — “I feel it.”)

Chapter 21

Days of the Week

21.1 lunes to viernes — the planets of the week, worn down

The Romans mapped the seven-day week onto the seven visible “wandering stars” — the planet-gods. Spanish kept that map, but handled the word “day” differently from its Romance cousins: where French still spells out “**-di**” (day) on every weekday, Spanish mostly just **dropped it**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Each weekday began life as “[planet-god]’s diēs (day).” In Vulgar Latin, *diēs* was simply **dropped as a separate word** in most of these — what survived is just the planet’s own Latin genitive form. That’s why **martes**, **jueves**, **viernes** already end in **-s**: not because *diēs* wore down into one, but because **Martis**, **Iovis**, **Veneris** — the planets’ own genitive forms — end in *-s* in Latin already. **Lunes** has no such *-s* to inherit (*lūnae* doesn’t end in one), so it likely picked up the ending by **analogy** with its four siblings:

Spanish	← Latin	planet-god	English echo
lunes	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	the Moon (<i>luna</i>)	<i>Monday</i> = Moon-day
martes	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the Germanic war-god = Mars)
miércoles	<i>Mercuriī diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)
jueves	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Jove</i>)	<i>Thursday</i> (Thor = Jupiter)
viernes	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus	<i>Friday</i> (Frigg/Freya = Venus)

Compare **French**, which keeps *diēs* as its own visible syllable on every day — **lundi**, **mardi**, **jeudi** — while Spanish dropped it from four of its five weekdays. **miércoles** is the odd one out: some historians of the language think its extra “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs* itself (fused in and reshaped) — though the exact sound changes are debated, unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes” — the work week
- each as “[planet]’s day, worn down” — “lunes = Moon, jueves = Jupiter”
- the bridge — “martes / Tuesday, both the war-god’s day (Mars / Tiw)”

Before you move on

Recall the weekday family:

- What did every Spanish weekday begin life as?

(“[Planet-god]’s *diēs* (day)” — the same Latin phrase French keeps more visibly with *-di*.)

- Why do **martes, jueves, viernes** end in *-s*, and where does **lunes** get its *-s* from? (**From the planet’s own Latin genitive** — *Martis/Iovis/ Veneris* already end in *-s*; *lunes* likely picked it up **by analogy**, since *lūnae* has no *-s* of its own.)
- What’s debated about **miércoles**? (**Whether its “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs*** — unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.)
- Why do *martes* and *Tuesday* line up? (They name the same day for the war-god: *Mars* in Latin, *Tiw* in Germanic.)

21.2 sábado and domingo — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — then two that broke the pattern entirely. The weekend is where **religion overwrote astronomy**, and Spanish keeps both rewrites in plain view.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	meaning	note
sábado	<i>sabbatum</i>	“ Sabbath ”	the planet-god (Saturn) is gone — replaced by the Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i> , “to rest”
domingo	<i>diēs Dominica</i>	“the Lord’s day”	<i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i> , “lord/master” — Spanish kept this one much less worn-down than French’s <i>dimanche</i>

Two different rewrites:

- **sábado** would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for). Instead, Latin Christians borrowed the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*), and it became *sábado*. So English **Saturday** and Spanish **sábado** are the **same day, two different names** — the planet vs. the Sabbath.
- **domingo** drops Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, Spanish made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Dominus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Spanish kept **domingo** recognizably close to *Dominica* — compare French’s more worn-down **dimanche**, where the *di-* (day) fossil jumped to the front of the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo”

- “sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord’s day” — religion, not planets
- the pair-ups — “sábado / Saturday (Sabbath vs. Saturn)”, “domingo / Sunday (Lord vs. Sun)”

Before you move on

Give all seven Spanish days. (*Lunes ... domingo*.) Where does **sábado** come from, and its English contrast? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum*; English kept *Saturday* = Saturn’s day.) What does **domingo** mean literally? (“The **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*.)

Chapter 22

Black, White, Red, and Blue

22.1 negro, blanco — two colours, and one of their histories

Two colours you can put to work immediately. One of them has the most ordinary history imaginable. The other does not — which is why it gets its own lesson next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

negro (“black”) ← Latin **niger**. Nothing surprising: the same Latin root gives English **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”) and the rest of the Romance family’s words for black — French *noir*, Italian *nero*, Portuguese *negro*. Latin’s word for black stayed put, in every daughter language.

Hold that in mind as the baseline. It is what a colour word normally does.

The two words in use

blanco (“white”) is the pair to it: *el gato negro*, *el gato blanco*. Both behave like any Spanish adjective — they follow the noun and agree with it (*la casa blanca*).

But hear what you would have expected and did not get. Latin’s word for white was **albus**, and by the *negro* pattern Spanish “white” should be something like *albo*. It is not. Where **blanco** actually came from — and what became of *albus* — is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “negro, blanco”
- with a noun — “el gato negro, la casa blanca”
- “negro” then English “denigrate” — the *niger* root

Before you move on

Say black and white. (*Negro, blanco.*) Where does *negro* come from, and what English word shares it? (Latin **niger** — *denigrate.*) What would you have expected Spanish’s “white” to be, given Latin *albus*? (Something like *albo* — and it isn’t. That is next lesson’s puzzle.)

22.2 blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

Negro came straight down from Latin, like almost every other everyday word you have met. **Blanco** did not come down at all. It walked in.

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two colour words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanco comes from **Germanic *blank** — “shining, gleaming.” It is a **loan**, traditionally attributed to contact with the **Visigoths**, the Germanic people who ruled Spain for centuries after Rome collapsed. Be careful how firmly you hold that last part: no surviving Gothic text actually preserves this word, so the Visigothic route is a **plausible traditional account**, not a documented one. What *is* well attested is the parallel case next door — **French** took the very same Germanic word (*blanc*) from a **different** Germanic people, the **Franks**. Two Romance sisters, the same borrowed word for white, two separate borrowings. Why would a borrowed word beat Latin’s own? Because **blank* was not a pale word: it meant **bright, gleaming**. Colour terms lose out to vivid ones all the time — English’s own *bright* is doing the same job in

“bright white.”

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s white did not vanish. It stopped being the **everyday** word and survived in corners:

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky going <i>white</i>
<i>albo</i> (rare, poetic)	white, pale	a fossil, mostly literary now
<i>álbum</i> (Eng. <i>album</i>)	album	a <i>blank white</i> tablet
<i>albino</i>	albino	white-skinned

That is the normal fate of a displaced word: not death, but retreat into technical and poetic corners. *El alba* is still every Spanish speaker’s word for dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pairing — “negro from Latin, blanco from Germanic”
- “el alba” — dawn — and hear the old Latin white inside it
- “blanco” then French “blanc” — the same loan, twice over

Before you move on

Where does **blanco** come from, and what did it mean? (**Germanic** ***blank**, “shining” — traditionally linked to the Visigoths, though not directly attested.) Which other language borrowed the same word, from whom? (**French** *blanc*, from the **Franks**.) Where did Latin’s *albus* end up? (In **alba** “dawn,” *álbum*, *albino* — no longer the everyday colour word.)

22.3 rojo — the same family as *red*, by a different branch

So far the sorting has been simple: *negro* inherited, *blanco* borrowed. **Rojo** needs a third box — inherited, yes, but not from

the word you would guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rojo (“red”) ← Latin **russus**, an everyday, expressive Latin word for red. That is a **different specific Latin word** from the one behind French *rouge* (← **rubeus**). Latin had several reds and the daughter languages did not all pick the same one.

Both *russus* and *rubeus*, though, descend from the very same ancient root: PIE *h₁rewd^h-* — which is also the root of English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and of Latin *ruber* itself (English **rubric**, once written in red ink).

So *rojo*, *rouge* and *red* are **cousins**, not copies: three descendants of one very old family, arriving by three different branches. Nobody borrowed this one from anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rojo”
- the cousins — “rojo · rouge · red”, three branches, one root
- the three so far — “negro inherited, blanco borrowed, rojo cousin”

Before you move on

Is **rojo** from the same Latin word as French *rouge*? (**No** — *rojo* ← *russus*, *rouge* ← *rubeus*.) Are they related at all? (**Yes** — cousins, via the shared PIE root *h₁rewd^h-*, which also gives English **red**.) Next: the one colour in this chapter that came from outside Europe entirely.

22.4 azul — a stone from Afghanistan, in your everyday vocabulary

Three colours in, three different histories: inherited, borrowed from a neighbour, inherited by a different branch. The fourth comes from outside the Indo-European family altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul (“blue”) ← Arabic لازورد (*lāzaward*), “**lapis lazuli**” — the deep blue stone, mined for centuries in what is now Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world. Spanish picked the word up during the centuries of Arabic-speaking rule in Iberia (**al-Andalus**). English has the same source at one more remove, in **azure**, and the stone keeps its own name: **lazuli**.

So Spanish’s word for blue is, underneath, the name of a **rock** — which is common for blue. Blue is the last basic colour term most languages acquire, and when they do, they usually name it after the thing that was reliably that colour.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the contrast worth keeping. **French** has *azur* too — but only as a **secondary, poetic** word (the sky’s blue, the *Côte d’Azur*); its everyday blue is the Germanic loan *bleu*. In **Spanish** it is the reverse: **azul is the plain, unremarkable, everyday word**, with no Germanic rival competing for the job at all.

Same borrowed word, two languages, opposite outcomes — a reminder that where a word came from tells you nothing about how ordinary it now feels.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “negro, blanco, rojo, azul”
- sort them — “negro inherited, blanco Germanic, rojo cousin of red, azul Arabic”
- “azul” then English “azure” — the same lapis lazuli

Before you move on

Name the four colours and sort them by origin. (*Negro* — Latin *niger*; *blanco* — Germanic **blank*; *rojo* — Latin *russus*, cousin of red; *azul* — Arabic *lāzaward*.) What did *lāzaward* actually name? (**Lapis lazuli**, the stone.) How does *azul*’s role differ from French *azur*’s? (**Azul is Spanish’s everyday blue**; French’s *azur* is only poetic, with *bleu*

doing the daily work.)

Chapter 23

Parents and Siblings

23.1 el padre, la madre — among the oldest words there are

“Father” and “mother” are some of the **oldest reconstructible words in human language** — older than Latin, older than Rome. Spanish kept them close to the Latin original, and they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- el padre (“father”) ← Latin **pater** ← PIE *ph₂tēr*.
- la madre (“mother”) ← Latin **māter** ← PIE *méh₂tēr*.

Why it’s said this way

Padre and English *father* both descend independently from the **same** PIE word — they’re siblings, not parent and child. Latin (and Spanish after it) kept the original *p* and *t* largely intact; the Germanic branch that gave English took a separate road through **Grimm’s Law**, which shifted the **inherited p** → **f** and **t** → **th**:

PIE ancestor	Latin → Spanish	Germanic → English
<i>ph₂tēr</i>	<i>pater</i> → padre	father
<i>méh₂tēr</i>	<i>māter</i> → madre	mother

So *padre* and *father* aren’t lookalikes borrowed late, and neither one comes *from* the other — they’re the **same inherited PIE word**, one branch keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*. The Latin root also

gives Spanish and English their “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternidad**, **patrón** and **maternal**, **maternidad**. (A further Latin-only offshoot, *māter* → *māteria*, “the stuff a tree-mother produces,” gives Spanish *materia* and, separately, *matriz* — “womb” — via Latin *mātrix*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el padre, la madre”
- the sound-law — “padre keeps p; father shifts to f — same word”
- “padre → paternal; madre → maternal”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with their articles. (**el padre, la madre**.) Does *padre* turn into English *father* directly? (**No** — both descend independently from the same PIE word; the Germanic branch shifted *p* → *f* and *t* → *th* via **Grimm’s Law**, while Latin/Spanish kept the original sounds.) Name an English cousin of each. (*padre* → paternal; *madre* → maternal.)

23.2 el hermano, la hermana — brother and sister, from a different word entirely

You might expect Spanish “brother” to come from Latin **frāter**, the way French’s *frère* does. It does not. Spanish’s siblings took a completely different word — one about **seeds**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, literally “a brother **of the same stock/blood**” — distinguishing a *full* brother from a half-brother, or from a “brother” in some looser sense.

Then something ordinary and strange happened: in everyday Latin the **adjective** took over the whole job and the **noun quietly dropped out**. (English does this all the time — a *mobile phone* becomes a *mobile*, a

cellular telephone becomes a *cell*.) What survived is the modifier:

- **el hermano** (“brother”) ← Latin **germānus**.
- **la hermana** (“sister”) ← Latin **germāna**.

So Spanish’s everyday word for brother is, grammatically, a leftover adjective.

Why it’s said this way

Germānus traces back to **germen**, “sprout, bud, seed” — the same root that gives English **germ**, **germinate**, and **germane** (originally “closely related,” from the same seed, before it loosened into just “relevant”).

So calling someone your *hermano* is, at the etymological root, calling them “**sprung from the same seed.**” (And no, this has nothing to do with *Germany* — that name is a separate, unrelated puzzle.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el hermano, la hermana” — brother, sister
- the root chain — “germen, seed” → “germānus, of the same seed” → “hermano”
- “hermano” then English “germinate, germane”

Before you move on

Does Spanish *hermano* come from Latin *frāter*? (**No** — from **germānus**, “of the same stock/seed,” an adjective that swallowed the noun *frāter* it used to modify.) What does its root *germen* mean, and what English words share it? (**Seed, sprout** — *germ, germinate, germane*.) Next: the silent *h* on the front, which is not the *h* you think it is.

23.3 the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

Germānus starts with a **g**. *Hermano* starts with an **h**. Something has to explain that — and the obvious explanation is the wrong one.

What to know first

- el hermano, la hermana — the words and the *germen* root.

Why it's said this way

You may already know that Spanish often turns a Latin initial **f** into a silent **h** — *filius* → **hijo** (“son”), *facere* → **hacer** (“to do”). **Hermano is not that**, and the difference is worth getting right.

Germānus is stressed on its **third** syllable (*ger-MĀ-nus*), which leaves the opening *ger-* **unstressed**. Latin’s **g** before a front vowel had already softened toward a *y*-like sound in everyday speech — and in that unstressed position it simply **fell away entirely**, giving Old Spanish **ermano**, with **no *h* at all**. That is the form actually recorded centuries ago.

The **h** you see today was added **later, in spelling only**, to mark the word’s old link to Latin *g-*. Compare:

word	what happened to the sound	was the <i>h</i> ever spoken?
hijo, hacer	Latin <i>f-</i> → a real breathy <i>h</i>	yes , for centuries
hermano	Latin <i>g-</i> simply dropped	no , never

Same silent letter today; two completely different backstories, only one of which involves a sound at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*germānus*” then “*ermano*” then “*hermano*” — the three stages
- the honest distinction — *hijo/hacer*’s *h* was once truly spoken; *hermano*’s *h* never was

Before you move on

Is *hermano*'s *h* the same kind of change as *hijo*'s or *hacer*'s? (**No.**)
What actually happened to *germānus*'s opening? (Its **g** dropped away in an **unstressed** syllable, giving Old Spanish *ermano*.) So where did the *h* come from? (**Spelling** — added later to mark the Latin link, never pronounced.)

Chapter 24

Head and Hand

24.1 la cabeza — “the head”

Spanish’s word for “head” is the boring, expected one — and that’s exactly what makes it interesting, once you see what French did instead.

You’ll want to know: la cabeza

la cabeza — the head. Feminine, so **la**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s word for “head” was **caput**. Spanish’s *cabeza* comes straight from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*), and *caput* shows up all over English too:

English	literally
captain	the “head” of a ship/unit
capital	the “head” city, or “head” sum of money
decapitate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange under “headings” — hence, to yield

Why it’s said this way

French had the exact same Latin word available — and **dropped it**. French *tête* (“head”) comes instead from **testa**, Latin for an **earth-ware pot**: Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English

speakers say “noggin” (a small mug), and in Gaul that joke eventually **replaced** the real word entirely. Spanish never made that swap — *cabeza* is *caput*, plain and simple, still standing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la cabeza” — the head
- “me duele la cabeza” — “my head hurts”
- the English family — “captain, capital, decapitate”
- the contrast — Spanish kept *caput*; French swapped it for a pot joke

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (*La cabeza* — feminine.) What Latin word is it from? (**Caput**.) Give an English word from the same root. (**Captain, capital, decapitate...**) What did French do instead? (**Replaced caput with *testa*, “pot”** — soldiers’ slang for the skull that took over completely.)

24.2 la mano — “the hand”

You’ve been trusting “-o words are masculine, -a words are feminine” since Chapter 1. Here’s the word that breaks it — and everyone learning Spanish has to memorize this one by name.

Grammar Lens: la mano and its gender

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, despite ending in **-o**.

Almost every Spanish noun ending in *-o* is masculine (*el libro, el gato...*). *Mano* is the single most common exception, and it’s actually **doubly** irregular. Latin **manus** (“hand”) belonged to the **4th declension** — a group of *-us* nouns that were mostly **masculine** (*fructus* “fruit,” *exercitus* “army,” *senātus* “senate”). *Manus* was one of a small handful of exceptions that were **feminine** instead (alongside *domus* “house” and

anus “old woman”). So *mano* broke the rule **twice over**: an exception within Latin’s own mostly-masculine 4th declension, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o* = masculine pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mano comes from Latin **manus**, “hand” — and that root is buried inside an enormous number of English words:

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>facere</i> , “to make”)
manuscript	written by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>scribere</i>)
maintain	hold in the hand (<i>manū tenēre</i>)
manage	to handle

Manufacture is worth pausing on: it literally means “made by hand” — and today it names precisely the opposite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la mano” — feminine, despite the *-o*
- “me duele la mano” — “my hand hurts”
- the family — “manual, manufacture, maintain — all a hand”
- the irony — “manufacture = made by hand”

Before you move on

Say “the hand,” and name its gender. (*La mano* — **feminine**, despite ending in *-o*.) Why is *mano* feminine when most *-o* words aren’t? (**It’s doubly irregular** — Latin’s 4th declension, where *manus* belongs, was mostly **masculine**; *manus* was one of a few feminine exceptions there, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o*=masculine rule.) Give an English word built on *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage.**)

Chapter 25

The Seasons

25.1 la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno — three plain, one surprising

Three of Spanish’s four seasons are exactly what you’d expect from Latin. The fourth hides a genuine surprise: its **meaning itself** drifted from one season to another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **la primavera** (“spring”) ← Latin *prīma vēra*, literally “**first spring**” (*vēr*, “spring,” + *prīma*, “first”). Italian still says the identical phrase, *primavera*, unchanged. (Old French once said *primevère* too, before switching to *printemps*.)
- **el otoño** (“autumn”) ← Latin *autumnus* — the same root behind French *automne* and English *autumn* itself.
- **el invierno** (“winter”) ← Latin *hībernūm* (*tempus*), “the **wintry** [season]” — the same root as French *hiver* and English *hibernate*, “to spend the winter.”

Why it’s said this way

You might expect *verano* (“summer”) to come from Latin **aestas**, “heat” — the way French *été* does. It doesn’t. The standard account (per Spanish etymological dictionaries) traces **verano** to Latin *vērānum* (*tempus*), “**of spring**” — built on the very same *vēr*, “spring,” behind *primavera*.

So how did a word meaning “spring-ish” end up naming **summer**? The

honest answer is a **shift in meaning over time**, not a sound change — though the exact story is murkier than a tidy one-line explanation. The traditional, simplified account says that as *primavera* (“first spring”) rose to become the standard word for spring, *verano*’s meaning drifted forward into the season right after, summer; the fuller picture likely also involves Vulgar Latin agricultural usage (a “vernal” grazing or working period that stretched from late spring into early summer), so the drift may not be purely a case of one word simply vacating a job for the other. Either way, two Spanish words both rooted in *vēr*, “spring,” ended up naming two different seasons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “primavera, verano, otoño, invierno” — the four seasons
- “primavera = prima vera, first spring”
- the surprise — “verano ALSO comes from *vēr*, ‘spring’ — but its meaning moved to summer”
- “invierno ~ hibernate”

Before you move on

What does **primavera** literally mean? (“**First spring**” — *prīma vēra*.) Does **verano** come from Latin *aestas*, like French *été*? (**No** — from *vērānum*, “of spring,” the same *vēr* root as *primavera*; its meaning **shifted** toward summer over time — traditionally linked to *primavera* taking over the job of naming spring, though the fuller history is murkier than that alone.) What English word is **invierno** the cousin of? (**Hibernate**.)

Chapter 26

Water, Wine, and Bread

26.1 el agua — water, and an article that is not what it looks like

One of the least changed words in Spanish, carrying one of its most misunderstood rules. The “masculine” article on this feminine noun is not a mistake and not an exception to gender.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agua (“water”) ← Latin **aqua** — almost unchanged in two thousand years. Compare French, where the *very same word* was worn all the way down to a bare “**eau**,” just the sound “oh.” Same starting point, same span of time, wildly different amounts of erosion: how fast a language wears its words down is not fixed.

English kept the whole Latin word too, but as a **learned borrowing** rather than an inherited everyday one: **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**, **aqualung**.

Grammar Lens: el agua’s article and gender

Notice: **el agua**, not *la agua* — yet *agua* is genuinely **feminine**. You can prove it: *el agua fría*, “the cold water,” keeps the feminine adjective ending, and the plural is *las aguas*, never *los aguas*.

The rule is **phonological**, not grammatical. Spanish swaps *la* for *el* directly before a **singular** feminine noun beginning with a **stressed a-sound**, to avoid running two identical vowels together (*la agua*). It is the same instinct that makes English pick “an apple” over “a apple.”

	singular	plural
the water	el agua	las aguas
the eagle	el águila	las águilas
the axe	el hacha	las hachas
Only the article changes. The noun's gender never moves.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua” — water, feminine, but takes *el*
- the proof — “el agua fría” and “las aguas”
- the contrast — “agua” barely changed; French’s “eau” wore all the way down

Before you move on

Is **agua** masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *el* replaces *la* only because *agua* begins with a **stressed a**.) How would you prove it? (*El agua fría*; *las aguas*.) How does Spanish’s erosion of *aqua* compare with French’s? (**Much less** — Spanish kept nearly the whole word; French wore it to “eau.”)

26.2 el vino — one word, three separate arrivals in English

The second drink is grammatically boring — plain masculine, plain *el vino*, no stressed-*a* trick. Its history makes up for that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vino (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum** — which held its shape well, as French’s *vin* did too.

English shares the very same root by **more than one road**, and the roads are worth separating, because they show three different ways a word can travel:

English word	how it got there
wine	<i>vīnum</i> borrowed directly into old Germanic, very early
vine, vinegar	borrowed centuries later, secondhand via French (<i>vin</i> + <i>aigre</i> , “sour wine”)
vineyard	not borrowed at all — English built it at home from the already-borrowed <i>wine</i> plus native <i>yard</i>

So *wine* and *vine* are the same Latin word twice, arriving a thousand years apart by different routes, and *vineyard* is a homemade compound made out of the first arrival. One Latin noun; three English histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua, el vino” — the two drinks
- “vino” then English “wine, vine, vinegar” — one root, three roads

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *vino*? (**Vīnum**.) Name three English cousins and say how each arrived. (**Wine** — direct, early, into Germanic; **vine/vinegar** — later, via French; **vineyard** — built at home from *wine* plus *yard*.) And why is it *el agua* but *las aguas*? (The *el* is a sound rule for a stressed *a*, singular only.)

26.3 el pan — bread, and the friend who shares it

Spanish’s word for bread hides the same lovely word-story you’d find in English’s “companion” — except Spanish kept **both halves**, the bread and the friendship.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pan (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis**. Masculine: *el pan*.

Why it's said this way

The Latin root **pān-** (“bread”) gives Spanish its own word for a close friend:

- **compañero / compañera** (“companion, friend, partner”) ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — literally “**one you share bread with.**” Spanish built this word from the very same recipe as English **companion** and **company** (which come from the identical Latin pieces) — but where English only kept the *friendship* sense, Spanish still visibly uses the **same root** for the actual **bread** (*pan*) too.
- **panadería** (“bakery”) and **panadero** (“baker”) — both transparently built on *pan*.

So *pan* and *compañero* are the same word-family doing double duty in Spanish: name the food, and name the friend you’d share it with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el pan” — bread
- “compañero” — literally, one you share bread with
- “panadería, panadero” — bakery, baker

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**El pan.**) What does *compañero* literally mean, and what’s it built from? (“**One you share bread with**” — *com-* + *pānis*.) Does English keep this same double meaning? (**No** — English’s *companion* only kept the friendship sense; Spanish still uses the same root for the actual bread, *pan*, too.)

Chapter 27

The Months

27.1 los meses — the calendar's gods and Caesars

Spanish's twelve months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, barely changed from Latin. Two things you already know pay off immediately: *marzo* is the war-god you met in *martes*, and *septiembre–diciembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10 from the counting chapters.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	who / what
enero	<i>Iānuārius</i>	Janus , the two-faced god of doors & beginnings
febrero	<i>Februārius</i>	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
marzo	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god — <i>the same Mars as martes</i> (Tuesday)! perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open” (buds opening)
abril	<i>Aprīlis</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
mayo	<i>Māius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
junio	<i>Iūnius</i>	originally <i>Quīntilis</i> , “the 5th [month]” — renamed for Julius Caesar after his death
julio	<i>Iūlius</i>	originally <i>Sextilis</i> , “the 6th [month]” — renamed for the emperor Augustus
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
septiembre	<i>september</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octō</i>)
octubre	<i>octōber</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
noviembre	<i>november</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)
diciembre	<i>december</i>	

Two payoffs land at once:

- **marzo = Mars = martes.** The month and the weekday honor the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, you know the other.
- **The 7–10 months.** *Septiembre* through *diciembre* still carry *septem*, *octō*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year

originally began in **March**, with September genuinely the 7th month. Centuries before Caesar, two new months (Januarius, Februarius) were added at the front to cover the winter, which pushed every later month's number out of step with its name — September became the 9th month while still being *named* “7th.” **Julius** and **Augustus** had nothing to do with that shift: they simply got two already-existing months — *Quintilis* and *Sextilis*, literally “5th” and “6th” — **renamed** in their honor after the fact. The names stuck; the months themselves were never new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre”
- the tie-back — “marzo / martes — both Mars, the war-god”
- “septiembre = 7, diciembre = 10” — the old March-start year

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martes*? (**Mars**, the war-god — his month and his day.) Why is *diciembre* Latin for “ten”? (**The Roman year began in March**, and adding January/February at the front later pushed every month's number out of step with its name.) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus **add** new months to the calendar? (**No** — *julio* and *agosto* were already-existing months, *Quintilis* and *Sextilis* (“5th”/“6th”), simply **renamed** in their honor.)

Chapter 28

Noon and Midnight

28.1 mediodía, medianoche — noon and midnight, spelled out in full

Two hours that don't get a number — they get a name. And Spanish keeps that name far more transparent than its French cousin does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	literally
mediodía	<i>medius diēs</i>	“ mid-day ” (<i>medio</i> “middle” + <i>día</i> “day”)
medianoche	<i>media nox</i>	“ mid-night ” (<i>media</i> “middle” + <i>noche</i> “night”)

Both halves are **fully alive, ordinary Spanish words on their own**: **medio/media** (“middle” — cousin of English *medium*, *mid*, *middle*) and **día/noche** (“day/night,” words you already know). Compare French, which took the same Latin phrase down a bumpier road: *minuit*’s second half, **-nuit**, is still the plain, everyday French word for “night” — just as recognizable as Spanish’s *noche*. But *midi*’s second half, **-di**, wore down into an opaque fragment: the ordinary French word for “day” is *jour*, not *di* — that piece survives only as a fossil, tucked inside weekday names like *lundi* and *mardi*. So the erosion split unevenly: French kept “night” transparent and lost “day,” while Spanish kept both.

They don't need *horas* the way a normal Spanish time (*son las tres*) never does either — they simply stand in for the hour on their own:

Es mediodía. — “It is noon.” **Es medianoche.** — “It is midnight.”

(Fun aside: English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the **ninth** hour” — originally mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier over the centuries to mean midday. Spanish kept the tidier, transparent “mid-day” instead.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mediodía” (noon), “medianoche” (midnight)
- break them — “medio + día”, “media + noche” — both halves still ordinary words
- “Es mediodía. Es medianoche.” — they stand in for the hour
- the contrast — French kept “night” (*nuit*) but wore “day” down to a fossil (*-di*)

Before you move on

What do *mediodía* and *medianoche* literally mean, and from what Latin? (“Mid-day” ← *medius diēs*; “mid-night” ← *media nox*.) Are both halves still recognizable, ordinary Spanish words? (**Yes** — *medio/ media* “middle,” *día/noche* “day/night.”) Did French erode its phrase evenly? (**No** — French’s *-nuit* stayed just as transparent as Spanish’s *noche*, but its *-di* wore down to an opaque fossil, since the everyday French word for “day” is actually *jour*.) How do you say “it is noon”? (*Es mediodía*.)

Chapter 29

Telling Time

29.1 la hora — Spanish’s barely-changed Latin hour

You’ve now seen this Latin word take three different paths: French wore it down to *heure*, German borrowed it centuries later as *Uhr*. Spanish’s path is the simplest of all — it barely changed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, “a season, a time of day” (the Greek goddesses of the seasons were the *Hōrai*). Spanish kept the word almost exactly as Latin had it — just a silent **h** in spelling, a fossil of a Latin *h* that was already weak and barely pronounced by the time Spanish inherited the word (the same non-story as French *heure* or English *hour*’s silent *h*). Be careful not to confuse this with *hijo* and *hacer*’s silent *h* — those come from a completely different, later Spanish sound change (Latin **f**- → Old Spanish aspirated *h*- → eventual silence), not from an already-weak Latin *h* the way *hora*’s is. Two different roads to the same “silent letter” result. Compare its cousins: French wore *hōra* down further to *heure*; German didn’t inherit the word at all, but borrowed it later as *Uhr*; English took the same Latin *hōra* and made *hour*.

language	word	what happened
Spanish	hora	inherited almost unchanged, just a silent <i>h</i>
French	heure	inherited, but worn down further
German	Uhr	not inherited — borrowed later, separately
English	hour	inherited via French, silent <i>h</i>

Grammar Lens: Son las and telling time

Spanish uses **ser** (“to be”) plus the **feminine plural article** (agreeing with the unspoken *horas*) to tell time — and famously switches number for “one”:

Es la una. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular — *la una*, “the one”) **Son las dos.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural — *las dos*, “the two”) **Son las diez.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**it is the one**” / “**they are the two/ten**” — the hour count itself is implied by the article and number, without needing to say *hora(s)* at all in everyday speech (unlike French’s *il est deux heures*, which spells out “hours” every time).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hora” — silent *h*, a fossil of an already-weak Latin *h*
- “Es la una. Son las dos. Son las diez.”
- “hora / heure / hour” — one Latin root, three different fates

Before you move on

What Latin (and Greek) word is *hora* from? (*hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*.) How did Spanish's path differ from French's and German's? (**Spanish** inherited it almost unchanged; **French** wore it down further to *heure*; **German** didn't inherit it at all and borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.) How do you say “it is one o'clock” vs. “it is two o'clock”? (*Es la una* — singular; *Son las dos* — plural.)

Chapter 30

The Weather

30.1 el tiempo — one word doing two jobs

Ask a Spanish speaker *¿qué tiempo hace?* and you are literally asking “**what time does it make?**” — because *tiempo* does not split “time” from “weather” the way English does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tiempo = both “**time**” and “**weather**” — from Latin **tempus**, which already carried this same double sense. Nothing was merged in Spanish; the two meanings simply arrived together and stayed.

English inherited the word too, through borrowing, but kept **only the time half: temporal, contemporary, tempo, temporary**. So the double meaning is not a Spanish oddity — it is the older state of affairs, and English is the one that narrowed.

How does a Spanish speaker know which is meant? **Context alone**, and it is never ambiguous in practice: *no tengo tiempo* is “I have no time,” *¿qué tiempo hace?* is “what’s the weather like?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el tiempo” — time, or weather, depending on context
- “¿qué tiempo hace?” — what’s the weather like?
- “tiempo” then English “tempo, temporal” — the *tempus* family

Before you move on

What two things does **el tiempo** mean? (**Time** and **weather**.) Which Latin word gives it, and did it already mean both? (**Tempus** — yes, both.) Which language narrowed the meaning, Spanish or English? (**English** — it kept only “time.”) Next: how to actually answer *¿qué tiempo hace?*

30.2 hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — the weather

Spanish *makes*

You can ask *¿qué tiempo hace?* Now answer it. Three of Spanish’s commonest weather answers all take the same verb you already know — *hacer*, “to make.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **calor** ← Latin **calor**, “heat, warmth” → English **calorie**, **caloric**, **cauldron**.
- **frío** ← Latin **frigidus**, “cold” (the middle syllable syncopated away) → English **frigid**, **refrigerate**.
- **sol** ← Latin **sol**, “sun,” unchanged → English **solar**, **solstice**, **parasol**.

Here is the part worth noticing: all three are **nouns**, not adjectives. *Calor* is “heat,” not “hot.” That is exactly why Spanish reaches for **hacer**: you cannot *be* a noun, but the world can **make** one.

hace calor — “it’s hot,” literally “**it makes heat**” **hace frío** — “it’s cold,” literally “**it makes cold**” **hace sol** — “it’s sunny,” literally “**it makes sun**”

French does the same thing with the same logic (*il fait chaud*); English is the outlier, forcing weather into “it **is** hot” with an adjective.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- the literal reading — “it makes heat, it makes cold, it makes sun”
- “calor” then English “calorie”; “frío” then “refrigerate”

Before you move on

Say “it’s hot,” “it’s cold,” “it’s sunny.” (*Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol.*) Why does Spanish use *hacer* rather than a “to be” verb? (Because *calor*, *frío* and *sol* are **nouns** — the weather **makes** heat, it does not *be* hot.) Give an English cousin of *frío*. (**Frigid, refrigerate.**)

30.3 llueve — the one weather word that will not join *hacer*

Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — three answers, one pattern. Now try rain, and the pattern breaks. Rain does not get made in Spanish; rain has a verb of its own.

Grammar Lens: rain brings its own verb

llueve = “it’s raining.” Not *hace lluvia*, not “it makes rain” — just **llueve**, a single word that is a complete sentence.

It comes from **llover**, “to rain,” and *llover* is **impersonal**: it has no subject at all, not even a “it” you could point to. Compare the two shapes side by side:

pattern	example	what carries the weather
hacer + noun	<i>hace calor</i>	the noun (<i>calor</i> , heat)
dedicated verb	<i>llueve</i>	the verb itself

English does exactly the same split, which makes it easy to feel: you say “it **is** hot” with an adjective, but “it **rains**” with a verb built for the job. Spanish just draws the line in the same place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llover ← Latin **pluere**, “to rain.” Recognise that **pl-** → **ll-** shift? It is the **same regular sound change** that gave you **llamar** (← *clamāre*), **llave** (← *clāvem*, “key”) and **llama** (← *flamma*, “flame”). Latin’s *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* clusters all became Spanish *ll-*.

So *llueve* is not an exception you have to memorise twice: it is a predictable descendant of *pluere* (the same root English keeps in **pluvial** and the **pluviometer**, a rain gauge), and it is the one weather word with enough of its own life to refuse the *hacer* frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿qué tiempo hace?” then “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- “llueve” — one word, a whole sentence, no *hacer*
- the family — “llamar, llave, llama, llover” — four Latin clusters, one Spanish *ll-*

Before you move on

Which weather word does **not** use *hacer*, and why? (**Llueve** — rain has its own impersonal verb, *llover*.) What Latin word is *llover* from? (**Pluere**.) What sound change turned its *pl-* into *ll-*, and what other words show it? (Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* → Spanish *ll-* — *llamar*, *llave*, *llama*.) And what does *el tiempo* mean? (**Time** and **weather**, from *tempus*.)

Chapter 31

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

31.1 once — quince: five words with a seam you can no longer see

Spanish counts past ten in **two completely different ways**, and the join between them is a real boundary in the language, not a place someone drew a line. Today: the first five, which you simply have to learn as words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin
once	<i>undecim</i> (“one-ten”)
doce	<i>duodecim</i> (“two-ten”)
trece	<i>tredecim</i> (“three-ten”)
catorce	<i>quattuordecim</i> (“four-ten”)
quince	<i>quindecim</i> (“five-ten”)

Every one of these *was* a compound — a number plus **-decim** (“ten,” the same root as *diez*). But these five are the numbers people say most often, and heavy use wears words smooth. Centuries of everyday speech fused each pair into a single, **opaque** word: no Spanish speaker hears “one-ten” in *once* any more than an English speaker hears “two-ten” in *twelve*.

Listen for the ghost, though. The **-ce** ending on *doce*, *trece*, *catorce*, *quince* is all that survives of Latin’s *-decim*. It is the same “ten” you already say in **diez**, ground down to two letters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince”
- just the endings — “-ce, -ce, -ce, -ce” — the worn-down *ten*

Before you move on

Count eleven to fifteen. (*Once, doce, trece, catorce, quince.*) What are these five, structurally? (**Fused Latin compounds** — number plus *-decim*, “ten.”) Which piece of each word is the old “ten”? (The **-ce** ending — *diez* worn down.) Next: the numbers where the seam is still wide open.

31.2 dieciséis — diecinueve: where the seam re-opens

You just learned five numbers whose insides had been ground smooth. Now say **fifteen** and then **sixteen** — *quince, dieciséis* — and hear the language change gear. From here you are not memorising words; you are following a rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	literally
dieciséis	<i>diez y seis</i> , “ten and six”
diecisiete	<i>diez y siete</i> , “ten and seven”
dieciocho	<i>diez y ocho</i> , “ten and eight”
diecinueve	<i>diez y nueve</i> , “ten and nine”

No fusion. You can hear **diez** plainly at the front of every one, and the number you already know sitting right behind it.

Grammar Lens: a formula, not a list

This is the structural difference that makes 15/16 a real boundary in Spanish rather than a convenient place to pause:

	11-15	16-19
how you get the word	remember it	build it
the “ten” inside	worn to <i>-ce</i>	still spelled <i>dieci-</i>
can you hear the parts?	no	yes
So <i>once</i> through <i>quince</i> are vocabulary , and <i>dieciséis</i> through <i>diecinueve</i> are grammar : one template, <i>dieci-</i> + <i>digit</i> , filled four times. Learn the template once and all four are already yours.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve”
- the seam out loud — “diez y seis” then “dieciséis”
- the boundary — “quince” (remembered), “dieciséis” (built)

Before you move on

Count sixteen to nineteen. (*Dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve*.) Are these fused or transparent? (**Transparent** — plain “ten and X.”) Which of the two groups do you have to memorise, and which can you generate? (**Memorise 11-15**; **generate 16-19** from *dieci-* plus the digit.)

31.3 duodēvīgintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

Dieciocho and *diecinueve* look like the least interesting words in the chapter — just two more ten-and-X compounds. They are actually the most interesting, because of what Latin said instead.

What to know first

- dieciséis — diecinueve — the *dieci-* plus digit template.

Why it's said this way

You would expect *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* to carry on whatever Latin did for 18 and 19. Latin did something else entirely. Its everyday words for those two numbers were **subtractive** — counted *down* from twenty:

number	Latin	literally
18	duodēvigintī	“ two from twenty”
19	ūndēvigintī	“ one from twenty”

(You still meet this habit in English clock-talk: “ten **to** four.”)

Spanish did not inherit either word. It built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* fresh, on exactly the same simple template as 16 and 17 — quietly **regularising away** an irregularity that existed in its own parent language. Languages are usually described as wearing down and getting messier; here is a clean case of one tidying up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Latin’s way — “two from twenty” — then Spanish’s — “dieciocho”
- “dieciocho, diecinueve” — addition, not subtraction

Before you move on

How did Latin say 18 and 19? (**Subtractively** — *duodēvigintī*, “two from twenty,” and *ūndēvigintī*, “one from twenty.”) Did Spanish keep that? (**No** — it built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* on the regular ten-and-X template.) So which language is the irregular one here? (**Latin** — Spanish simplified.)

31.4 veinte — the number the teens were counting toward

Latin’s own 18 and 19 were counted *down from twenty*. So it is worth meeting twenty itself — the number the whole run has been aiming at.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

veinte (“twenty”) ← Latin **vīgintī**. It was worn down by ordinary sound change — the *g* softened away, the vowels shifted — but notice what did **not** happen to it: it was never **fused** out of two separate words the way *once* through *quince* were. *Vīgintī* was already a single word for a single round number, so there is no seam inside *veinte* to look for. Three different histories, then, in one short chapter:

words	what happened
<i>once</i> - <i>quince</i>	two words fused into one
<i>dieciséis</i> - <i>diecinueve</i>	two words built into one, seam visible
<i>veinte</i>	one word, simply worn

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince” — the five fused Latins
- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve” — built, not fused
- “veinte” — twenty, worn but never fused

Before you move on

Count eleven to twenty. Where is the boundary between remembering and building, and why is it there? (**After** *quince* — 11-15 are fused Latin compounds, 16-19 are *dieci-* plus a digit.) Did Spanish inherit Latin’s subtractive 18 and 19? (**No** — it regularised them.) Was *veinte* fused from two words? (**No** — Latin *vīgintī* was already one word; it was only worn down.)

Chapter 32

Dog and Cat

32.1 gato — the word that travelled with the animal

Some etymologies can be followed all the way home. This one runs from your mouth back to ancient Egypt, and every step of it is documented.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gato (“**cat**”) ← Latin **cattus**. But *cattus* was **not** Classical Latin’s word for cat. That was **fēlēs**, which survives today only in the scientific name *Felis catus* and in English **feline**.

Cattus entered Latin **later**, arriving with the animal itself as domestic cats spread along **Roman trade routes** from where they were domesticated — **Egypt**, around 2000 BCE. The word is most likely **Afro-Asiatic** in origin (compare Nubian **kadis**, “cat”).

So word and creature travelled together, out of Africa into Europe, and the newcomer pushed *fēlēs* out almost everywhere: Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, Old Irish *cat*, Welsh *cath*, English *cat*. When a thing arrives from abroad, its name usually arrives with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el gato” — the cat
- the trail — “kadis, cattus, gato”

- the word it replaced — “felēs,” now only in “feline”

Before you move on

What was Classical Latin’s actual word for cat, and where does it survive? (**Fēlēs** — in *Felis catus* and English *feline*.) Where did *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, travelling with the domesticated cat out of **Egypt**.) Next: the other animal in this chapter, whose history nobody can trace at all.

32.2 perro — the word nobody can explain

Gato could be traced all the way to Egypt. **Perro** is the opposite kind of word, and it is worth knowing that such words exist: completely ordinary, used a thousand times a day, and **nobody knows where it came from**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perro (“dog”). Roll the *rr*: *PEH-rrro*.

The word Spanish **should** have inherited is **canis** — the same root as English **canine**, French *chien*, Italian *cane*. And it did survive, as the now-archaic Spanish **can** (still readable in old poetry and in *canino*). But at some point *perro* pushed *can* almost entirely out of everyday use — and *perro* itself has no agreed origin.

Why it’s said this way

Three serious proposals, none confirmed:

proposal	the case for it	the problem
onomatopoeia — a growl, or a shepherd’s call “ <i>perr, perr</i> ”	matches how herding calls become names elsewhere	no early written evidence
pre-Roman Iberian substrate	the <i>-rrro</i> ending is a known marker of likely pre-Latin words in Spanish	the substrate languages are barely recorded
Persian <i>persus</i> , a hunting-dog breed	such breeds did spread in the late Empire	the sound match is loose

Notice what makes this a **good** open question rather than a shrug: each proposal predicts different evidence, and the evidence needed simply has not survived. *Perro* remains one of Spanish's genuinely unsolved puzzles, and a useful reminder that “we don't know” is a real answer in etymology, not a gap in your notes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el perro, el gato” — dog and cat
- “can” — the archaic word *perro* replaced, from Latin *canis*
- the contrast — “gato, traced to Egypt; perro, unsolved”

Before you move on

What archaic Spanish word did *perro* replace, and what is its Latin source? (**Can**, from **canis** — the root of English *canine*.) Does *perro* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — onomatopoeic, pre-Latin substrate and Persian proposals all remain unconfirmed.) And *gato*'s origin, by contrast? (**Traceable** — Latin *cattus*, probably Afro-Asiatic, travelling out of Egypt.)

Chapter 33

Green and Yellow

33.1 verde — the colour named after being alive

After *azul*'s long journey from Afghanistan, here is a colour that stayed exactly where it started. It is also the one that names a **process** rather than a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

verde (“**green**”) ← Latin **viridis** (worn down through *viridis*), which comes from the verb **virēre**, “**to be green, to flourish, to be vigorous.**”

So the adjective is built on a **verb of thriving**. Latin did not name the colour of leaves; it named what leaves are *doing*, and let the colour follow. The same root gives *vigour* its neighbours in English: **verdant**, **verdure**, and the green-tinged **verdigris** (“green of Greece”).

One careful non-connection: **verde is not a cousin of English *green*.** *Green* comes from a completely separate **Germanic** root, tied to *grow* and *grass* — which, funnily enough, is the same idea arrived at independently. Two families, two words, one metaphor: green is the colour of things that are growing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde” — green
- the root — “virēre, to flourish” → “verde”
- “verde” then English “verdant” — and *not* “green”

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **verde**, and what does it mean? (**Virēre**, “to be green, to flourish.”) Is *verde* related to English *green*? (**No** — *green* is Germanic, from the same family as *grow* and *grass*; the two languages reached the same metaphor separately.) Next: a colour that is not named after a colour at all.

33.2 amarillo — the colour that started as a taste

Verde was exactly what you would expect from Latin. This one is not. Latin had three perfectly good words for yellow, and Spanish took none of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amarillo (“**yellow**”) does **not** trace to *flāvus*, *gilvus* or *luteus* — Latin’s actual yellow words. It comes from Late Latin **amarellus**, “**a little bitter**,” a diminutive of **amarus**, “**bitter**.”

A colour named after a **taste**. The bridge is medicine: yellow was the colour of **bile** and of **jaundice** (which Spanish still calls *ictericia*, but which folk speech long tied to bitterness), and of a great many bitter-tasting plants. A word meaning “somewhat bitter” came to mean “the yellowish look of a bitter thing,” then simply “yellowish,” and by Spanish’s Golden Age it had dropped the taste entirely and kept only the colour.

You can still check the family in a living word: **amargo** (“bitter”) is *amarillo*’s cousin, straight from the same *amarus*. Say them together and the shared *amar-* is right there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde, amarillo” — green and yellow
- “amarillo, amargo” — hear the shared *amar-*
- the path — “a little bitter” → “yellowish” → “yellow”

Before you move on

Does **amarillo** come from a Latin word for yellow? (**No** — from *amarellus*, “a little bitter,” a diminutive of *amarus*.) What everyday Spanish word is its cousin? (**Amargo**, “bitter.”) And *verde*? (From **virēre**, “to flourish” — a colour named after being alive, as this one is named after a taste.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before the lessons — every lesson tells you the one or two sounds its own word needs, right where you need them. This page sits at the back so the whole system is *somewhere* you can find it: look things up as curiosity strikes.

The five pure vowels

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time — unlike English, which reuses each vowel letter for several sounds.

- **a** — as in *father*. Always.
- **e** — as in *bed*. Always.
- **i** — as the *ee* in *see* (not English *i*). The most common vowel slip for English speakers.
- **o** — as in *note*, short and clean, no *w*-glide.
- **u** — as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Consonants that differ from English

- **h** — always silent. *hola* is *OH-la*.
- **qu** — a hard *k*, with a **silent u**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*.
- **ll** — like English *y*: *llamo* is *YA-mo*.
- **ñ** — the *ny* of *canyon*: *español*.

- **rr** — a rolled *r*; single *r* between vowels is a light tap (*pero* vs. *perro*).
- **j** — a throat-*h*, like Scottish *loch*: *jueves*.
- **c** before *e/i* — soft (*s* in Latin America, *th* in much of Spain): *gracias*.
- **d** between vowels — softens toward *th* in *this*.
- **v** and **b** — essentially identical, a soft *b*.

Stress and written accents

- Ends in a vowel, *n*, or *s* → stress the second-to-last syllable (*ca-SA*).
- Ends in another consonant → stress the last syllable (*ha-BLAR*).
- A written accent (´) overrides both and marks the stress exactly (*ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*); it also separates look-alike words (*qué/que*, *tú/tu*).
- Questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark (¿, ¡) so the intonation is signalled up front.